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THE METAMORPHOSES ABRIDGED

Translated by Ian Johnston, Vancouver Island University, Nanaimo, British Columbia, Canada. This text is in the public domain.

TRANSLATOR'S NOTE

In these selections, the line numbers refer to this abridged English translation, and the numbering starts again with each new selection. Partial lines are counted together in the reckoning, so that two or three consecutive short lines are equivalent to one full line. The explanatory footnotes and the side headings have been added by the translator. Line references to Ovid's complete poem (in the footnotes) are to the English translation by Ian Johnston.

A word on pronunciation of names: the letters *-eus* and *-aus* at the end of a name are normally two syllables in this translation: (e.g., *Orpheus* is pronounced *Ór-phe-us*, *Pentheus* is pronounced *Pén-the-us*, *Menelaus* is pronounced *Me-ne-lá-us*, and so on); a dieresis over a vowel indicates that it is pronounced by itself (e.g., *Danaë* is pronounced *Dá-na-e*, *Nereïds* is pronounced *Né-re-ids*, *Caÿster* is pronounced *Ca-y-ster*, and so on); final vowels are pronounced by themselves (as in *Calliope*, *Penelope*, *Achaea*, and so on), although there are several exceptions, usually when the name has long been adopted into English (e.g., *Crete*, *Rome*, *Ganymede*, *Nile*).

One source of minor confusion is Ovid's habit of changing verb tenses frequently from present to past and back again, often in mid-sentence. While this stylistic habit is not uncommon in conversational English, it is rare in formal English. Different translators handle this feature in different ways. Some put all verbs into the past tense, while others follow Ovid's changes faithfully. Most recent translations (so far as I can tell) retain the movement back and forth between present and past tenses, but do so less frequently than Ovid does, so that there is more consistency within short passages of the English. This last-mentioned practice is the one I have followed in this translation.

Ovid's speeches are sometimes difficult to keep track of, because he will have a speaker telling us what someone else said, and that account may include more direct speech also containing direct speech. At one point, he has speeches within a speech within a speech within a speech. To avoid complex, awkward, and confusing punctuation, I have tried to stick to a simple use of quotation marks (double quotation marks for direct speech, and

single quotation marks for all speeches within speeches) and have indented the left margin appropriately to indicate how direct or indirect a particular speech is.

A SHORT INTRODUCTION

The *Metamorphoses* by Publius Ovidius Naso has, over the centuries, been one of the most accessible and influential works from our classical past. This extraordinary collection of Greek and Roman myths and folk tales has always been a popular favourite and has decisively shaped Western art and literature from the moment it was completed in AD 8.

Ovid's stories, about 250 in all, begin with the creation of the world and end with a tribute to Augustus Caesar, the poet's contemporary, moving from famous early myths to fabulous divine or semi-divine heroic characters and well-known figures from traditional tales, then to the great historical saga of Troy, the wanderings of Aeneas and Ulysses (Odysseus), up to the recent history of Rome. Most of the stories involve miraculous and dramatically arresting transformations, in which a living being is changed into something else or is physically altered in some way, often as a result of intense suffering, or in which inanimate objects become living creatures.

The work has always been one of our principal sources of classical stories and hence an invaluable resource for later poets, painters, playwrights and storytellers, from countless medieval and Renaissance artists (including Shakespeare) to modern Broadway producers. But the popularity and influence of the poem rest on a great deal more than the outlines of the tales. For Ovid has a brilliant style, which transforms what might otherwise be a mere catalogue of stories into a seamless, forward-driving, and endlessly diverting totality.

Ovid is famous for his skill in creating transitions from one story to the next, often by having a character in one story move onto something new in the next, or by following someone's reaction to a story. He will frequently arrange stories in groups as part of an ongoing conversation or contest, or a series of stories within a story. As a result, the poem never flags or develops a stop-start rhythm but is always urging the reader or listener forward in one continuous narrative.

Ovid also likes to anchor his stories in the passionate emotions of the gods or of human individuals, so that the actions arise out of familiar and powerful feelings. The poem is justly famous for its set speeches, especially those of a young girl in love for the first time and caught up in passions which she knows she should resist but cannot, invariably with disastrous results. The psychological complexities many of the characters reveal in their self-examinations are fascinating. The formal speeches, too, like the long speech of Pythagoras or Medea's famous incantation or Hecuba's lament, bring these characters to life and have helped to define them for hundreds of years. This intensely dramatic quality

allows us to feel the stories much more immediately, so that we can make up our own minds, rather than having to listen to the judgment of the narrator. The speeches also bring out evocatively the harsh cruelty of many of the transformations, which are usually the final stage of intense suffering.

Ovid is famous, too, for his visual imagination, which ranges from cosily erotic and often humorous details, to graphic depictions of natural disasters, like storms at sea, catastrophic floods or plagues, to an almost grotesque treatment of battle wounds and mutilations. Given the imaginative quality of these images, it is no accident that the poem has had such a major influence on the history of Western art.

But the most famous, complex, and contested aspect of Ovid's poem is the narrator's attitude to his own stories. The speaker (who clearly identifies himself as the poet) repeatedly calls attention to the absurdity of the fictions he is creating and mocks the credulity of people who believe them. In many places Ovid pushes the descriptive details to such an extreme that one gets a sense he may be ridiculing his own stories and also earlier works which have dealt with similar events, simultaneously paying a tribute to a famous predecessor and gently satirizing him. It is as if he is inviting us to enjoy the poem but not to take it all that seriously.

Now, this is a risky business. After all, if the narrator is constantly threatening to pull the carpet out from under his own fiction, there is a real danger that the reader might simply lose interest or get confused. But Ovid negotiates this difficulty with consummate skill: he delights us with his stories and, at the same time, constantly mocks the notion, directly and indirectly, that they offer a significant insight into anything. The technique has the effect of driving something of a wedge between the style and the content and invites us to admire the amazing skill with which the poet can create such a remarkable work, so much so that, in a very real sense, the poet's skill, his extraordinary verbal 'wit', is one of the central attractions of the poem, constantly on display.

Unlike the works of the great epic poets he is drawing on, Ovid's poem does not invite us to treat the stories, individually or collectively, as presenting anything we might consider a vision of life. They matter as stories, for they provide him with an opportunity to display his poetical skill, but they do not put pressure on us to think about anything beyond this literary concern. That, indeed, may be one key to his popularity, for Ovid's attitude to his myths neutralizes any threat they might pose to a rival system of belief. Some of those who demand that a poet should strive for a high moral seriousness have deplored this aspect of Ovid's style, citing his inappropriately sly tone or the pleasure he takes in rhetorical excess. Others, more sensitive to the delights of poetry, have always considered Ovid a poet's poet, someone we read in order to surrender ourselves to the sheer pleasures of delightful fiction for its own sake. That, as Ovid seems to have sensed, is the key to his enduring popularity: in a world of constant change, his closing lines proclaim, emperors may come and go, but his brilliant work will always remain.

Finally, a short note on the selections (which are presented in the order in which they occur in Ovid's complete poem). I have concentrated on including passages that, first, tell a good story more or less on their own, without a potentially irritating thicket of explanatory footnotes (of the sort that would be required for the debate between Ajax and Ulysses or the wanderings of Aeneas, for instance), and, second, that are excellent examples of Ovid's poetic style at its finest. I also kept in mind the usefulness of a story for the reader's understanding of important later literary references.

Given these priorities, many selections virtually picked themselves (e.g., the Transformation of Chaos, Apollo and Daphne, Pygmalion, Phaëton, Icarus, Pyramus and Thisbe, and so on). I also considered it important to offer at least one longer section incorporating several stories (the Songs of Orpheus) in order to offer a lengthy example of Ovid's skill at creating stories in combination and transitioning seamlessly from one to another). I chose at least one tale that is not at all well known (Cinyras and Myrrha) because it is part of that sequence and because it is such a splendid example of Ovid's style, especially the attitude of the narrator to his own fiction and the treatment of a young girl wrestling with powerful sexual feelings).

There are, of course (and regrettably), many well-known stories I have not included. In some cases I have done so because the passage is too long or too repetitive (e.g., the battle of the Lapiths and Centaurs) or because the style lacks much of the "wit" that Ovid is most celebrated for (e.g., the accounts of the achievements of Aeneas or Romulus or Julius Caesar) or because the passage requires extensive footnoting to provide necessary background information (e.g., the debate between Ajax and Ulysses). Others I would have happily included if I had not faced limitations on the length of the book. I offer my sincere apologies to any readers whose particular favourite has not been included.

The selections are all taken from my translation of the complete *Metamorphoses* (combined, they represent about one third of the total poem). In many cases, the selections have been edited to make them somewhat shorter than in the original. Should these passages whet the appetite of some readers for more, they are welcome to help themselves to the online text of that complete translation.

My spirit drives me now to sing about
the forms of things changed into new bodies.
Since you gods caused these transformations, too,
inspire what I am going to write about,
and bring forth an uninterrupted song,
from the primal origins of the world
down to this present age.

Before the sea,
land, and heavens, which cover everything,
the entire world of nature looked the same.
They called that Chaos, a crude, confused mass,
nothing but lifeless stuff and scattered seeds
of matter not yet properly combined,
all piled up in the same place together.
There was no Titan yet providing light
to the world, Phoebe did not grow larger
and renew her crescent horns, nor did Earth
remain hanging in the surrounding air,
balanced by her own weight. Amphitrite
had not yet pushed her arms through long margins
of the coastal shores, and where there was land
there was also sea and air, but the ground
was not solid, the water was not fit
for swimming, and the air lacked any light.²
No matter retained its own proper shape—
one thing would keep obstructing something else,
for in one body cold things fought with hot,
wet with dry, soft with hard, and heavy things
with those which had no weight.

This conflict	CHAOS IS TRANSFORMED
god and more favourable nature stopped.	
For he cut land off from sky, and water	30

²In Greek mythology, the Titans were the immediate divine descendants of the first two gods Gaia and Ouranos. Phoebe (from the Greek for *shining*) was one of the original Titans and became synonymous with the moon. The Titan who provided light from the sun was Hyperion or Hyperion's son. Amphitrite, wife of Neptune, god of the sea, here stands for the sea generally.

from land, and separated the bright heavens
from heavy air. Then, once he had drawn off
these elements and taken them away
from the confused mass, he set them apart,
fixing them in place in harmonious peace.
The fiery might of vaulted, weightless sky
pushed out, creating for itself a place
in the loftiest heights. Closest to it
in lightness and location is the air.
The Earth, denser than these two, attracted
the larger elements and was pressed down
by its own weight. Water flowing round it
took possession of the furthest regions
and enclosed the solid sphere completely.

40

After the god—whichever god it was—
had divided Chaos and arranged it
in this way, forcefully dividing it
in sections, first of all he shaped the land
in the form of a large sphere, to make sure
it was the same on every side, and then
he commanded seas to be spread around
and swell with blustery winds, encircling
shorelands of the places they surrounded.
He added springs, huge pools, and lakes, and set
sloping banks to contain descending streams.
These differ in different locations—
some the earth itself absorbs, while others
reach the sea and, entering the expanse
of open water, beat against the coasts
instead of riverbanks. He also ordered
plains to be extended, valleys to sink,
leaves to cover trees, and stony mountains
to rise up. And just as heavens are split,
with two zones in the north, two in the south,
and a fifth zone hotter than each of these,
so the god was careful to distinguish
the enclosed matter with the same number
and on earth marked out as many climates.
Of these, the one in the centre is too hot
to live in, and two are covered in deep snow.
Between these areas he placed two more,
assigning them a temperate climate,
mixing heat and cold. Over these hangs air,

50

60

70

heavier than fire, to the same extent
that earth is heavier than water.¹

There he also ordered clouds to gather
and vapours, too, and thunder, which so stirs
the minds of human beings, as well as
winds producing lightning bolts and flashes.
The maker of the world did not permit
these things to take possession of the air
indiscriminately. It is, even now,
difficult to stop them ripping the world
to pieces, though each of them directs his blasts
at different places, so great is their strife.
Over these he placed bright, weightless aether,
without a trace of earth's impurities.

80

Scarcely had he separated all things
within specific limits in this way,
when the stars, which had remained long hidden,
buried in thick mist, began to blaze forth
through the entire sky. And to make sure
no place would lack its forms of living things,
the stars and the forms of gods occupy
the floor of heaven, the waters yielded
to let glittering fish live there, the land
took in wild beasts, the gusting air took birds.

90

What was still missing was an animal
more spiritual than these, more capable
of higher thinking, which would be able
to dominate the others. Man was born—
either that creator of things, the source
of a better world, made him from god's seed,
or the Earth, newly formed and divided
only recently from lofty aether
still held seeds related to the heavens,
which Prometheus, Iapetus' son, mixed
with river water and made an image

CREATION OF HUMAN BEINGS

100

PROMETHEUS

¹The heavens had been divided up by astronomers with five parallel circles: the equinox (in the centre), the two tropics (Cancer and Capricorn), and two polar circles. These verses indicate that the god marked out the climates on the earth's surface in a similar numerical pattern: the hot zone is between the tropics, the temperate zones are between the tropics and the polar circles, and the frigid zones are beyond the polar circles. The Latin uses the terms *right* and *left*; following many others, I have substituted *north* and *south*.

of the gods who rule all things.¹ Other creatures
keep their heads bent and gaze upon the ground, 110
but he gave man a face which could look up
and ordered him to gaze into the sky
and, standing erect, raise his countenance
towards the stars. Thus, what had been crude earth
and formless was transformed and then took on
the shapes of human life, unknown till then.

The Golden Age was born first. It fostered 110
faith and right all on its own, without law
and without revenge. Fear and punishment
did not exist. There were no threatening words 120
etched in brass and set up for men to read,
nor were a crowd of suppliants afraid
of the looks of men who judged them.² They lived
in safety, with no one there to punish.
No chopped-down pine tree had yet descended
down its mountain slope into the flowing waves,
so it might travel to a foreign world,
and mortals were familiar with no shores
except their own. There were no deep ditches
enclosing towns, no straight trumpets of war 130
or horns of curving brass, no swords or helmets.
People passed the time in gentle leisure
and security, with no need for troops.
The earth itself, also free and untouched
by hoes, not yet wounded by any ploughs,
produced all things spontaneously, and men,
content with food which grew without duress,
gathered arbutus fruits, mountain berries,
cornels, berries clinging to harsh brambles,
and fallen acorns from the spreading tree 140
of Jupiter. It was always springtime,
and gentle breezes of warm air caressed
flowers which did not grow from any seeds.
Soon unploughed Earth brought forth her crops, as well,
and the land, without being refreshed, grew white
with heavy ears of grain. Rivers of milk
would sometimes flow. Sometimes streams of nectar

¹Iapetus and his son Prometheus were Titans, members of the family of ruling gods before Jupiter overthrew his father, Saturn, and imprisoned him.

²The Romans inscribed their laws on brass and placed the tablets in a public place for people to see.

and yellow honey dripped from green oak trees.

Once Saturn was cast in gloomy Tartarus,
Jupiter ruled the world.¹ A Silver Age
then followed, less favourable than gold,
but still more valuable than yellow bronze.
Jupiter shortened the previous springtime
and split each year into different seasons,
with winter, summer, changeable autumn,
and short-lived spring. Then, for the first time,
air glowed white, scorched with blazing arid heat,
and ice hung down, congealed by wind. Then men
first moved to dwellings. Their homes were caverns,
dense thickets, and brushwood bound with bark.
Then they began to bury Ceres' seeds
in lengthy furrows, and young bullocks groaned,
straining at the yoke.

THE SILVER AGE

150

160

After these two ages,
a bronze race followed, with fiercer natures,
more inclined to wage horrific warfare,
but not to act without due piety.
Finally came the brutal Age of Iron.
During this era of debased desires,
every form of crime broke out, and honour,
truth, and faith ran off. In their place appeared
cheating, treachery, deceit, viciousness,
and criminal cravings for possessions.
Men set sails to catch the winds, though sailors
at this point did not understand them well,
and ships' keels, which for a long time had stood
high in the hills, scudded through unknown seas.
Careful surveyors marked long boundaries
on lands as common to men earlier
as air and sunlight. And the fertile soil
no longer was required to provide
just crops and food it was obliged to give,
for men went to the bowels of the earth
and dug **for ores**, which spurred them on to vice.
These the Earth had hidden and moved away

THE BRONZE AND IRON AGES

170

180

¹ The first family of gods, led by Saturn (in Greek Cronos), was overthrown by Jupiter (in Greek Zeus) and most of them were confined deep underground. Tartarus is the lowest point of the underworld.

to Stygian shades.¹ Now harmful iron emerged
 and gold, which brings more injuries than iron.
 Then war, which fights with both, comes on the scene,
 brandishing and rattling weapons in hands
 all stained with blood. Plunder becomes a way of life.
 Guests are not safe from those who welcome them, 190
 nor is the father from his son-in-law.
 Love of brothers is also rare. Men hope
 their wives will die, and wives all feel the same
 about their husbands. Dreadful step-mothers
 mix lethal poisons, and sons keep asking
 about their father's age before his time.
 Piety lies conquered, and virgin Astraea,
 the last celestial being, abandoned Earth
 now soaked in blood.²

And to make the lofty aether
 no more safe than Earth, they say that Giants 200
 tried to overrun the realms of heaven,
 by piling one mountain on another,
 up to the soaring stars. Then Jupiter,
 the all-powerful father of the gods,
 hurled down his lightning bolt, smashed Olympus,
 and split Ossa away from Pelion
 lying underneath.³ When those frightful Giants
 lay buried in the structure they had made,
 men claim that Earth, drenched with great quantities
 of her children's blood, grew damp, then gave life 210
 to the warm gore, and changed it to the form
 of human beings, so that some monuments
 of that ferocious race might still remain.
 But those progeny, scorning gods above,
 were violent—eager, before all else,
 to keep on killing. You could well conceive
 that they were born from blood.

When Saturn's son,

THE WAR OF THE GIANTS

200

210

JUPITER DESTROYS HUMANITY

¹ The Stygian shades are associated with the river Styx, one of the main rivers of the underworld. Thus, iron and gold are deep in the earth, close to Hades.

² Astraea was a goddess associated with innocence and justice. After she abandoned Earth, Jupiter placed her in the heavens as the constellation Virgo.

³ Olympus, Ossa, and Pelion are all mountains in northern Greece. The Giants, children of Earth, piled them on top of each other in order to attack heaven.

father of the gods, sees what is going on
from his loftiest citadel, he groans,
and senses an enormous rage, a feeling 220
befitting Jupiter. He calls a meeting.
Those summoned are not tempted to delay.
And so, when the gods above are seated
in the marble inner room, Jupiter,
sitting high above them all speaks these words,
stating his indignation:

“My worries
about the earthly realm were no greater
when each of those serpent-footed Giants
was ready to throw his one hundred arms
around the captured sky, for even though 230
the enemy was savage, still that war
hung on one group and had a single cause.
Now I must wipe out the race of mortals
over the entire world. I swear I’ll do it.
We have already tried all other options,
but a wound beyond all cure must be removed,
sliced off with a knife, so that healthy parts
do not become corrupted, too.
Wherever Earth lies open, the Furies
exercise their sway.¹ You might well believe 240
that men had sworn to act as criminals.
Let them all quickly pay the penalty
they richly merit! So stands my judgment.”

Some of the gods speak up, endorsing
what Jupiter has said, spurring him on
and encouraging his rage, while others
play their parts with silent affirmation.
But still, for all of them the destruction
of the human race is something grievous.
They ask about the future of the world. 250
How will Earth look, if she lacks human life?
Who will now place incense on the altars?
Is Jupiter prepared to let all things
by preyed upon by savage animals?
The king of the gods commands them not to ask
such questions and, to relieve their worries,

¹The Furies are the divine agents of blood revenge, especially within the family.

tells them he will take care of everything.
He promises a race of beings unlike
the previous ones and says their origin
will be a wonder.

And now Jupiter
is about to scatter his lightning bolts
on every country, but he is afraid
the sacred aether, by some accident,
may be set on fire from so many flames,
and distant polar regions may burn up.
Then, too, he remembers that Fate decrees
there will come a time when the sea and land,
as well as all the palaces of heaven,
will be attacked by flames and set alight,
and Earth's mass, produced with so much effort,
will be in danger. So he sets aside
those weapons forged by hands of Cyclopes
and approves a different punishment—
he will send rains down from the entire sky
and wipe out mortal men beneath the waves.¹
So he sends out South Wind on sodden wings,
his dreadful face veiled in pitch-black darkness,
his beard heavy with rain, water flowing
from his hoary locks, mists sitting on his forehead,
his flowing robes and feathers dripping dew.
When Jupiter stretches out his hand and strikes
the hanging clouds, heavy, crashing rainstorms
pour down from the heavens. Crops are flattened,
fond hopes of grieving farmers overthrown,
their long year's work now wasted and in vain.
And Jupiter's rage does not confine itself
to his own sky. For Neptune, his brother,
god of the azure sea, provides him help
with flooding which augments the pouring rain.
Neptune gave his orders, and the rivers
relax the mouths of all their fountain springs
and race down unobstructed to the sea.
Neptune himself with his trident strikes the land.
Earth trembles and with the tremor lays bare
the sources of her water. Streams spread out
and charge through open plains, sweeping away

260

THE DELUGE

270

280

290

¹The Cyclopes, one-eyed monsters, work in the divine forge to make Jupiter's thunderbolts.

all at once groves, planted fields, cattle herds,
men, and homes, along with sacred buildings
and their holy things. If any house remains
still standing and is able to resist 300
such a huge catastrophe, nonetheless,
waves higher than the house cover the roof,
and its towers, under pressure, collapse
beneath the surge.

And now the land and sea
are not distinct—all things have turned into
a boundless sea which has no ocean shore.
Some men sit on hill tops, others in boats,
pulling oars here and there, above the fields
which they just ploughed not long before. One man
now sails above his crops or over roofs 310
of sunken villas, another catches fish
from high up in an elm. Sometimes, by chance,
an anchor bites into green meadowland,
or a curved keel scrapes against a vineyard
submerged beneath the sea. And in those places
where slender she-goats have grazed on grasses,
misshapen sea calves let their bodies rest.
Nereïds are astonished at the groves,
cities, and homes lying beneath the waves.¹
Dolphins have taken over in the woods, 320
racing through lofty branches and bumping
into swaying oaks. Wolves swim among sheep.
Waves carry tawny lions and tigers.
The forceful, mighty power of the boar
is no help at all, nor are the swift legs
of the stag, once they are swept into the sea.
The wandering bird, after a long search
for some place to land, its wings exhausted,
falls down in the sea. The unchecked movement
of the oceans has overwhelmed the hills, 330
new waters beat against the mountain tops.
The deluge carries off most living things.
Those whom it spares, because food is so scarce,
are overcome by gradual starvation.

¹ Nereïds, daughters of Nereus and Doris, were nymphs of the sea

The fertile territory of Phocis,
 while still land, separates Aonia
 from Oeta, but when that flood took place
 was still part of the sea, a wide expanse
 of water which had suddenly appeared.
 In that place there is a soaring mountain
 which has two peaks striving to reach the stars.
 Its summit rises high above the clouds.
 Deucalion lands here in his small boat,
 with the wife who shares his bed—for the sea
 now covers every other place. They revere
 Corycian nymphs and mountain deities
 and prophetic Themis, too, the goddess
 who at that time controlled the oracle.

340

No man was finer than Deucalion,
 no man loved justice more, and no woman
 had more reverence for gods than Pyrrha.
 When Jupiter observes the earth submerged
 in flowing water, with only one man left
 from many thousands not so long before
 and sees one woman from many thousands
 a short while earlier, both innocent,
 both worshippers of the gods, he scatters
 the clouds, and once North Wind has blown away
 the rain, he makes land open to the sky
 and heaven to the earth.

350

*And the sea's rage
 does not persist. The lord of the ocean
 sets down his three-pronged weapon, calms the seas,
 and summons dark-blue Triton standing there
 above the ocean depths, his shoulders covered
 by native shells, and orders him to blow
 his echoing horn and with that signal
 summon back the flooding waters and the sea.¹
 Triton raised his hollow shell, whose spirals
 grow as they curl up from the base—that horn,
 when filled with air in the middle of the waves,
 makes coastlines under east and western suns
 echo its voice—and thus, once the god's lips,
 dew dripping from his soaking beard, touched it,
 and, by blowing, sounded out the order*

360

370

¹ Triton, a minor sea deity, was the son of Neptune and Amphitrite. His famous horn was made from a conch shell.

to retreat, all the waters heard the call,
on land and in the sea. They listened to it,
and all of them pulled back. And so the sea
had a shore once more, full-flowing rivers
remained within their banks, floods subsided,
hills appeared, land rose up, and dry places
grew in size as the waters ebbed away.
After a long time, exposed tops of trees
revealed themselves, their foliage covered
in layers of mud. The world had been restored.

380

When Deucalion sees that earth is empty
and observes the solemn silence over
devastated lands, with tears in his eyes
he speaks to Pyrrha:

“O wife and sister,
the only woman alive, linked to me
by common race and family origin,
then by marriage, and by these dangers now,
we two are the total population
of the entire world, every place spied out
by the setting and rising sun. The sea
has taken all the others. Even now,
there is nothing secure about our lives,
nothing to give us sufficient confidence.
Those heavy clouds still terrify my mind.
O you for whom I have so much compassion,
how would you feel now, if you had been saved
from death without me? How could you endure
the fear all by yourself? Who would console
your grief? For if the sea had taken you,
dear wife, I would follow you, believe me,
and the sea would have me, too. How I wish
I could use my father’s skill to replace
those people and infuse a living soul
in moulded forms of earth. The human race
lives now in the two of us. Gods above
thought this appropriate, and we remain
the sole examples left of human beings.”

390

400

410

Deucalion said this, and they wept. They thought
it best to pray to the celestial god
and to seek help from sacred oracles.

Without delay they set off together
to the stream of Cephisus, whose waters
were not yet clear but by now were flowing
within their customary banks. And there,
once they have sprinkled their heads and garments
with libations, they approach the temples
of the sacred goddess, whose pediments
are stained with filthy moss and whose altars
stand without a fire. As they touch the steps
before the shrine, they both fall on the ground,
and kiss the cold stone, in fear and trembling.
Then they speak these words:

420

HUMAN LIFE IS RESTORED

“O Themis, if gods
may be overcome with righteous prayers
and change their minds and if their anger
may be averted, reveal to us the art
by which destruction of the human race
may be repaired and, most gentle goddess,
assist our drowned condition.”

430

The goddess
is moved and through the oracle speaks out:

“Leave the temple. Cover your head, and loosen
the garments gathered around you. Then throw
behind your backs the bones of your great parent.”

For a long time they are both astonished.
Pyrrha’s voice is the first to break the silence,
refusing to act on what the goddess said.
Her mouth trembling, Pyrrha asks the goddess
to grant her pardon, for she is afraid
to offend her mother’s shade by throwing
her bones away. Meanwhile, they both review
the obscure dark riddle in the language
of the oracle they have been given,
examining the words between themselves.
And then the son of Prometheus consoles
Epimetheus’s daughter with these words
to reassure her:

440

“Either we have here
some subtle falsehood, or, since oracles

450

respect the gods and do not recommend
impious acts, our great mother is the Earth
and, I assume, what people call her bones
are those rocks in the body of the earth.
These stones are what we have been commanded
to throw behind our backs.”

Although the way
Deucalion has interpreted the words
encourages the Titan’s daughter, their hopes
are plagued by fears—that’s how much both of them
have doubts about the heavenly command. 460
But then what harm will there be in trying?
They go down, cover their heads, unfasten
their tunics, and, as they have been ordered,
throw stones behind where they are standing.
The stones—and who would ever think this true,
if old traditions did not confirm it?—
began to lose rigidity and hardness.
Gradually they softened, and then, once soft,
they took on a new shape. They grew larger
and before long acquired a gentler nature. 470
One could make out a certain human form,
but indistinctly, like the beginnings
of marble carvings not yet completed,
crude statues. But still, those pieces of them
which were earthy and damp from any moisture
were changed into essential body parts.
What was solid and inflexible changed
to bones, and what just a few moments before
had been veins remained, keeping the same name.
Soon, with the help of gods above, the stones 480
which the man’s hand had thrown took on the form
of men, and the stones the woman had cast
changed into women. That’s why human beings
are a tough race—we know about hard work
and provide the proof of those origins
from which we first arose.

The earth brought forth
the other animals spontaneously
in various forms. After the moisture
which had been there earlier had grown warm
from the sun’s fire and wet swamps and marshes 490

NEW CREATURES ARE BORN

had swelled up from the heat, the fertile seeds
of matter, nourished in quickening soil,
as in their mother's womb, increased in size
and, over time, took on a certain shape.
When the Nile with its seven river mouths
leaves the sodden fields and sends its waters
down their old channels and the brand new mud
grows hot from the aetherial sun, farmers,
as they turn the soil, find many animals.
Of these creatures, some are just beginning, 500
at the moment of being born. Men see
some which are incomplete and lacking limbs.
Often in the same body one section
is alive, while another is crude earth.
And so it's true that when heat and moisture
reach a certain temperature, they give birth,
and from these two things all beings spring up.
Fire may be the enemy of water,
and yet moist heat produces everything—
this discordant concord is appropriate
for conceiving living things. And therefore,
when earth, still muddy from the recent flood,
grew warm again from penetrating heat
of the aetherial sun, she then brought forth
countless forms of life, in part restoring
ancient species and in part creating
new monstrosities.

APOLLO AND DAPHNE

Apollo's first love
was Daphne, the daughter of Peneus.
It was not blind chance which made him love her,
but Cupid's savage rage. The Delian god,
proud of his recent conquest of the snake,
saw Cupid flexing his bow, pulling back
the string, and said to him:

CUPID AND APOLLO

“Impudent boy,
why play with weapons which are made for men?
Carrying that bow suits shoulders like my own,
since I can shoot wild beasts and never miss
and wound my enemy. So stay content

kindling any kind of love you fancy
with that torch of yours, but do not pre-empt
those praises due to me.”

The son of Venus
then replied to him:

“O Phoebus, your bow
may strike all things, but mine can strike at you.¹
Just as all animals are less than gods,
so, to the very same extent, your fame
is less than mine.”

Cupid spoke. Keen to act,
he struck the air with beating wings and stood
on the shady peak of Mount Parnassus.
He pulled out two arrows from his quiver,
each with a different force. One of them
makes love run off, the other brings it on.
The arrow which arouses love is gold,
with a sharp, glittering head, while the arrow
which inhibits love is blunt and has lead
below the shaft. With this second arrow
the god hit the daughter of Peneus,
but with the first he struck Apollo's bones,
piercing right through them, into the marrow.
He is immediately in love, but she
runs away from the very name of love,
delighting in deep places in the woods
and skins of the wild beasts she chases down,
emulating virgin Phoebe. A ribbon
holds her tousled hair in place. Many men
court her, but she dislikes all suitors.
And so, rejecting men, knowing nothing
of them, she roams the pathless forest glades,
without a care for Hymen, love, or marriage.²
But your beauty, Daphne, is an obstacle
to what you so desire. The way you look
makes sure your prayers will not be answered.
For Phoebus glimpses Daphne and falls in love.
He wants to marry her, and what he seeks

APOLLO AND DAPHNE

¹Phoebus is another name for Apollo.

²Hymen is the god of marriage.

he hopes to get. But his own oracles
deceive him. Just as light straw catches fire
once grain is harvested, and hedges blaze
from torches which some traveller by chance
has brought too near or else left there at dawn,
that's how Phoebus is changed then into flames.
That's how his whole chest burns, and by hoping,
he feeds a love that is in vain. He sees
the tangled hair hanging around her neck
and says:

“What would that hair of hers look like,
if only it were beautifully arranged.”

He observes her eyes, like bright fiery stars,
gazes at her lips—but the sight of them
is not enough—and praises fingers, hands,
her arms, and shoulders (more than half exposed!),
imagining those parts which lie concealed
are even lovelier. She runs away,
swifter than a soft breeze, and does not stop
when he calls her, crying these words:

“O nymph,
daughter of Peneus, stay! I beg you.
I do not chase you as an enemy.
Nymph, stop! This is the way a lamb runs off,
fleeing a wolf, or a deer a lion,
or a dove on quivering wings takes flight
to escape an eagle—each one of them
racing from its enemy. But the reason
I run after you is love. Alas for me!
I feel so wretched—you might fall headfirst,
or brambles scratch your legs (which don't deserve
the slightest injury)—and I might be
the one who brings you pain. You rush ahead
through rugged places. Set a slower pace,
I beg you, and restrain your flight. I, too,
will follow you more slowly. At least ask
who it is that finds you so delightful.
I am no shepherd or mountain dweller,
or some uncouth local custodian
of herds or flocks. You have no idea,
you thoughtless girl, you do not know the man

you're running from. That's why you scamper off.
The Delphic lands, Claros, and Tenedos,
the palace of Pataraea—all serve me.
Jupiter is my father, and through me
what has been and what is and what will be
are each made known. Through me songs and strings
resound in harmony. True, my arrows
always find their mark, but there's an arrow,
with truer aim than mine, which has transfixed
my uncommitted heart. The healing arts
are my invention, and throughout the world
I am called the Helper. The power of herbs
is under my control. But my love now,
alas, cannot be cured by herbs, and arts
which aid all people are no help at all
to their own master."

Peneus' daughter

with timid steps ran off, away from him,
as he was on the point of saying more.
Though his speech was not yet over, she left,
and he was by himself. And even then
she seemed so beautiful. The winds revealed
her body, as the opposing breezes
blowing against her clothing made it flutter,
and light gusts teased her freely flowing hair.
She looked even lovelier as she fled.
The youthful god can endure no longer
wasting his flattery. Love drives him on.
With increasing speed, he chases after her.
Just as a greyhound, once it spies a hare
in an open field, dashes for its prey,
and the hare, feet racing, runs for cover—
one looking now as if he is about
to clutch her and already full of hope
he has her in his grip—his outstretched face
brushing against her heels—while she, not sure
whether she has been caught, evades his jaws,
and runs away, his mouth still touching her,
that's how the god and virgin race away,
he driven on by hope and she by fear.
But the one who follows, who has the help
of Cupid's wings, is faster. He gives her
no rest and hangs above her fleeing back,

panting on the hair across her shoulders.
She grows pale as her strength fails, exhausted
by the strain of running away so fast.
Gazing at the waters of Peneus,
she cries out:

DAPHNE IS TRANSFORMED

“Father, help me! If you streams
have heavenly power, change me! Destroy
my beauty which has brought too much delight!”

Scarcely has she made this plea, when she feels
a heavy numbness move across her limbs,
her soft breasts are enclosed by slender bark,
her hair is changed to leaves, her arms to branches,
her feet, so swift a moment before, stick fast
in sluggish roots, a covering of foliage
spreads across her face. All that remains of her
is her shining beauty.

Phoebus loved her
in this form, as well. He set his right hand
on her trunk, and felt her heart still trembling
under the new bark and with his own arms
hugged the branches, as if they were her limbs.
He kissed the wood, but it shrank from his kiss.
The god spoke:

“Since you cannot be my wife,
you shall surely be my tree. O laurel,
I shall forever have you in my hair,
on my lyre and quiver. You will be there
with Roman chieftains when joyful voices
sing out their triumphs and long processions
march up within sight of the Capitol.
**And you, as the most faithful guardian
of Augustus’ gates, will stand on his door,
and protect the oak leaves in the centre.**
And just as my untrimmed hair keeps my head
always young, so you must always wear
eternal honours in your leaves.”

Apollo finished.
The laurel branches, newly made, nodded

in agreement, and the top appeared to move,
as if it were a head.

PHAËTON

Phaëton, the young son of Clymene, wants to know if his father is truly Apollo, god of the sun (also called Phoebus Apollo or Phoebus). His mother tells him to visit his father's palace to ask him. So Phaëton sets out to talk to his father.

The palace of the Sun, high in the sky,
has soaring pillars, bright with gleaming gold
and fiery bronze, the highest pinnacles
are of white ivory, and double doors
give off a silver light. The artistry
is even finer than the materials,
for on it Mulciber has carved the seas
encircling lands lying in the centre,
the globe of Earth, and heaven suspended
above that globe.¹ The waves hold sea-green gods—
echoing Triton, shifty Proteus,
Aegaeon with arms pressing the huge backs
of whales, along with Doris and her daughters
(some seem to be swimming, others sitting
on the shore, drying their green hair, and some
being carried on a fish—in appearance
all look different and yet somehow the same,
as sisters ought to). The Earth has cities,
human beings, woods, wild beasts, rivers, nymphs,
and other rural deities. Above these
is placed the image of a brilliant sky,
six constellations on the right-hand doors
and the same number on the left-hand side.

THE PALACE OF THE SUN

After Phaëton, Clymene's son, came
up the steep path and went inside the home
of the father he was not sure about,
he instantly set out to make his way
into his father's presence, but then stopped
some distance off. He could not continue
moving any closer to that brilliant light.

PHAËTON AND APOLLO

¹Mulciber is another name for Vulcan, god of the forge, metalwork, and crafts (the Roman equivalent of the Greek god Hephaestus).

Wrapped in purple robes, Phoebus was sitting
on a throne sparkling with bright emeralds.
To his right and left stood Day, Month, and Year,
Ages and Hours, spaced equally apart,
with the new Spring encircled by a crown
of flowers. And naked Summer stood there,
carrying garlands of wheat, Autumn, too,
stained with trodden grapes, and icy Winter
with untidy snow-white hair. Then the Sun,
placed in the middle of them all, with eyes
which perceive all things, noticed the young man
trembling at the strangeness of the palace
and said:

“What has led you to travel here?
What are you seeking in my citadel,
Phaëton, child no parent should disown?”

Phaëton said:

“O universal light
of the enormous world, Phoebus, father—
if I use that name with your permission
and if Clymene is not concealing
some crime under a deceitful picture,
give me a token, father, so that men
will believe I am a true child of yours.
Erase the doubts in my own mind.”

He spoke.

His father set aside the beams gleaming
all around his head and told Phaëton
to come closer. Then he embraced the lad
and said:

“You are a worthy son of mine—
that cannot be denied—and Clymene
has stated your true origin. Now ask
for any gift you like which will relieve
the doubts you feel, so I may offer it
and you receive it. Let Stygian pools,
which my eyes have not yet seen and which gods

swear by, be present here as witnesses
to what I promise.”¹

He had scarcely finished,
when Phaëton asked for his father’s chariot,
the right to guide his wing-footed horses
for one day. Phoebus regretted the oath
he had just sworn. He shook his splendid head
two or three times and said:

“Those words of yours
have made my words reckless. I wish I could
take back what I have promised! I confess
this is the one thing, son, I would refuse.
Still, I can try to talk you out of it.
What you’ve requested is not safe, Phaëton.
The gift you want is just not suitable
for your strength or youth. Your fate is mortal,
but what you wish is not for mortal men.
In your ignorance, you are aspiring
for more than what is lawful to be done,
even with gods above. Each deity
is allowed to follow his own pleasure,
but no one, except myself, is able
to stand upon the fire-bearing axle.
Even the one who governs vast Olympus,
whose terrible right hand hurls thunderbolts,
does not drive this chariot. And what is there
more powerful than Jupiter? The track
is steep at the beginning—fresh horses
in the morning can hardly make the climb.
The highest part is in the middle of the sky,
where looking down upon the sea and land
is often frightening, even for me,
and giddy terror make my heart tremble.
The final section of the path slopes down.
It requires a steady hand. Moreover,
Tethys herself, whose waters down below
receive me, has a constant fear I’ll fall
too quickly. Then, too, the sky rushes past
in a never-ending whirl, dragging stars
high up, spinning them in rapid circles.

¹The Stygian pools are the waters of the river Styx in the Underworld.

I drive in the opposite direction.
Its force, which overpowers all things,
does not overpower me, as I move
against its rapid orbit. But suppose
you get the chariot. How would you manage?
Will you be able to make way against
the whirling heavens, so their swift motion
does not carry you away? Perhaps your mind
imagines there are groves up there, cities,
homes, and temples richly endowed with gifts.
The road passes through dangers and visions
of wild beasts. Even if you keep on course
and are not drawn astray, still you must move
through the opposing horns of that bull Taurus,
the bow of Haemonian Sagittarius,
the maw of the fierce Lion, on one side
the savage claws of Scorpio bending
in a sweeping arc and, on the other,
the curved claws of the Crab. And those horses—
you will not find them easy to control,
those spirited beasts, whose mouths and nostrils
snort out the fires blazing in their chests.
They have trouble following my commands
when their fierce hearts are hot. Their necks fight back
against the reins. My son, you must take care
I don't become the giver of a gift
which kills you. While conditions still permit,
change what you want. Of course, you still desire
sure evidence which will help you to believe
you are born of my own blood. But I provide
firm proof by fearing for you, and I show
I am your father by a father's worries.
Look at my face! I wish you could insert
those eyes of yours into my heart and sense
my fatherly anxiety in there!
Finally, look around at whatever
the rich world contains and ask for something
great and good out of heaven, earth, and sea—
there are so many! I will not refuse.
This is the only thing I'm asking you
not to take—and, in truth, it should be called
a punishment rather than an honour.
Phaëton, you're asking for a penalty
and not a gift. Why, in your ignorance,

my boy, do you put arms around my neck
to win me over? Do not have any doubt—
I shall give whatever you have chosen,
for I swore by the waters of the Styx.
But you must make a wiser choice.”

Phoebus

ends his words of warning, but Phaëton
rejects his father’s words and, all aflame
with desire to guide the chariot, holds out
for what he’s asked for. And so his father,
having delayed as long as possible,
leads the young man to the soaring chariot,
a gift from Vulcan. The axle is gold,
as is the pole and the curved outer rims
running around the wheels. The rows of spokes
are made of silver, while along the yoke
chrysolites and gems, set in a pattern,
cast their dazzling light back onto Phoebus.
While bold Phaeton is admiring these,
gazing at the artistry, lo and behold,
watchful Aurora from the shining east
opens up the purple doors to the hall
crammed full of roses. The stars all vanish,
their cohorts driven off by Lucifer,
the last to leave his station in the sky.¹
When the Titan sees him go, as the earth
and world are growing redder and the horns
on the crescent moon appear to vanish,
he orders the swift Hours to yoke the horses.
Those quick goddesses respond to his commands.
They lead the horses out from lofty stalls—
the beasts, filled with ambrosial nourishment,
are snorting fire!—and then attach to them
the jingling harnesses. Next, the father
rubs divine ointment on his young son’s face,
making it invulnerable to searing flames.
He sets his rays in his son’s hair, heaving
sighs from an anxious heart prophesying
disaster, and says:

¹Lucifer (“the bringer of light”) is the morning star (Venus), which heralds the arrival of the sunrise.

“My boy, if you can
at least listen to your father’s warnings,
spare the whip, and hold the reins more strongly.
These horses charge ahead all on their own.
What’s hard is holding them with their consent.
And do not be tempted by the pathway
directly through the five celestial zones.
There is a track carved out at an angle
in a wide curve contained inside three zones.
Avoid the Arctic and the southern poles,
and the Bear linked to the north. Make your trip
along this route. You will see certain tracks
left by my wheels. And so heaven and earth
get equal heat, do not guide the chariot
too low or drive it through the upper sky.
If you go too high, you’ll burn up heaven’s roof,
and if too low, the earth. The safest course
to take is through the middle. Do not let
the right wheel make you turn aside towards
the twisted Snake or the left one lead you
to the low down Altar.¹ Maintain your course
between the two. All that remains I leave
to Fortune, who I pray will help you out
and take better care of you than you do.
While I tell you this, damp Night has touched
the boundaries placed on the western shore.
We do not have the freedom to delay.
We have been summoned! Bright Aurora shines,
and the darkness has been driven away.
Your hands must seize the reins, or if your mind
has changed, take my advice, not my chariot,
while you still can, while you still have your feet
on solid ground, and while you are not yet
acting on your unfortunate desires
and, with no experience, standing there
inside the chariot. Let me provide the earth
with daylight, while you look on in safety.”

Phaëton, with his young body, takes his place
in the light chariot and waits there, happy
to have the reins now resting in his hands.
He thanks his reluctant father. Meanwhile,

PHAËTON STARTS HIS JOURNEY

¹ The Snake and the Altar are constellations.

the swift horses of the sun—Pyroeis,
Eoüs, Aethon, and the fourth one, Phlegon—
keep whinnying—they fill the air with flames
and strike barriers with their hooves. Tethys,
who does not know her grandson's destiny,
throws back the gates and offers those horses
the freedom of the boundless universe.
They race off on their journey, hooves speeding
through the air, slicing the opposing clouds.
Lifted on wings, they outstrip the eastern wind
rising from the same regions of the sky.
But for the horses of the Sun the weight
is much too light, for they longer pull
their customary load. Just as curved ships
without a proper ballast toss around,
when their lack of weight makes them unstable,
as they move through the sea, so that chariot,
without its usual freight, leaps through the air
and is tossed up high, like something empty.
As soon as the four-horse team observes this,
they charge ahead, leaving the beaten track,
not running the same path they used before.
Phaëton, alarmed, unsure how to use
the reins entrusted to him, does not know
where the path might be, and even if he did,
he would still lack the strength to guide the team.
Then, for the first time, the cold Triones
were warmed by the sun's rays and tried in vain
to dip down in the forbidden ocean.
The Serpent, closest to the frozen pole,
who earlier was sluggish with the cold
and not a threat to anyone, warmed up
and grew more fearful from the heat. They say
you, too, Boötes ran away confused,
though you were slow and held up by the Plough.
But when unfortunate Phaëton looked
from high in the aether down on the earth
lying far, far underneath him, he turned pale.
His knees shook with sudden fear, and his eyes,
in such a powerful light, were obscured
by darkness. And now he would have preferred
never to have touched his father's horses.
Now he is sorry he confirmed his birth
and managed to get what he requested.

Now he desires to be called Merops' son,
as he is carried like a ship driven
by North Wind's blasts, whose captain has let go
the useless rudder and turned things over
to praying and the gods. What can he do?
A large part of the sky lies behind him,
but even more is there before his eyes.
In his mind he surveys them both, sometimes
glancing ahead towards the west, which Fate
will ensure he does not reach, and sometimes
looking back towards the east. Stupefied,
not knowing what to do, he is unable
to let go the reins or keep gripping them.
He does not even know the horses' names.
He trembles to see astonishing things
and images of huge wild beasts scattered
in various places throughout the sky.
There is a place where Scorpio curves his claws
in two arcs and, with his tail and pincers
bending on either side, stretches his limbs
across the space of twin constellations.
When the boy sees this beast, moistened with sweat
from pitch black poison, threatening to attack
with his curved sting, cold terror numbs his mind,
and he lets go the reins. Once they drop down
and touch the horses' backs along the top,
the team then swerves off course and runs ahead
without restraint, through regions of the air
unknown to them. Wherever their instincts
drive them, they race forward, with no control,
and charge at stars fixed high in lofty space,
hurtling the chariot through trackless places.
At times, they head for the highest regions,
and then at times are carried headlong down,
on a path much closer to the earth. Moon
is astounded that her brother's horses
are racing on below her own. Scorched clouds
begin to smoke. In all the highest places,
the land goes up in flames, then splits apart
into yawning cracks, and with its moisture
drawn away, dries up. All the grass turns white,
trees and leaves catch fire, and parched harvest crops
supply the fuel for their own destruction.

PHAËTON LOSES CONTROL

EARTH BEGINS TO BURN

Then Phaëton sees all parts of the world
ablaze and cannot bear the intense heat.
His mouth inhales the scorching air, as if
from some deep furnace. He feels his chariot
get hot. He can no longer tolerate
the ash and sparks thrown up. On every side
he is surrounded by hot smoke. Darkness
swallows him up, and he has no idea
where he should go or where he is, carried
by the will of his swift horses. Men think
that at that time the Ethiopians
had their blood drawn to the body surface
and turned black, and Libya was transformed
to an arid desert, all its moisture
drawn off by the heat. Back then, too, the nymphs,
their hair dishevelled, wept for springs and lakes.

Everywhere the ground breaks up and sunlight
shines down through the fissures right to Tartarus,
alarming the ruler of the Underworld
and his consort, too. The sea gets smaller.
What has recently been water now becomes
a field of arid sand. Mountains covered
by deep seas stand out, raising the number
of the scattered Cyclades.¹ Fish swim down
to the lowest depths, and curving dolphins
do not dare to leap above the water
up into the air, as is their custom.
In the sea, seals are on their backs, lying
lifeless on the surface. And men report
even Nereus himself, with Doris
and her daughters, lay hidden in warm caves.
Three times Neptune, looking grim, attempted
to extend his arms up from the waters.
Three times he could not stand the scalding air.

But fecund Earth, surrounded by the sea,
between the ocean waters and the springs,
which were all shrinking, burying themselves
in the womb of their dark mother, lifted
her ravaged face, all scorched down to her neck,
set her hand against her forehead, making

EARTH APPEALS TO JUPITER

¹The Cyclades are scattered islands in the eastern Mediterranean.

all things shake with her powerful tremors,
sunk back a little and was lower down
than her usual level. In a broken voice,
she said these words:

“O ruler of the gods,
if this is what you want, if this treatment
is something I deserve, then why hold back
your lightning? Let the power of your flames
destroy me, let me perish in your fires,
and let the majesty of the author
of this disaster mitigate its pain.
It’s hard for me to open up my jaws
to speak these words.”

(And, true enough, the heat
made speaking difficult).

-

“Look at my hair—
it’s scorched—and all these ashes in my eyes,
over my whole face. Is this the reward,
the honour, you pay for my fertility
and service, because I endure the wounds
of the curved plough and harrow and am worked
the entire year, because I provide leaves
and tender nourishment for cattle herds,
grain crops for the human race, and incense
for you gods? Still, suppose I do deserve
to be destroyed, what have the waters done?
Why does your brother deserve such treatment?
Why are those waters which chance committed
to his care shrinking and moving further
from the sky.¹ But if you are not concerned
about me or your brother, have pity
on your own heaven. Take a look around.
Both of the poles are steaming. And if fire
destroys the poles, then your own house will fall.
Look! Atlas himself is in great distress!²
His shoulders can hardly hold up heaven—

¹ In Greek mythology, the three brothers Zeus (Jupiter), Poseidon (Neptune), and Hades (Pluto) drew lots to determine which of them should rule particular parts of the world. Neptune drew the lot for the sea, Pluto for the underworld, and Jupiter for the sky.

²The giant Atlas held up the heavens and kept them separate from Earth.

it's so white hot. If the seas, if the earth,
if the celestial palace is destroyed,
we are thrown into primordial chaos.
Snatch from the flames whatever still remains,
and help preserve the safety of the world."

Earth spoke. Then, unable any longer
to endure the heat or keep on talking,
she pulled her face back deep within herself,
into caves closer to the dead below.

But the all-powerful father, calling
gods above (and especially the god
who has loaned the chariot) to bear witness
how a dreadful fate will destroy all things,
if he does not help out, climbs way up high,
to the very heights of heaven, from where
he spreads the clouds across wide earth, stirs up
thunder, and hurls his pulsing lightning bolt.
But at that time he had no clouds to drag
across the land nor any rain to send
down from the heavens. He thunders and hefts
the lightning bolt by his right ear, hurls it
at the charioteer, and, in an instant,
drives him from the chariot and from life.
With his savage fire he puts out the fires.
The horses, in their confusion, all veer
in different directions, pull their necks
free of the yoke, and, with the harness torn,
run off. Reins lie in one spot, the axle,
torn off from the pole, lies in another,
spokes from the broken wheels are somewhere else,
and the remnants of the shattered chariot
are scattered far and wide. But Phaëton,
his golden hair consumed by fire, is thrown
and carried headlong on a long pathway
through the air, just as in a peaceful sky
a star sometimes seems to fall, even though
it has not really fallen. Far away
from his own land, in a distant region
of the world, Phaeton is taken in
by mighty Eridanus, who cleans off

JUPITER ENDS PHAËTON'S JOURNEY

his blackened face.¹ The body, still smouldering
from the three-forked flame, Hesperian naiads
set in a grave and mark the stone with verse:

*Here lies Phaëton, who wished to guide
his father's chariot. And though he died,
there was great daring in what he tried.*

ACTAEON AND DIANA²

[Actaeon was fond of roaming the woods with his companions hunting wild animals. The following tale is a story of what happens to him on one of his hunting expeditions.]

There was a valley men called Gargaphia,
thick with pine and sharp-pointed cypress trees,
sacred to Diana, who wears her tunic
tucked high up on her legs. Deep in this place,
there is a wooded cave, not formed by art,
for nature with her own ingenuity
has imitated art, by tracing out
a natural arch of native limestone rock
and lighter sandstone. A sparkling fountain pool
of limpid water murmurs on the right,
and grassy banks enclose its open streams.
Here the forest goddess, when exhausted
from her hunting, would bathe her virgin limbs
in the clear waters. Once she reached the place,
she would give one of her armed nymphs her spear
quiver, and unstrung bow. Another nymph
held in her arms the robe she'd taken off,
while two undid the sandals on her feet.
Then a Theban girl, Crocale, who was
more skillful than the rest, tied up the hair
tangled across her neck, into a knot,
though she herself kept her hair hanging down.
Nephele, Hyale, Rhanis, Psecas,
and Phiale fetched water in large jars
and poured it out.

GODDESS DIANA IN THE WOODS

¹Eridanus is a river god in northern Italy (the river is often identified as the Po).

² Actaeon is a young prince of Thebes (a grandson of the founder of the city). Diana is the virgin goddess of the hunt.

While the Titanian goddess
is bathing there in her usual stream,
lo and behold, Actaeon arrives there,
at that very spot. He has set aside
his hunting and is wandering around
the unknown wood, uncertain where he is.
The Fates have led him there. Once he enters
the cave watered by those springs, all the nymphs,
naked as they are, once they see a man,
beat their breasts and fill the entire forest
with their sudden cries, rushing to surround
and conceal Diana with their bodies.
But the goddess herself, who is taller,
stands there head and shoulders above them all.
Since she was being watched without her clothes,
Diana's face changed colour to the blush
one sees quite commonly when clouds are struck
by sunlight from an opposite direction
or by the purple dawn. And though a crowd
of her companions was standing round her,
she turned sideways and twisted her head back.
How she wished she had her arrows with her!
But she did have water. She scooped some up
and splashed it in Actaeon's face, sprinkling
his hair with her avenging drops, adding
words which prophesied his future ruin:

“Now you may say you have seen me naked,
if you still retain the power of speech!”

Without any further threats, she places
the horns of a full-grown stag upon his head
where she has sprinkled. She stretches out his neck,
alters his ears so the tops are pointed,
changes his hands to feet, his arms to legs,
and covers his body with dappled hide.
Then, added to that, she makes him timid.
The son of Autonoë runs away,
astonished, as he flees, he is so fast.
Still, when he gazes in the water and sees
his face and horns, he is about to say

“I feel so wretched.”

But no voice comes out!
He groans. That is his voice. Tears trickle down
a face that is not his. All that remains
from what he was earlier is his mind.
What is he to do? Should he go back home
to the royal palace? Or hide himself
here in the woods? Shame hinders him from one,
fear from the other.

While he is in doubt,
his hounds see him. The pack of hunting dogs
is driven by its eagerness for prey
over remote cliffs, rocks, and pinnacles,
where the going is rough, without a path.
Actaeon flees through places where often
he pursued before. Now, alas, he runs
from his own helpers! He longs to cry out:

ACTAEON'S DOGS

"I am Actaeon. Know your own master!"

But he has no words to express that wish.
The barking echoes in the upper sky.
Melanchaetes is the first to wound him
along the back, and then Theridamas.
Oresitrophus bites into his shoulder.
**These dogs had gone out later but had found
a quicker route by shortcuts through the hills.**
They keep their master pinned, as the whole pack
rushes in a mass and buries its teeth
in Actaeon's flesh. By this point no place
on his body remains without a wound.
He groans, making sounds which are not human,
but yet not ones a stag could make, and fills
the well-known hills with dismal cries. His knees
are bent, just like a begging suppliant,
and he moves his silent features here and there,
as he might move his arms.

His companions,
quite ignorant of who he is, urge on
the ferocious pack with their usual cries,
while their eyes are searching for Actaeon.
They keep calling eagerly,

“Actaeon!”

as if he were not there (he turns his head
when he hears the name). They criticize him
for not being present, for being too tired
to enjoy the spectacle of their prey.
He might well prefer he could be absent,
but he is there. And he might well desire
to see and yet not feel the savage acts
of his own dogs. They stand all around him,
sinking jaws inside his body, ripping
to pieces their own master, whom they see
as the deceiving image of a stag.
Men say quiver-bearing Diana’s rage
was not appeased until Actaeon’s life,
after countless wounds, finally was gone.

JUPITER, JUNO, AND TEIRESIAS
ECHO AND NARCISSUS¹

While these events are happening on earth,
they say that Jupiter, who was quite full
of nectar, shelved his serious concerns
and shared some slight, amusing anecdotes
at ease with Juno. Jupiter remarked:

JUPITER, JUNO, AND TEIRESIAS

“To tell the truth, the pleasure women get
from sex is greater than what men receive.”

Juno denied the claim. They both agreed
to ask wise Teiresias his opinion,
since he had known both male and female love.
Once in the green forest he had used his staff
to strike two massive copulating snakes,
and (amazingly!) he was then transformed
from man to woman. He spent seven years
like that, and in the eighth year came across
the selfsame sight once more. And so he said:

“If the power in the stroke which hits you
is so immense it can change the gender

¹This story begins at 3.484

of the person who delivers the blow
into its opposite, then I will now
strike at you once more.”

When he hit those snakes,
his previous form returned, and once again
he was a man. And so he is the one
they choose to resolve their playful quarrel,
and he confirms what Jupiter has said.
Juno, they say, was seriously displeased,
unjustly so, out of all proportion
to the dispute. So she condemned the eyes
of the one who had pronounced the judgment
to eternal darkness. But Jupiter,
the almighty Father, to mitigate
his loss of sight (since no god is allowed
to reverse the actions of another god),
gave Teiresias the power to see
into the future and with this honour eased
his punishment.

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Throughout Aonia
Teiresias’ fame was highly praised
in every city. When people asked him,
he provided accurate replies.¹
Dark Liriope was the first to test
and to confirm the truth of what he said.
The winding river Cephissus had once
embraced her, enclosed her in his waters,
and taken her by force. From her full womb
this loveliest of nymphs had given birth
to an infant one could fall in love with,
even at that age. She called him Narcissus.
When Teiresias was asked about him—
whether the child was destined to pass through
the distant season of mature old age—
the visionary prophet then replied:

TEIRESIAS’ PROPHECY

“Only if he never gazes at himself.”

For some time the prophet’s words seemed worthless.
But what in fact took place—the way the young lad died

¹Teiresias was a blind prophet in Thebes.

and the bizarre nature of his madness—
proved those words were true.

The son of Cephisus
was now sixteen—one might consider him
both boy and youth. Many young men and girls
desired him, but in his tender frame
there was such fearful pride that no young men
or girls affected him.

The nymph Echo,
with the resounding voice, who has not learned
to hold her tongue when someone speaks or else
to speak out first herself, saw Narcissus
driving panicked stags towards his hunting nets.
Back then Echo was not just a voice.
She still had a body. But nonetheless,
though she loved to talk, she could only speak
as she does now. If a person uttered
many words, she could repeat the last ones.
Juno had made her talk this way, because,
when she could have caught out those mountain nymphs
lying beside her husband Jupiter,
Echo would deliberately detain her
with a long chat, until the nymphs had fled.
After the goddess realized the trick,
she said:

ECHO AND JUNO

“That tongue of yours has swindled me.
I will give you less power over it,
the very briefest use of your own voice.”

And she made good her threat by what she did.
Echo just repeats the last words spoken,
merely duplicating what she has heard.
So when she sees Narcissus wandering
through solitary fields and burns with love,
she tracks him surreptitiously. The more
she follows him, the more she is on fire,
just as quick-burning sulphur smeared around
the tops of torches seizes any flames
which approach too close. O how many times
she longed to meet him with flirtatious words,
using soft entreaties! Nature stops her

ECHO AND NARCISSUS

and does not allow her to begin. But she
is ready for what Nature does permit.
She waits for sounds which her voice can repeat.
Now, it so happens that the boy, enticed
away from a group of faithful comrades,
shouts out:

“Is there anybody here?”

Echo answers:

“Here!”

He is astonished.
He casts his eye in all directions and,
in a loud voice, cries:

“Come over here!”

She calls back to the person calling her.
He looks around and, when no one comes out,
he shouts again:

“Why run away from me?”

He gets back all the words he has called out.
Narcissus stands there, misled by what seems
a voice which answers his, and calls again:

“Let’s meet here together.”

She could not reply
more willingly to any sound, and cried:

“Meet here together.”

To support her words,
she came out from the woods and ran to him,
to throw her arms around the neck she loved.
He ran away and, as he ran, complained:

“Take your hands off me! Stop these embraces!
I’ll die before you have your way with me!”

All she replied was:

“Have your way with me.”

Now spurned, she conceals herself in forests,
and, in her shame, covers her face with leaves.
From that time on, she lives in lonely caves.
But still her love is there and even grows
from the pain of her rejection. Worries
and lack of sleep waste her wretched body.
Poverty shrinks her skin, and all juices
in her body move out into the air.
Only her voice and bones are left. Her voice
still lives. The story goes her bones were changed
to shapes of stone. Since that time, she hides out
in the woods. No one has ever seen her
in the mountains, but she is heard by all.
It is the sound which still lives on in her.

ECHO IS TRANSFORMED

Narcissus scorned her, just as he had scorned
other nymphs born in the streams and mountains,
and just as he had previously scorned
whole companies of men. Then one of those
Narcissus had rejected raised his hands
up to the sky and prayed:

NEMESIS PUNISHES NARCISSUS

“Though he may love
another in this way, let him not have
what he desires from love.”

The prayer was just,
and goddess Nemesis agreed to it.

There was a clear stream, with limpid waters
like silver, as yet untouched by shepherds
or goats and cattle grazing mountain slopes,
undisturbed by any bird, savage beast,
or bough split off a tree. All around it
there was grass fed by adjacent waters
and trees which would not let the pool grow warm
from any sun. Here Narcissus, weary
from eager hunting and the heat, lay down,
attracted by the scenery of the place
and by the water springs. And while he tries

to slake his thirst, another thirst begins.
As he is drinking, he sees an image,
the reflection of his face, and falls in love,
desiring a thing which has no substance.
He thinks the shadow must possess a body.
Astonished by himself, he remains there,
motionless, wearing the same expression,
like a statue made of Parian marble.
Stretched out along the ground, he contemplates
the double constellation of his eyes,
his hair, which looks suitable for Bacchus
or worthy of Apollo, his beardless cheeks,
his ivory neck, his sensuous mouth,
and the blush mixed in with snowy whiteness,
admiring every feature which makes him
worth admiring. Without a sense of shame,
he desires himself. The one approving
is the person being approved, and while
he is pursuing, he is being pursued.
He kindles fire and burns at the same time.
How often he kisses the devious spring
without success! How often he reaches in
to clutch the neck he sees in the centre
of the water, and yet his arms cannot
embrace himself! What he is looking at
he does not recognize, but what he sees
sets him aflame, and the very error
which deceives his eyes excites them. Why then,
you foolish lad, do you keep trying to clutch
that fleeting image? What you are seeking
does not exist. And if you turn away,
you will lose the thing you love. What you see
is the shadow of a mirror image,
which has nothing of its own. It arrives
with you and stays with you and leaves with you,
if you can leave. No need for Ceres' food,
no need for rest can take him from the place.
Instead he lies on the thick grass and peers
at the misleading image, for his eyes
can never gaze enough. He lifts himself
a little, holds out his arms, and cries:

NARCISSUS IN LOVE

“You forest trees, has anyone ever
been more cruelly in love? You should know,

for you have offered useful hiding places
to many lovers. In all those ages
your life has passed, that huge expanse of time,
have you known anyone who pined away
like this? I see him, and he pleases me.
But still, what I see and what pleases me
I cannot find. My loving has been caught
in such a huge mistake! To make my grief
more painful still, we are not held apart
by the mighty sea or by some journey,
or by mountains, or walls with bolted gates.
The only thing which keeps us separate
is that tiny pool! He himself desires
to be embraced. Every time I lean down
with my lips to the clear water, he lifts
his upturned face to mine. And you would think
he could be touched. It's such a little thing
that blocks our love. Whoever you may be,
come here! O you extraordinary boy,
why play these tricks with me? When I seek you,
where do you go? You cannot be running
from my shape and youth, and I am someone
who has been loved by nymphs! You promise me,
with that loving face of yours, unknown hope.
When I hold out my arms to you, then you
are happy to hold out your own. When I smile,
you smile. Often I have seen you weeping
when I shed tears. And if I nod my head,
you return my gesture. From the motion
of your fair mouth I guess you send back words
which do not reach my ears. I am in you.
I have felt it. I am not being deceived
by my own image. I am burning up
with love for my own self. I rouse the flames
and suffer from them, too. What do I do?
Should I be the person asking or being asked?
But what is there to ask for? What I want
is with me. My riches have made me poor.
O how I wish I could divide myself
from my own body! What a novel wish
for someone who's in love, for I desire
to be divided from the one I love.
Now sorrow saps my strength. My time of life
will soon run out, and I will pass away

in the prime of youth. And for me my death
will not be a burden, since, by dying,
I put my pain to rest. I would prefer
the one I love to keep on living longer,
but now the two of us, both in one life,
will die together.”

Narcissus finished.
Not thinking clearly, he went back again
to the same image and splashed the waters
with his tears. Once he disturbed the surface,
the reflection was obscured. When he saw
the image disappearing, he cried out:

“Where are you going? Stay! Do not leave me,
you pitiless boy, the one who loves you!
Let me gaze upon the face I cannot touch,
the food I need to feed my wretched madness.”

In his grief, he ripped the upper border
of his clothing and beat his naked chest
with hands as white as marble. As he struck,
his chest turned rosy red, just like apples,
in which some parts are usually red
and some are white, or just as unripe grapes
in various bunches commonly possess
a purple colour. Once he saw his image
in the water, he could not endure it
a moment longer, but, as yellow wax
drips in a tiny flame, as morning frost
dissolves in the warm sun, so Narcissus,
wasted by love, gradually melts away,
consumed by hidden fire. And now his face
has no more colour red mixed in with white.
He lacks vitality and strength, those things
which, only recently, gave such delight
to the body Echo earlier had loved.
She was still angry and remembered him,
but when she saw Narcissus, she was sad.
Whenever the poor boy would cry:

“Alas!”

her echoing voice would then repeat:

“Alas!”

And when he struck his shoulders with his hands,
she sent him back the same sound as the blow.
His final words as he was looking in
those waters he habitually watched
were these:

“Alas, my beloved boy, in vain!”

The place gave every word back in reply.
He cried:

“Farewell.”

And Echo called:

“Farewell!”

He set his weary head down on green turf,
and death closed up those eyes which so admired
the beauty of their master. Even then,
after he had been received in houses
of the dead, he would keep gazing into
waters of the Styx. His naiad sisters
wept for Narcissus. They cut off their hair
and laid it out for him. The dryads, too,
lamented, and Echo returned their cries.
Now they were preparing the funeral pyre,
the torches they would brandish, and the bier.
But there was no body. Instead they found
a flower with a central yellow part
surrounded by white petals on all sides.

NARCISSUS IS TRANSFORMED

PYRAMUS AND THISBE¹

“In the place where they say Semiramis
surrounded her high city with brick walls,
Pyramus and Thisbe lived in houses
side by side—the finest looking young lad

¹The story is in quotation marks because in Ovid's text it is narrated by one of the daughters of Minyas.

and the choicest girl in the entire East.¹
As neighbours, they got to know each other
and took their first few steps together. In time,
love grew, and they would have been united,
swearing the marriage oath, but their parents
would not permit it. Still, the two of them
burned with love, minds equally committed,
a fiery blaze their parents could not quench.
No one knows about it. They speak with nods
and signs. The more they try to hide the fire,
the hotter it burns. Their two houses shared
a wall in common, which had been fractured,
leaving a narrow crack. This had happened
earlier when it was built, and no one,
in all the many years, had seen the fault.
But what does love not notice? You lovers
were the first to find it, and you made it
a pathway for your voices. Through that crack
the slightest murmurs of your tender words
would safely pass. When they stood beside it,
Thisbe on one side, Pyramus the other,
and each one of them, in turn, had seized on
breath from the other's mouth, they often said:

‘Envious wall, why be an obstacle
to lovers? Would it be so difficult
to let us completely join our bodies?
Or if that is too much, you might at least
open up so we can kiss each other.
We are not ungrateful, for we admit
it is thanks to you we have a passage
for words to reach our loving ears.’

They spoke
like this in vain, from both sides of the wall.
Night came. They said farewell, and each one gave
his own side kisses, which did not pass through
and reach the other side.

One morning later,
when Dawn had sent away the stars of night
and sunlight had dried out the frosty grass,

¹The city in question is Babylon.

they met at their accustomed place. First of all,
they complained about their many troubles,
talking there in quiet murmurs. But then,
they decided they would try outwitting
their guardians in the silence of the night,
go outside, and, once they had left the house,
they would also leave the built-up city.
So they would not lose their way wandering
across open fields, they agreed to meet
at the tomb of Ninus and hide themselves
in the shadows of a tree. In that place
stood a lofty mulberry loaded down
with white fruit, beside an ice-cold fountain.
They thought the plan a good one. When daylight,
which seems to leave so slowly, is cast down
in the waters and from those same waters
night emerges, Thisbe opens the door
and steals out through the darkness, deceiving
her own family. Her face veiled, she reaches
the tomb and sits down by the very tree
they talked about. Love makes her bold. But then,
lo and behold, a lioness comes there,
with foaming jaws smeared from a recent kill
of oxen, intending to slake her thirst
in the waters of the near-by fountain.
Babylonian Thisbe sees the creature
from a distance in the moonlight and runs,
with trembling steps, into a murky cave.
In her rush, the veil falls off behind her
and remains there. Once the fierce lioness
has drunk her fill, quenched her thirst, and moved
towards the trees, by chance she finds the veil
(without the girl) and rips the silky fabric
in her bloodstained jaws. Pyramus goes out
somewhat later and in the deep dust sees
clear footprints of the savage animal.
His whole face turns pale. When he also sees
the garment stained with blood, he cries:

‘One night
will see two lovers perish. Of the two
she was the one who most deserved to live
a lengthy life. My soul has done great harm.
I have been your death, you unhappy girl,

the one who told you to come out at night
to places full of danger and was not
the first to get here. O you fierce lions,
wherever you may live beneath this rock,
tear apart my body, and with sharp teeth
devour my wicked heart. But that's the way
a coward acts—to hope that death will come.'

He picks up Thisbe's veil, takes it with him
to the shade of that tree they talked about.
When he has shed his tears into the veil
he knows so well and kissed it, he cries out:

'Now soak yourself in my blood, too.'

Then, without a pause, he plunges the sword
he carries on his belt into his belly
and, as he is dying, pulls the blade out
from the seething wound. He is on the ground,
lying on his back, blood spraying way up high,
just as a pipe made of defective lead
will split and, through the hissing crack, water
shoots in thin streams far away, as its spurts
pulse through the air. On the mulberry tree
the fruits change colour from the sprinkling blood.
They now look black, and as blood soaks the roots,
it stains the hanging mulberries dark purple.

Lo, Thisbe, not yet free from fear, returns,
so she will not disappoint her lover.
Her eyes and heart search for the youth. She yearns
to tell him the great danger she escaped.
She knows the place and outline of the tree,
which she has seen before, but the colour
of the fruit makes her unsure. She wonders
if this is the tree. While still uncertain,
she catches sight of quivering limbs beating
on the bloodstained soil. She draws her foot back,
her face as pale as boxwood, and shudders
like the sea which ripples when slight breezes
brush across its surface. She hesitates,
then sees her love, and, with a cry of grief,
she strikes her innocent arms, tears her hair,
embraces the body of the man she loves,

and fills his wounds with tears, mixing their drops
with her lover's blood. She kisses his cold face
and cries:

‘O Pyramus, what accident
has taken you from me? O Pyramus,
answer! Your dearest Thisbe calls to you.
Please hear me, and raise your sagging head!’

At Thisbe's name, Pyramus raised his eyes,
already heavy with death, looked at her,
and closed them once again. She saw the veil,
recognized it was her own, then noticed
the ivory scabbard had no sword. She cried:

‘Your own hand and your love have finished you,
unhappy man. I, too, have a strong hand—
enough for this one thing. And I have love,
which will give me strength to endure the wounds.
I shall follow you in death, and people
will call me the most unfortunate cause
and companion of your fate. You, alas,
who could be torn from me by death alone,
will not be torn away in death. And yet,
you poor parents, mine and his, I ask you
with words from both of us, in your great grief,
do not forbid those whom true love has joined
in their last hour to be laid together
in a common tomb. And you, O tree,
whose branches now cover the sad body
of one of us and will soon cover two,
keep the symbols of our deaths, and always
yield dark fruit appropriate for mourning,
a symbol of the blood we two have shed.’

Thisbe finished. Then setting the sword point
beneath her breast, she fell upon the blade,
still steaming from the blood of Pyramus.

But her entreaty did affect the gods
and moved her parents. So when fully ripe,
the fruit is dark, and what remains of them
after the funeral pyre sits in one urn.”

PERSEUS WITH ATLAS AND ANDROMEDA¹

But Perseus was rushing through thin air
on whirring wings, bearing the famous prize
of a snake-haired monster he'd overcome,
soaring over Libyan sands, with blood
dripping down to earth from the Gorgon's head.
The ground soaked up the drops and gave them life
as various snakes (that is the reason
so many snakes infest this land). Later,
Perseus was carried off here and there,
pushed by warring winds, like a cloud of rain.
From high up in the heavens he gazed down
on distant lands. He flew around the globe.
Three times he saw the freezing Bears, three times
the pincers of the Crab, often driven
to the west, and often towards the east.
Now, as light failed, afraid to trust himself
to the dark night, he halted in the west,
intending to rest awhile in the realm
of Atlas, until Lucifer announced
Aurora's fire, and Aurora summoned
the chariot of day.

Now, this Atlas,
son of Iapetus, surpassed all men
in physical size and was the ruler
of the remotest regions of the world
and of the oceans whose waters receive
the panting horses of the Sun and take in
his weary chariot.² He has a thousand flocks
and as many herds, who roam the meadows.
There are no neighbours to disturb his land.
Leaves on his trees glitter with shining gold,

¹Perseus was the son of Jupiter and Danaë. The wings that enabled him to fly were on his sandals. He has just killed the Medusa, the monster whose gaze turns those who look at her to stone (Ovid does describe that event). The prize he is carrying is Medusa's head.

²²Atlas was a Titan, one of the family of ruling gods before Jupiter took control.

covering golden boughs and golden fruit.
Perseus said:

“My friend, if the glory
of high birth has some influence with you,
the founder of my clan is Jupiter.
If you are someone who applauds great deeds,
you will approve of mine. I’m asking you
for hospitality and rest.”

Atlas
recalled an ancient prophecy given
by Themis at Parnassus:

“The time will come,
Atlas, when your trees will be stripped of gold.
A son of Jupiter will be honoured
for acquiring the spoil.”

Afraid of this,
Atlas built strong walls around his orchard
and placed in there an enormous dragon
to protect the place. He kept all strangers
off his lands. So he said to Perseus:

“Leave here, in case the glory of those deeds
you lie about and Jupiter, as well,
are not there to help.”

To these threatening words
Atlas added violence, attempting
with his great hands to push Perseus away.
Perseus holds his ground, combining force
with reassuring words. But Perseus
is not as powerful (for who can match
the strength of Atlas?). So Perseus says:

“Very well, then, since for you my friendship
has no value, take this gift!”

He turns away
and with his left hand holds out the foul head
of Medusa, and Atlas is transformed
into a mountain as huge as he was.

His beard and hair turn into forest trees,
his hands and shoulders change to mountain crests.
What was his head before is now the peak.
His bones are turned to rock. All his features
start to grow much larger, and he becomes
something colossal (so you gods ordained),
and all the heavens with their countless stars
now rest on him.

Aeolus had confined
the winds to their prison caves on Aetna,
and Lucifer, the brightest of all stars,
who rouses men for work, had risen up
high in the heavens. Perseus put on
his wings again, tying them to his feet.
Then he took his weapon, a curving sword,
and with the movement of his sandals' wings
carved out a passage through the flowing air.
Passing countless nations in lands below
on every side, he came to Ethiopia,
observed the people there, and saw the fields
of Cepheus, where Jupiter Ammon
had unjustly ordered that Andromeda,
though innocent, should suffer punishment
for things her mother said. When Perseus,
grandson of Abas, saw the girl, whose arms
were chained to solid rock, he would have thought
she was a marble statue, but her hair
moved in the gentle breezes and warm tears
flowed from her eyes.¹ Before he realized it,
Perseus caught fire. Amazed and smitten
by the image of the girl he saw there,
he almost forgot to keep those wings of his
beating the air. He came down, stopped, and said:

“These are not the chains you should be wearing,
but rather those which link up those in love.

¹Jupiter was worshipped in Libya (under the name Jupiter Ammon), where there was a famous temple and oracle dedicated to him. Andromeda was the daughter of Cepheus, the ruler of the region. Her mother, Cassiope, had boasted about her own beauty, comparing it to the Nereïds (nymphs of the sea, daughters of Nereus). The Nereïds had asked Neptune for a sea monster to attack the Ethiopians, and the oracle had declared that, to avert disaster, Andromeda had to be sacrificed to the monster. So she was tied to a rock washed by the sea (where the monster could attack her)

Tell me your name and what your land is called—
I'd like to know—and why you are in chains.”

At first the girl said nothing, not daring,
as a virgin, to talk to a strange man.
Her hands would have concealed her modest face,
as well, if she had not been bound. She did
what she could do and let her eyes fill up
with flowing tears. He kept on asking her
repeatedly, and she, so as not to seem
to be confessing that she was at fault
by her unwillingness to say a word,
told him her name, her country, and how much
her mother had believed in her own beauty.

Before she has finished all the details,
the waves roar, and out of the boundless deep
a threatening monster bursts up, covering
a wide surface of the sea. The virgin screams.
Her father and her mother stand close by,
feeling wretched (the mother more justly so).
They bring no help with them, but cries of grief
to suit the moment. They both beat their breasts,
clinging to the body of the chained-up girl.
Then the stranger says:

“You can shed your tears
for a long time after this, but right now
there is not much time to help. My name
is Perseus, Jupiter’s son with Danaë.
Although she was imprisoned, Jupiter
made her pregnant with streams of fertile gold.
Yes, I am Perseus, who overcame
the snake-haired Gorgon and dared to travel
through gusting breezes on these beating wings.
So if I seek this young girl as my wife,
surely as a son-in-law I will rank
ahead of all the rest. And if the gods
will only show me favour, I will try
to add a further service to those things
I have accomplished. Here’s my proposal—
if my courage saves her, then she is mine.”

Her parents agree to his conditions
(for who would hesitate?). They plead with him
and promise even more. They offer him
their kingdom as a dowry.

Then, just as
the sharp prow of a swift ship driven on
by the sweating arms of its youthful crew
cuts through the waves, so the powerful chest
of that sea monster shoves the waves aside.
When its distance from the rock is as far
as a Balearic sling can send its shot
whirling through the air, Perseus suddenly
sets his feet against the earth, then rises up
high into the clouds. As his shadow falls
across the surface of the sea, the beast
sees it and, enraged, attacks the shadow.
Just as Jupiter's eagle, when it spies
a snake in an open field exposing
its dark back to Phoebus and seizes it
as it turns away, sinking sharp talons
in its scaly neck, in case it twists back
its savage fangs, so Perseus, descendant
of Inachus, swooping down rapidly
through the empty sky, suddenly makes for
the monster's back and, as it roars, buries
his sword in its right shoulder, all the way
to the curving hilt. The sea beast, now hurt
with a serious wound, sometimes lifts itself
high in the air or sinks beneath the waves,
and sometimes turns at bay, like a fierce boar
surrounded and driven mad by a pack
of yelping hounds. Using his speeding wings,
Perseus eludes the ravenous jaws
and, every time he sees an opening,
strikes with his curved blade—now along its back,
crusted with hollow shells, now at its ribs
along the flanks, now at the thinnest part
of the creature's tail, which tapers like a fish.
The monster's mouth spews out sea water mixed
with purple blood, drenching his sandal wings
and weighing them down. Perseus does not dare
to trust his soaking wings. He spies a rock
whose topmost point extends above the sea

when it is still but which is covered up
when the waters surge. Standing on that rock,
his left hand braced against the upper edge,
he strikes the monster's side repeatedly,
three or four times, plunging in his sword.

The shores and the high palaces of gods
resound with noisy shouting and applause.
Cassiope and Cepheus, her father,
are delighted. They greet their son-in-law,
acknowledging him as the one who helped
and saved their house. The girl, freed from her chains,
approaches, the cause of all his efforts
as well as the reward. Perseus cleans
his victorious hands in water drawn up
from the sea. Then he makes a bed of leaves
to soften the ground, so as not to harm
the snake head on the solid sand, spreads out
plants born beneath the sea, and sets down there
the head of Medusa, Phorcys' daughter.
The absorbent centres of that seaweed,
still living, soak up the Gorgon's power,
at, at its touch, grow hard. The stems and leaves
take on a new rigidity. Sea nymphs
try out this miracle on several plants,
and when they all grow hard in the same way,
the nymphs rejoice. They repeat the process
by scattering seeds from those rock-hard growths
into the sea. And corals, even now,
retain this property. They petrify
in contact with the air, and what lives on
below the water turns to stone above.

Perseus raises three earth-built altars
to three deities—the one on the left
to Mercury, the right hand one to you,
virgin warrior Minerva, and one
between the two to Jupiter. He offers
a cow in sacrifice to Minerva,
a calf to Mercury, wing-footed god,
and a bull to Jupiter, who rules the gods.
Perseus quickly claims Andromeda
as his reward for such a great exploit,
without a dowry. In front of both of them

Hymen and Love hold up the marriage torch,
fires are filled with huge amounts of incense,
garlands hang from rooftops, and everywhere
the melodies resound from lyres, pipes and song,
delightful symbols of a happy heart.
All the golden halls lie open, their doors
thrown back, and the Ethiopian leaders
move to a banquet beautifully prepared
and set before them.

When the banquet ends
and they have filled their hearts with wine, a gift
from munificent Bacchus, Perseus,
descendant of Lynceus, asks about
the culture and the people of the place,
their character and habits. One of those
present at the feast answers his questions
and then says:

“And now, most brave Perseus,
I beg you to describe the bravery
and skill you used to carry off that head
with snakes for hair.”

Agenor's descendant
then tells them how there is a cave below
the icy slopes of Atlas, safely tucked
inside its solid mass. In the entrance
dwelt two sisters, daughters of Phorcys,
who had just one eye to share between them.
He had stolen that eye with a deft trick,
by putting out his hand while the sisters
were exchanging it. And then he describes
how he went through distant, hidden places,
hard to reach, and rocks bristling with dense woods,
and reached the Gorgons' homes, how he had seen
everywhere in fields and roadways the forms
of wild beasts and men who, after looking
at Medusa, had changed from what they were
to stone, how he himself had nonetheless
gazed at dread Medusa's shape reflected
in the shining shield he held on his left arm,
how, while she and her snakes were sound asleep,
he had sliced through her neck and seized her head,

how Pegasus, the winged, swift-flying horse,
was born from Medusa's blood—his brother, too.

He tells them of the dangers he went through
in his long trip (and these were not made up),
the seas and lands he had seen under him
while he was flying up high, and stars he touched
when he spread out his wings. Then he fell silent,
while they were still expecting to hear more.
One of the leaders there spoke out, asking
why Medusa was the only sister
who had snakes tangled in her locks of hair.
Their guest responded:

“Since your question
involves a story well worth telling, listen—
here is the answer to what you just asked.
Medusa was once extremely beautiful,
the envious hope of many suitors.
Of all her features, none was lovelier
than her hair. I found a man who told me
he had seen it. People say that Neptune,
who rules the sea, attacked her sexually
in Minerva's temple, and the daughter
of Jupiter turned away, concealing
her pure face behind her aegis. And then,
to make sure the act was not unpunished,
she changed the Gorgon's hair to filthy snakes.
And now, to terrify her enemies,
to stun them all with fear, on her breastplate,
in the front, she wears those snakes she made.”

CERES, PROSERPINE, AND PLUTO¹

‘Ceres was the first to break up fertile ground
with a curved plough, the first to give earth crops
and wholesome food, the first to give us laws.
All things are gifts from Ceres, and Ceres
is the subject of my story. If only
I could sing something worthy of the goddess,
for she is surely worthy of a song.

¹This story begins at 5.537. This passage is a report by Urania, one of the nine Muses, of a story sung by Callisto, another one of the Muses (i.e., a tale within a tale; hence, the single quotation mark).

The huge island of Sicily is piled
above a Giant's limbs. Its immense mass
keeps Typhoëus buried underground,
the one who was so bold he set his sights
upon the realm of heaven. True, he tries
to struggle and often fights to rise again,
but his right arm is pinned down underneath
Ausonian Pelorus, and you, Pachynus,
hold down his left. Lilybaeum pushes
on his legs, and Aetna presses down his head.
Below it Typhoëus, flat on his back,
hurls ash from his fierce mouth and vomits fire.
He shifts around, trying to cast aside
that weight of earth, to roll the mighty hills
and cities off his body. Then Earth shakes.
Then even the king of the silent world
is afraid the ground might open up, split
in a wide crack, and daylight might come in
to scare the trembling shadows of the dead.
Fearing such a great disaster, Pluto
had left his shadowy dwelling place and,
riding in a chariot with black horses,
was carefully circling the foundations
of Sicilian lands.¹ After checking these
and satisfying himself that no regions
were unstable, he set aside his fears.
As he moved around, the goddess Venus,
sitting on her mountain, noticed Pluto.
Embracing her winged son, she said:

‘Cupid,
my son, my weapon, my hands, my power—
take those arrows you use to overwhelm
all beings, and shoot your swift-flying dart
into the heart of Pluto, whose lot won
the last of the three kingdoms.² Your great might
conquers gods above, even Jupiter,
and makes them your subjects, gods of the sea,
as well, and the one who rules them all.

¹Pluto is god of the Underworld, which holds the shades of the dead.

²As mentioned before, the three brothers Jupiter, Neptune), and Pluto drew lots to determine which of them should rule particular parts of the world. Neptune drew the lot for the sea, Pluto for the underworld, and Jupiter for the sky.

Why leave out Tartarus? Why should you not
expand your mother's kingdom and your own?
The stakes are high—a third part of the world!
I patiently endure the way we're scorned,
especially in heaven. Love's power
is on the wane, together with my own.
Do you not see how huntress Diana
has abandoned me, along with Pallas, too?
And if we allow it, that child of Ceres
will stay a virgin, too. She wants to live
like those two others. But if the kingdom
we both share in common gives you pleasure,
then make that goddess and her uncle one.¹

Venus spoke. Cupid opened his quiver,
as his mother had instructed, and picked
a single arrow from the thousand there.
None of the other arrows was as sharp
and accurate, or truer to the bow.
He bent the supple tips against his knee,
and his barbed arrow struck Dis in the heart.

Not far from Henna's walls lies a deep lake
named Pergus. Music from its swans matches
songs Caÿster hears on his gliding stream.
A wood surrounds the lake, enclosing it
on every side. Its leaves act as a shield
and ward off rays from Phoebus, the branches
cool the place, and the moist earth produces
purple flowers. By that pool the season
is an eternal spring. While Proserpine
was playing in this wood, picking violets
and shining lilies, and, like a young girl,
was keen to fill her baskets and her lap,
trying to gather more than anyone
of her own age, Pluto caught sight of her
and, in almost the same instant, loved her
and carried her away—that's how rapid
love can be. The frightened goddess shouted
cries of grief to her mother and her friends,

¹Ceres is a daughter of Saturn and a sister of Jupiter and Pluto (who is thus uncle to Ceres' daughter). The child of Ceres is Proserpine (also called Persephone) whose father is Jupiter. Proserpine is usually pronounced with three syllables (i.e., no final -e).

mostly to her mother. She tore her robe
along its upper edge, and the flowers
she had gathered fell from her loosened clothes.
Prosperine was so innocent and young,
that this loss also brought out virgin tears.
Her abductor drove the chariot ahead,
urging on his horses, calling each of them
by name, shaking his dark, rust-coloured reins
over their manes and necks, and charging on
through deep lakes and stinking sulphurous pools.

Then his strong arm hurled his royal sceptre,
which sank down to the bottom of a pool.
Stuck by the blow, Earth opened up a path
to Tartarus. The chariot hurtled down
right through the middle of the gaping hole.¹

Meanwhile, the girl's mother, goddess Ceres,
fearing for her daughter's safety, searches
every land and every sea. When the dawn,
Aurora, with her dew-drenched hair, arises
or Hesperus, the Evening Star, appears,
they do not find her resting. Her two hands
hold flaming torches she has lit from fires
on Aetna. In her frantic state of mind,
she bears these through the darkness of the night,
and when kind daylight once more dims the stars,
from the time Sun rises till the hour he sets,
she continues searching for her daughter.

[Ceres eventually is told that Proserpine is now in the Underworld, reigning as queen.]

When she heard this,
Ceres was stunned, as if turned into stone,
and for a long time seemed to be in shock,
until her intense anguish pushed aside
the weight of her bewilderment. She rushed
in her chariot up to heaven, and there,
face clouded in sorrow, hair dishevelled,
she stood in front of Jupiter and spoke
in a bitter voice:

¹Tartarus is the lowest region of the Underworld.

‘I have come to you,
Jupiter, to plead for my own offspring
and for yours, as well. If the child’s mother
finds no favour with you, let the daughter
influence her father and, I beg you,
do not let your care for her be any less
because she was born from me. Lo, my child
has been found, the one I have been seeking
for so long, if you can call it finding
when one is still more certain she’s been lost,
if you call it finding when all one knows
is where she is. I can accept the fact
that she has been abducted, provided
he returns her. A man who steals and rapes,
is no fit husband for a child of yours,
even if the girl were not my daughter.’

Jupiter replied:

‘That child is our pledge,
our shared responsibility, yours and mine.
But if you wish to give accurate names
to things, this is not a criminal act.
The truth is that this is love. And Pluto
would not be a son-in-law who shames us,
if you, goddess, would give him your consent.
If Pluto lacked all other qualities,
he would still be great—he is Jove’s brother!
What if he did not lack my qualities
and were not inferior to me at all,
except for the lot he drew? However,
if your desire that those two separate
is so strong, Prosperine may come back here
to heaven, but on one fixed condition—
that her lips have not touched down there,
for this has been established by the Fates
in their decrees.’

Jupiter had spoken.
Ceres was resolved to save her daughter.
But Fate would not allow it, for the girl
had broken her fast. In her innocence,
while she was in the cultivated garden,
wandering round, she had picked purple fruit

from a bent-over pomegranate tree,
taken seven seeds from its yellow rind
and pressed them in her mouth.¹ So Jupiter,
to mediate between his grieving sister
and his brother, divides revolving years
in equal portions. So now the goddess,
Persephone, is common to both realms.²
The months she spends with Ceres up above
match those she spends with Pluto down below.
Her face and nature change immediately.
For now the way she looks, which seemed so sad
a moment ago, that even Dis himself
would notice it, is joyful, like the sun,
which, hidden earlier by clouds of rain,
conquers those clouds and breaks away from them.

PROCNE, PHILOMELA, AND TEREUS

Now, Tereus was an important man,
with wealth and power, who traced his descent
from mighty Mars himself, so Pandion,
king of Athens, gave his daughter Procne
to him in marriage. But neither the Graces
nor Hymen was present at the wedding,
nor was Juno, who blesses married brides.
The Furies held up the wedding torches,
which they had taken from a funeral,
and they prepared the marriage bed, as well,
while the ominous screech owl hovered high
above the house and settled on the roof
above their chamber. Such were the omens
when Procne and Tereus were married,
such the omens, too, when they had a child.
It's true that Thrace congratulated them,
and they themselves gave thanks to all the gods.
They commanded that the day when Procne,
Pandion's daughter, and Thrace's famous king
were married, as well as the day on which

¹Ovid's text does not state specifically that the fruit is from a pomegranate tree, but long-standing traditions and rituals associated with Ceres for centuries identified the "purple fruit" as a pomegranate. The number of seeds varies from one account to another.

²Persephone is the Greek name for Proserpine. As queen of the Underworld, she is usually called Persephone (four syllables: Per-seph-o-ne).

their son, Itys, was born, should be declared a public holiday. That shows how much what really matters lies concealed from us.

Now the Titan Sun had drawn the seasons of the revolving year through five autumns, when Procne, trying to coax her husband, said to him:

“If you feel anything for me,
either let me go to see my sister,
or let my sister come to visit us.
You can promise my father she’ll be back
before too long. If you could arrange things
so I can see my sister Philomela,
you’d be giving me a truly lovely gift.”

Tereus told his men to launch a ship,
and, using sails and oars, he made the trip
to the port of Cecrops’ city, landing
at Piraeus. There, as soon as he met
his father-in-law, they linked right hands,
and Tereus offered his best wishes.
He had started to explain the reason
for his arrival and his wife’s request,
promising that if her sister visited,
she would come back soon, when, lo and behold,
Philomela arrived, looking gorgeous
in her rich garments, but even richer
in her own loveliness. She looked just like
what we so often hear about in stories
of the naiads and the dryads who roam
around the middle of the woods, if only
they possessed **her dress and her refinement**.
Tereus saw the girl and was on fire,
just as if someone were to place a flame
under dry ears of grain or set a torch
to piles of leaves or hay stacked in a barn.
Her beauty, it’s true, deserved such feelings,
but he was driven on by natural lust,
and people from his country tend to have
strong sexual passions. So he caught fire
thanks to his country’s vices and his own.

His desire wishes to corrupt the care
of her attendants and her nurse's trust,
to tempt the girl herself with immense gifts,
whatever his whole kingdom can afford,
or carry her off and defend the rape
with savage warfare. He is so consumed
with unbridled passion, there is nothing
he will not dare, for he has no power
to repress the fires blazing in his chest.
And now he cannot cope with a delay.
His eager mouth returns to the request
from Procne, and beneath her very words
he states what he himself desires. His feelings
make him eloquent. When he keeps asking
beyond what is polite, he makes it clear
that this is what Procne has requested.
He even adds his tears, as well, as though
she has instructed him to use those, too.
By gods above, how much hidden darkness
the human heart contains! The very things
Tereus does to promote his evil scheme
make them believe he is compassionate.
The people praise him for his evil deeds.
Philomela desires the same thing, too.
With her arms around her father's shoulders,
she coaxes him to let her travel there,
to visit her sister. She urges him
for her own well being, though what she seeks
will work against her. Tereus looks on,
and, as he gazes at her, imagines
he is holding her already. He sees
her kiss her father, putting both her arms
around his neck, and he absorbs it all
as an incitement, adding food and fuel
to his frenetic lust. And every time
she holds her father to her, he desires
to be that father—although if he were,
his feelings would be no less abhorrent.
Pandion gives way to the entreaties
from both of them. Philomela rejoices,
thanks her father, and thinks, unlucky girl,
she and her sister have now won the day,
when that success will bring on both of them
enormous grief.

The work of sun god Phoebus
by now was almost done. His horses' hooves
were drumming on the slopes of western skies.
A royal feast had been set out on tables
with wine in golden cups. They ate their fill
and then retired to have a peaceful sleep.
But although Tereus, the Thracian king,
went to bed, he burned for Philomela,
recalling her face, her hands, her movements,
imagining those parts he had not seen
to be just as he would want them. He fed
the fires within him and grew so restless
he could not sleep. Dawn came. As Tereus
was leaving, Pandion clasped the right hand
of his son-in-law and, with tears running
down his cheeks, implored him to look after
his daughter Philomela:

“My dear son,
because affection compels me to it,
and both my daughters wish it, and you, too,
Tereus, have said this is what you want,
I entrust her to your care. I beg you,
by your honour, by our united hearts,
and by gods above, to take care of her
with a father's love and to send her back
as soon as possible, this sweet comfort
in my worrisome old age. Any delay
will be too long for me. And Philomela,
if you have any affection for me,
come back to me as quickly as you can.
It's enough your sister is so far away.”

He gave these instructions to his daughter
and kissed her. As he issued his orders,
he wept quiet tears. Then he asked them both,
as a pledge of faith, for their two right hands.
These he took and joined, and then he told them
to remember to greet on his behalf
his absent child and grandson. His voice choked.
Convulsed with sobs, he could hardly manage
a last farewell. His mind was so afraid,
filled with an ominous sense of trouble.

As soon as Philomela was on board
and the painted **ship had** moved away from land,
as oar blades churned the sea, Tereus cries:

“I have triumphed! I am taking with me
just what I desire!”

The barbarian king
is overjoyed. He has trouble putting off
the pleasures his mind conjures up. His eyes
never turn away from her, just as an eagle,
Jupiter’s swift bird of prey, sets a hare,
gripped in its hooked claws, inside its lofty nest,
and the prisoner has no place to flee,
while the predator keeps gazing at its prey.

And now the trip is over. Once they reach
Tereus’ land, they leave the sea-worn ship,
and the king hauls Pandion’s daughter off
to a high-walled building, hidden away
in an ancient forest, and locks her in.
Philomela, pale, trembling, and in tears,
afraid of everything about the place,
keeps asking where her sister is. The king
reveals his criminal desire, and then
his force overpowers the lonely girl,
who often screams in vain to her father,
often to her sister, and above all,
to the mighty gods. She trembles with fear,
like a terrified lamb wounded by the jaws
of a grey wolf and later cast aside,
which does not realize it is now safe,
or like a dove with its feathers soaking
in its own blood, panic stricken, afraid
of the ravenous claws which snatched it up.
Soon, when she regains her senses, she tears
her dishevelled hair, like someone mourning,
scratches her arms, beats them against her breast,
stretches out her hands, and screams:

“You barbarian!
Think of what you have done, you savage beast!
Are you quite unmoved by what my father

asked of you with such affectionate tears,
or by any feelings for my sister,
or my innocence, or your marriage vow?
You have confounded everything! I am
now forced to be my sister's substitute
and you the partner of the two of us!
Procne will have to be my enemy.
Why did you not rip out this life of mine,
you traitor? Then your crime would be complete!
I wish you'd killed me before committing
this abominable rape. Then my shade
would have been free of shame. But if the gods
observe these things, if celestial powers
have any influence, if everything
is not destroyed along with me, then you
will pay me for this someday. I myself
will throw away all sense of shame and shout
what you have done. And if I get the chance,
I'll move among your people with the story.
If I'm kept a prisoner in the woods,
I'll fill the forest with my voice and move
the rocks, which know how you have ruined me!
Let heaven hear these things—and gods, as well,
if any gods live there!"

Philomela's words
enraged the king and also roused his fear.
Spurred by both emotions, he pulled the sword
he carried out of its scabbard, grabbed her
by the hair, forced her arms behind her back,
and tied her up. Once she saw his sword,
Philomela fully believed and hoped
she would be killed and offered him her throat.
But as she struggled to speak and pour forth
her anger, calling out her father's name
repeatedly, Tereus seized her tongue
with pincers, and using his savage blade
he sliced it out. The bottom of her tongue
still quivered in place, but the tongue itself
lay trembling on the dark earth, muttering.
It wriggled about (the same way a tail
from a snake will commonly keep moving
when it has been cut off), as if, in dying,
it was seeking some trace of its mistress.

They say (though this I hardly dare believe)
that even after this abhorrent crime
Tereus, in his lust, violated
her mutilated body many times.

After committing these atrocities,
Tereus calms down and returns to Procne,
who, as soon as she sees her husband, asks
about her sister. He pretends to sigh
and tells a made-up story of her death.
The tears he sheds make her believe his lies.
From her shoulders Procne tears her splendid robes
richly woven with gold and clothes herself
in black. She builds an empty burial vault,
where she makes sacrifices for a ghost
who does not exist and laments the fate
of a sister for whom death chants like that
are not appropriate.

The sun god circles
through twelve constellations. A year goes by.
What can Philomela do? There is a guard
to keep her from escaping, and the walls
of the place where she is held are thick,
made out of solid rock. Her speechless lips
can provide no details of what happened.
But pain promotes great ingenuity,
and when times are bad one grows resourceful.
With great skill she pulls thread into a warp
on a barbarian loom, and, by weaving
patterns of purple on a white background,
she depicts the crime. Once she is finished,
she entrusts the weaving to a servant,
asking her with gestures to present it
to the queen, her mistress, and the servant,
as requested, carries it to Procne,
not knowing what the woven work contains.
The wife of the savage tyrant unfolds
the tapestry and, looking at it, reads
her sister's dreadful fate. She says nothing.
It is amazing she can keep so quiet,
but grief prevents her speech. Her tongue seeks out
words which might be adequate to express
her murderous rage, but cannot find them.

With no time to weep, she rushes ahead,
so totally intent on her revenge,
she no longer separates right from wrong.

It was now time for young Thracian women
to celebrate the Bacchic festival
which, following their traditions, is held
at three-year intervals. These rites take place
at night, when Mount Rhodope re-echoes
to sounds of clashing brass. In the darkness,
the queen leaves home, dressed to participate
in sacred rituals and holding weapons
for the ecstatic ceremonial rites,
vine leaves wrapped around her head and deerskin
hanging down one side, with a slender spear
across her shoulder. Procne runs ahead
with throngs of her companions through the woods,
instilling terror. She keeps pretending
that you, Bacchus, have inspired her frenzy,
but she is driven on by frantic grief.
At length, rushing through the trackless forest,
she arrives at Philomela's building.
Procne, screaming and howling Bacchic cries,
shatters the doors and seizes her sister.
She dresses her in ritual garments
as one of the god's enraptured worshippers,
concealing her face with leaves of ivy,
drags the terrified girl away from there,
and leads her back inside the palace walls.
When Philomela saw that she had come
to that dreadful home, the bewildered girl
trembled with horror, and her face grew pale.
But Procne, once in the house, took away
the symbols of the Bacchic ritual,
uncovering her wretched sister's face,
and tried to hug her. But Philomela,
filled with shame, could not bear to raise her eyes.
She **thinks she is a whore who has** been false
to her own sister. So she kept her gaze
fixed on the ground. She wished to take an oath,
with the gods as witnesses, that her shame
was forced upon her, and she tried to use
her hands to show it, for she had no voice.

But Procne was ablaze—she could not check
her rage—and stopped her sister's tears, saying:

“No weeping now. This is a time for swords,
or something else more powerful than steel,
if you have such a thing available.
Sister, I am prepared for any crime.
I could set the royal palace on fire
with torches, hurl that treacherous Tereus
in the middle of the flames, or with a sword
slice out his tongue, eyes, or the sexual parts
he used to shame you, or I could expel
his guilty soul out through a thousand wounds!
I am prepared for a tremendous act—
but what that act will be, I'm still not sure.”

As Procne said this, her young son Itys
came to his mother, and she sensed from him
what she could do. While watching him, her eyes
grew cold, and she muttered:

“How much you look
just like your father!”

That was all she said.
Then, seething with silent rage, she began
to hatch her ghastly plan. But when the boy
ran to greet his mother, placed his small arms
around her neck, kissed her, and then added
some childish words of love, his mother
was truly shaken, her anger wavered.
Against her will her eyes filled up with tears.
But as soon as she felt too much emotion
eroding her resolve, she glanced away
and looked back at her sister's face. Gazing
at each of them in turn, she asked:

“Why is it
that one of them speaks of his affection
and the other has had her tongue removed
and does not talk? He can call me mother.
Why can she not call me sister? Just look,
daughter of Pandion, at your husband,
the man you married. You are not worthy

of your race. In someone married to Tereus
showing affection is a filthy crime!”

She did not pause, but dragged Itys away
to a distant room in the lofty home,
just like a tigress on the Ganges’ banks
hauling a baby fawn through shady trees.
Already sensing what his fate might be,
the child stretched out his hands and cried,

“Mother!

Mother!”

He tried to reach around her neck,
but Procne plunged her sword into his side,
close to his heart. She did not look away.
That one blow was enough to kill him,
but Philomela then took up the sword
and cut his throat, and while the limbs were warm,
still showing signs of life, they sliced him up
and set some pieces boiling in bronze pots,
as others hissed while roasting there on spits.
The inner chamber dripped with blood and gore.

Procne then invites Tereus, her husband,
who has no idea of what they’re doing,
to a feast. She falsely states that the meal
is a sacred ritual of her homeland.
Claiming the only one the law permits
to be there is the husband, she dismisses
his followers and attendants. And thus,
Tereus sits in his high ancestral seat,
feasting by himself, filling his stomach
with his own flesh and blood, so out of touch
with what is going on, he calls to her:

“Bring Itys here!”

Procne cannot conceal
her savage exultation. Eager now
to proclaim the news about the slaughter
she has carried out, she shouts:

“You have him
in there with you—the one you’re calling for!”

Tereus looks and asks where Itys is.
While he is searching, calling out again,
Philomela jumps at him, just as she is,
hair soaking from the appalling murder,
and thrusts the head of Itys, dripping blood,
right in his father’s face. At that moment,
more so than any other, she wishes
she could speak and proclaim her great delight
in words which match her mood.

The Thracian king
gives a tremendous roar and pushes back
the table, screaming out to the Furies,
those snake-haired sisters from the deep valley
of the Styx. Now, if it were possible,
he would tear his chest apart and disgorge
the dreadful meal of half-digested flesh.
He weeps and calls himself the wretched tomb
of his own son. And then with his sword drawn
he chases after Pandion’s daughters.
But you would think those Athenian women
have bodies now held up on feathered wings,
for they are taking flight. One of them flies
into the woods. The other nestles down
up in the eaves, still carrying traces
of that murder on her breast, her feathers
stained with blood. Tereus, swift in his grief
and cravings for revenge, is also turned
into a bird, with a crested head plume
and, instead of his long sword, a huge beak
jutting out in front. This bird, which looks armed,
has a name and is called the hoopoe bird.

JASON AND MEDEA¹

By now, in their ship built at Pagasae,
the Argonauts were carving their passage
across the sea. **They had paid a visit**

¹This passage begins at the opening of Book 7.

to Phineas, who was dragging out his life
in helpless, permanently blind old age.¹
The young sons of Boreas had chased off
the Harpies, those birds with young girl's faces,
from the poor man's island. After overcoming
many challenges with famous Jason
in command, they finally made their way
to the swift stream of the muddy Phasis.²
While they were meeting with king Aeetes,
asking him to return the Golden Fleece
from that ram which had carried Phrixus off,
and while king Aeetes was proposing
his grotesque conditions, which demanded
enormous labours from the Argonauts,
the daughter of the king, Medea, was seized
by fiercely passionate love for Jason.
For a while she tried to fight against it,
but when her reason could not overcome
her feelings, she said:³

“To struggle like this, Medea,
is useless. Some god—I don't know which one—
is going against you. I suppose that this,
or something like it, is what people call
being in love. For why do those demands
my father makes strike me as very harsh?
And, in fact, they are far too harsh! But why
am I afraid this man might come to grief,
when I've only now just seen him? What is it
that makes me so afraid? Unhappy girl,
if you can do it, you must douse these flames
which you have fanned inside your virgin heart!
If I could, I'd act with greater wisdom,
but some new force is pulling me along.

¹Phineas was punished by Jupiter, who blinded him and placed him on an island where his food was stolen by Harpies, flying monsters with female faces.

² The Phasis is a river in Colchis, a region in the western Caucasus (on the eastern shores of the Black Sea). Jason, son of Aeson and a prince of Iolcus (in Thessaly), was seeking to win back his father's kingship by acquiring the Golden Fleece. He assembled a crew of heroic figures to sail with him: Calais, Zethus, Hercules, Philoctetes, Peleus, Telamon, Orpheus, Castor, Pollux, Atalanta (the only woman), and Euphemus.

³Phrixus had been saved from death by a winged ram with a fleece of gold, which had carried him to Colchis. He sacrificed the ram to Neptune, and Aeetes, king of Colchis, kept the fleece in a grove, where it was guarded by a dragon. Jason is asking Aeetes to return the fleece.

My desire tells me one thing, and my mind
says something else. I see the better way
and want to go there, but I take the worse.
Why, you royal virgin, are you on fire
for a stranger? Why these dreams of marriage
in a foreign land? For this country, too,
can offer you someone to love. The gods
will determine if this man lives or dies.
But let him live! I may make that prayer,
even if I'm not in love. For what crime
is Jason guilty of? Apart from those
with pitiless hearts, who would not be touched
by Jason's youth, noble birth, and courage?
Or if he lacked all other qualities,
who could resist his beauty? For it's true—
he has really moved my heart. And unless
I offer my help, the breath of the bulls
will scorch him, or he will have to battle
against those earth-born enemies sprung up
from seeds which he himself has sown, or else
he will be offered up as cruel prey
to that ravenous snake.¹ If I stand by
and let this happen, I'll be confessing
a tigress was my mother and my heart
is made of iron and stone. Why do I
not watch him die—contaminate my eyes
by looking on? Why do I not incite
the bulls or the ferocious earth-born men,
or the dragon that never sleeps to fight
against him? May the wishes of the gods
bring better things! But I should not just pray
for this to happen. I should do something!
Should I then betray my father's kingdom
and use my power to save a stranger
I don't even know, so that with my help
he may remain unhurt, then sail away
without me, get married to someone else,
leaving Medea here, abandoning her
to face her punishment? If he could do that,
if he could prefer some other woman
to me, then let the thankless wretch perish!

¹Medea here is listing the tasks her father, king Aeetes, has set Jason, if he wishes to get back the Golden Fleece

But with that face, nobility of soul,
and handsome form of his, I need not fear
he will deceive me or forget my help.
Besides, he will promise himself to me
in advance. I will call upon the gods
to witness what we pledge. Why be afraid,
when you will be quite safe? Prepare yourself,
and do not wait. Jason will forever
be indebted to you. He'll marry you
in a solemn rite, and throngs of women
in Pelasgian cities will honour you
as the one who saved him.¹ So shall I then
be carried off by winds and leave behind
my country, my sister, brother, father,
and my gods, as well? But then my father
is a savage creature, my native land
a barbarous place, and my young brother
still a child. My sister's prayers are with me,
and the greatest god is here inside me!
I will not be leaving what is great behind,
no, I will be pursuing what is great—
honour for saving these young men of Greece,
a knowledge of much finer lands and towns
whose fame is celebrated, even here,
and the arts and culture of those regions.
Then there's Jason, for whom I'd willingly
trade everything the entire world contains.
Once he is my husband, I will be called
a happy woman, well loved by the gods,
and my head will touch the stars. Yes, but then
what of those stories people talk about—
rocks clashing in the middle of the sea,
Charybdis, the enemy of sailors,
who sucks down the sea and then spews it back,
and brutal Scylla with her savage dogs
barking in the deep seas of Sicily?
But as I am carried across the sea
on that long voyage, I will be holding
the man I love, embracing Jason's chest.
In his arms I will have no fears at all,
or, if I do, I will be afraid for him,

¹The term *Pelasgian* refers to all of Greece. The name is derived from the early inhabitants of the region. At times, however, it denotes a specific area (e.g., Thessaly).

only for my husband. But, Medea,
do you really think this is a marriage?
Are you not wrapping crime in lovely names?
Instead of doing that, you should consider
just how great a wrong you are proposing
and, while you can, avoid such treachery.”

Medea finished. Her eyes were gazing
at those virtues standing right before her—
right, piety, and modesty. Cupid,
now overpowered, turned his back on her.

Medea set off for the ancient altars
of Hecate, Perses’ daughter, hidden
in a shadowy grove, deep in the woods.
At this point she was firm. Her emotions,
now repressed, had ebbed. But then she saw him,
the son of Aeson, and the dampened fires
burst into flame again. Her cheeks turned red,
and her whole face grew hot. Just as a spark
buried in the ashes piled above it
is often fed by winds, grows, and, once stirred,
regains the strength it had before, that’s how
her passion (now so dull, you would have thought
by this time it had died) blazed up again,
when she observed the young man standing there
in front of her. And, as it so happened,
on that particular day Aeson’s son
was looking especially attractive.
Her love would be so easy to forgive!
She gazed at him, her eyes fixed on his face,
as if it was the first time she had seen him,
so disconcerted she did not believe
the man she was looking at was mortal.
She could not turn away. When the stranger
reached for her right hand and began to speak,
requesting in a humble voice her help
and promising marriage, Medea burst
into tears and answered:

“I understand
what I am doing. I am being seduced
by love, not by ignorance of the truth.
I will do what I can to save you, but then,
once you are safe, give me what you promise!”

Jason swore by the sacred rituals
of the three-formed goddess, by the spirit
in that grove, by the all-discerning Sun,
father of his future father-in-law,
by his own exploits, and by the dangers,
those immense perils, he would face. His oath
convinced Medea. He received from her
immediately some magic herbs and learned
how to apply them. Then, he made his way
back to the palace, overjoyed.

The next day,
once Aurora scatters the glittering stars,
people stream to the sacred field of Mars
and gather in position on the ridge.
Aeetes himself sits in the middle,
dressed in purple. His ivory sceptre
makes him conspicuous. Then, lo and behold,
bronze-footed bulls are snorting Vulcan's fire
from adamantine nostrils! Their hot breath
scorches the grass and sets the ground alight.
Just as fully stoked flaming forges roar
or limestone baked in earthen furnaces,
as it absorbs the heat, makes a loud hiss
when water drops are sprinkled over it,
that's how the chests and parched throats of those bulls
resound, as they pant out the roiling flames
they hold inside. But the son of Aeson
moves out to meet them. As he comes nearer,
the dreadful beasts turn their ferocious heads
and iron-tipped horns towards him, pawing
the dusty earth with cloven hooves, bellowing,
filling the air with smoke. The Argonauts
are stiff with fear. Jason moves to the bulls.
He does not feel their fire-laden breath
(such is the power of magic potions!).
His hand boldly strokes their hanging dewlaps
and harnesses the beasts under the yoke.
He forces them to pull the heavy plough
and with its blade carves up the untilled field.
The Colchians are stunned. The Argonauts
shout even louder, spurring Jason on.
Then from a bronze helmet he takes out

the dragon's teeth and scatters them, like seed,
across the field he has just ploughed. These seeds
have earlier been soaked in potent venom
and, once implanted in the soil, grow soft.
The sown teeth sprout and then begin to turn
into new bodies. Just as an infant child
acquires its human shape within the womb
of its own mother, forming parts inside,
and does not come out into the open air
before its body is complete, so these men
do not emerge out of the fertile soil
until they are full grown inside the womb
of pregnant Earth. Even more amazing,
they are brandishing weapons created
at the same time they are. The Pelasgians
watching these warriors about to hurl
their sharp pointed spears at young Jason's head
are fearful—their faces fall, their spirits
fail them. Even Medea feels afraid,
though she has taken steps to keep him safe.
When she sees the young man all by himself
with so many enemies assailing him,
the blood drains from her face. She sits down,
suddenly chilled and pale. And just in case
the power of the herbs she has provided
is insufficient, she recites a spell
to help him and invokes her secret arts.
Jason picks up a heavy rock and throws it
right in the middle of his enemies
and turns the fight from an attack on him
into a battle where those warriors
go after their own ranks. So those brothers,
created from the earth, wound one another
and die, falling in an internecine fight.

The Achaeans cheer, clutch the winner's hand,
and throw their arms eagerly around him.
And you, barbarian princess, you, too,
would like to hold the victor in your arms,
but your fear of being shamed prevents you.
You would embrace him, but are held in check
by concerns about your reputation.
You do what is appropriate—rejoice
with silent feeling and then offer thanks

to your spells and to the gods who craft them.
Jason still had to use his magic herbs
to put the dragon to sleep. This creature,
distinguished by its crest and triple tongue
and with hooked teeth—a terrifying sight!—
was the custodian of the tree which held
the Golden Fleece. Once Jason had sprinkled
the beast with herbal juices which produce
a Lethean sleep and had muttered three times
the words which bring calm slumbers, using spells
which soothe stormy seas and raging rivers,
sleep settled on that dragon's sleepless eyes,
and Aeson's heroic son carried off
the Golden Fleece. Proud of what he had won
and taking with him as another prize
the person who had made that possible,
triumphant Jason reached the port of Iolchos
with his wife, Medea.

In Thessaly,
mothers and aged fathers offered gifts
for their sons' safe return and in the flames
poured heaps of incense. As they had promised,
they led in and killed a sacrificial beast,
whose horns they had wrapped in gold. But Aeson,
Jason's father, did not participate
in their rejoicing, for, worn down by age,
he was now close to death. With this in mind,
Jason spoke about him to Medea:

MEDEA AND AESON

“Wife, to you, I admit, I owe my life,
and though you have given me everything
and the sum total of your services
is beyond belief, if your enchantments
can do it (and what can those spells of yours
not bring about?) then take away some years
from my own life and add them to my father's.”

Jason could not check his tears. Medea
was moved by the love Jason had displayed
in making the request. She thought about
her very different feelings for her father,
king Aetes, whom she had left behind.

However, that thought did not affect her,
and she said:

“Husband, what unholy scheme
has just passed through your lips? Do I look
as if I can transfer part of your life
to someone else? Hecate would not approve,
and what you ask is not appropriate.
But, Jason, I will try to give a gift
greater than the one you have requested.
Using my arts, I will try to lengthen
your father’s life without reducing yours,
if Hecate, the goddess of three forms,
will only give her personal consent
to such an immense and daring action
and lend us her support.”

It was three nights
before the moon’s horns were completely joined
into a sphere. But once the full moon shone
and her whole shape gazed down on earth, Medea
slipped from the palace in loose-fitting robes.
Her feet were bare, and her uncovered hair
hung down across her shoulders. She moved off,
without attendants, through the still silence
of the night. Deep slumbers had brought calm rest
to men and birds and beasts. There was no sound
in any hedgerow. Still leaves were silent,
and silent, too, the dewy air. Nothing moved,
except the quivering stars. Stretching her arms,
Medea turned herself around three times,
sprinkled water taken from a flowing stream
three times above her head, and then three times
her mouth let out a piercing howl. Knees bent,
she knelt down on the solid earth and cried:

“O Night, most faithful to these sacred rites,
and all you stars who, with the golden moon,
follow the fiery light of day, and you,
triple-formed Hecate, who understand
what we intend and come here eagerly
to undertake the task of helping us
with our sorcerer’s chants and rituals,
and you, O Earth, who grows the potent herbs

enchanters use, and you winds and breezes,
hills, streams, and lakes, you gods of every grove,
and all you gods of Night, be present here—
all those who help me, whenever I wish
to reverse a river's flow, make it run
past its astonished banks back to its source,
and with my magic soothe tempestuous seas
or stir up tranquil waters, scatter clouds
and bring them on, summon the stormy winds
and have them die away. With spells and chants
I break the serpent's jaws, rip living oaks
and boulders from their native soil, move trees,
and order hills to shake and earth to groan
and shadows of the dead to leave their tombs!
And you, O Moon, I also draw you down
in an eclipse, and my spells also make
the chariot of the Sun, my grandfather,
grow pale, and from my poisons Aurora
loses colour! On my behalf, you cooled
the fire from those bulls and forced their necks
beneath the yoke to pull the curving plough,
a task they could not bear. You made those men
born from dragon's teeth fight one another
in savage battle, and you lulled to sleep
the guardian of the fleece, who never slept,
and by deceiving him, sent that treasure
off to towns in Greece. Now I need the juice
by which old age, once renewed, can revert
to the prime of life, get back youthful years.
And that you will provide—that's why those stars
are sparkling, why a chariot is on its way
drawn by the necks of dragons on the wing."

A chariot was there, sent down from heaven,
and once Medea had climbed in, patted
the dragons' harnessed necks, picked up the reins,
and given them a shake, it snatched her off,
up to the sky. Looking down on Tempe,
in Thessaly lying far below her,
she drove the dragons on to certain places,
where she inspected herbs they might provide—
to Ossa as well as lofty Pelion
to Othrys, Pindus, and Mount Olympus,
an even higher peak. She took the plants

which pleased her, pulling some out by the roots,
and cutting others with a curved bronze knife.
Nine days and nights Medea moved around,
drawn in her chariot by those winged dragons,
examining the fields. Then she came back.
The dragons had not eaten any food.
They had only breathed the odour of those herbs,
and yet they had cast off their skins, the mark
of their advancing years. She reached her door,
right at the threshold, but remained outside,
with nothing but the sky above her head.
Shunning the company of men, she built
two altars out of turf—one on the right
for Hecate, one on the left for Youth.
When she had covered these with sacred boughs
from the forest wilderness, she dug out
two ditches in the earth close by and then
performed a holy sacrifice, plunging
her knife in a black ram's throat and soaking
the open ditches with her victim's blood.
Next, she poured goblets of liquid honey
on the blood and, in a second offering,
cups filled with heated milk. As she poured,
she uttered spells, calling on the spirits
of the earth, imploring the king of shades
and his ravished wife not to take the life
still left in the old man's limbs too quickly.

When she has appeased the gods with prayers
and lengthy incantations, she orders
Aeson's exhausted body to be brought
into the open air. Then with her spells
she puts him in a deep and death-like sleep
and stretches him on a layer of herbs.
She orders Jason and his attendants
to go away, advising them to take
their profane eyes far from her mysteries.
They disperse, as she has asked. Medea,
with her hair dishevelled, circles around
the flaming altars, like a worshipper
of Bacchus. She dips her branching torches
into the dark ditches, stains them with blood,
and at the altars lights them in the fire.
Next she purifies old Aeson, three times

with flame, three times with water, and three times
with sulphur. Meanwhile, a potent mixture
in a bronze cauldron set above the flames
is boiling, seething white with bubbling froth.
In this vessel Medea cooks some roots
she dug from fields in Thessaly, with seeds,
flowers, and black herbal juices, adding
stones gathered from the most distant regions
of the East and sand washed by ebbing seas.
She puts in hoar frost she scraped up at night
by moonlight, the ominous wings and flesh
of a screech owl, and the cut-up entrails
of the ambiguous werewolf, which can change
its bestial visage to a human face.
And she does not forget the scaly skin
from a thin Cinyphian water snake,
and liver from a long-lived stag. With these,
she includes the eggs and head from a crow
which has lived nine human generations.
When the barbarian princess had used these
and a thousand other items to attain
her more than mortal purpose, she stirred up
the whole mix with the branch of a mild olive,
long since dried out, blending what was on top
with what was underneath. Lo and behold,
in that hot bronze cauldron the old stick changed!
First it turned green and then, soon after that,
sprouted leaves and suddenly was loaded
with a heavy weight of fruit. When the flames
made foam boil over from the hollow bronze
and warm drops hit the earth, the ground turned green!
Soft grass and flowers sprung up from the soil!
When she saw this, Medea drew a knife,
slit open Aeson's throat, let his old blood
flow out, and replaced it with her juices.
After the old man had absorbed these fluids,
some passing through his mouth, some through his wound,
at once the colour of his hair and beard
changed from white to black, his skeletal frame
in one heart beat had vanished, his pallor
and debility were gone, compact flesh
smoothed out his hollow wrinkles, and his limbs
grew large and strong. Aeson was astonished,

recalling he had been just like this once,
some forty years ago.

And her magic spells
do not stop there. Medea then pretends
she has had a quarrel with her husband
and, under false pretenses, runs away
as a suppliant to Pelias, the king.
Because Pelias is himself worn out
and very old, his daughters welcome her.
By simulating friendship with deceit,
crafty Medea soon makes them her friends,
and when she tells them that of her good deeds
the greatest is the way she has removed
Aeson's frailty and when she lingers
on that tale, in Pelias' daughters
she creates the hope that similar spells
could restore the youth of their own father.
They ask Medea to do it, telling her
to name her price. She remains quite silent
for a while and appears to hesitate,
keeping those who are urging the request
in doubt, pretending she is still unsure.
Soon, however, she promises to try.
She tells them:

"To give you more confidence
in this talent of mine, your oldest ram,
of all your sheep the leader of the flock,
will, thanks to my medicines, become a lamb."

Immediately they lead in a woolly beast,
a feeble creature thoroughly worn out
with innumerable years. Its ancient horns
curl round its shrunken temples. Medea
cuts its scrawny throat with her Thessalian knife,
staining the blade (even though the creature
has hardly any blood), and then she stuffs
the creature's body in a hollow cauldron,
which also holds her potent magic juice.
This shrinks its body's limbs and melts the horns,
and with those horns its years dissolve away.
From the middle of the cauldron they can hear
a soft bleating noise, and then, right away,

MEDEA AND THE DAUGHTERS
OF PELIAS

while they are wondering about the sound,
a lamb jumps out and runs away to play
and find its mother's udder for some milk.
The daughters of Pelias are amazed.
And now Medea's promises have shown
she can be trusted, they encourage her
even more eagerly to work her magic.

Phoebus had led his horses from their yoke
three times, after completing their descent
into the Iberian sea. On the fourth night
brilliant stars were shining as Medea,
Aeetes' deceitful daughter, set out
on a blazing fire pure water and herbs
(but ones which had no healing potency).
King Pelias and the guards escorting him
by now were fast asleep, bodies stretched out
and relaxed, like corpses. Medea's spells
and magic powers had put them in that state.
The daughters, following her instructions,
accompanied the Colchian sorceress
into the room where Pelias was sleeping
and stood there, grouped around the royal bed.
Medea said:

“Why are you so listless?
Why hold back now? Unsheathe those swords of yours,
let his old fluids out, so I can fill
his empty veins with youthful blood! You hold
your father's life and age in your own hands.
If you have any loving feelings for him,
if those hopes which spur you are not empty,
carry out this action for your father.
Use your weapons to chase away old age,
and, with one slash of those swords you hold,
drain his corrupted blood.”

Urged on by these words,
both daughters, because they love their father,
for the first time set aside their duty.
In order to avoid irreverence,
they carry out an irreverent act.
Still, neither one can watch the stab she makes.
They avert their eyes, turn their heads away,

and with brutal hands blindly stab their father.
Blood pours from the old man, who lifts himself
up on his elbows, half cut to pieces,
and tries to leave the bed. Stretching pale arms
out into the middle of so many swords,
he cries out:

“Daughters, what are you doing?
Why take up arms against your father’s life?”

Their courage and their strength abandon them.
Pelias is about to speak more words,
but Medea cuts off all further speech.
She slits his throat. His mutilated corpse
she then dumps in the seething cauldron.

[To escape punishment, Medea leaves in her chariot drawn by dragons and goes on an extended trip over various islands.]

Finally, with her winged dragons she reached
Ephyre, home of the Pirenian spring,
where people in the olden days would claim
that in the earliest ages human bodies
were created out of rain-soaked mushrooms.
Here, after Jason’s new bride was consumed
by Medea’s drugs and both seas had seen
the royal palace burning, Medea
profanely bathed her sword in her sons’ blood.¹
After this appalling act of vengeance,
she fled, avoiding Jason’s armed response.
Borne from there on her Titanic dragons
she came to Athens, city of Pallas, where
Aegeus took her in (and should be condemned
for that one act alone), but welcoming her
was not enough. He also joined himself
to her, and she became his wife.

MEDEA’S REVENGE

MINOS AND THESEUS, DAEDALUS AND ICARUS²

¹Jason betrayed Medea by marrying the daughter of the king of Ephyre (an ancient name for Corinth). Medea, seeking revenge for his infidelity, sent the new bride a poisoned tiara and dress which ate away her flesh, and she died in agony. The king of Corinth died from the poison, as well, and the palace burned down. Then Medea killed both sons she and Jason had had together.

²This passage begins at 8.243 in the complete poem.

As soon as Minos reached the land of Crete,
he disembarked. To fulfill a promise
he had made to Jupiter, he sacrificed
one hundred oxen and hung his trophies
in the palace as a decoration.
But he faced a growing family scandal.
The shameful adultery of the queen
was obvious from the bizarre nature
of her hybrid monster child. Minos
chose to move this disgrace out of his home
and to keep it in a complex structure,
a labyrinth built with blind passages.
Daedalus, a man highly celebrated
for his skill in architecture, drew up
the plans. With confusing direction marks
he led the eye into a wandering maze
of various twisting pathways. Just as
the playful waters of the Maeander
keep changing course, as they flow here and there
across the fields in Phrygia and can see
the waves upstream moving down towards them,
while their uncertain currents sometimes flow
to their sources, sometimes to the open sea,
that's how Daedalus designed the pathways,
countless wandering passages in the maze.
The structure was so hard to navigate,
that even Daedalus found it difficult
to find his way back to the entry point.
In that labyrinth Minos imprisoned
the monstrous double shape of bull and man.
Twice he fed it blood from young Athenians
chosen by lot at nine-year intervals.

But the third time he collected tribute,
the monster was overcome, for Theseus,
son of Aegeus, with the assistance
of young Ariadne, Minos' daughter,
by following a thread made his way back
on the tricky pathway to the entrance,
a trip no one had ever made before.
He immediately set sail for Dia,
taking Ariadne with him, but then
cruelly abandoned his companion

on the shore. The girl, in her isolation,
wept bitter tears, but Bacchus embraced her
and provided help. Taking off the crown
around her head, he set it in the sky,
to make her famous as an eternal star.
Up through the lighter air it soared aloft
and, as it moved, its jewels were transformed
to brilliant fires. They settled into place,
retaining still the outline of a crown,
halfway between the kneeling Hercules
and the serpent held by Ophiuchus.

Meanwhile, Daedalus had grown frustrated
with Crete and his long exile there. He yearned
for his own land, but was held back by the sea.
He said:

“Minos may block off land and sea,
but surely the sky is open to us—
and that’s the route we’ll take. He may control
all things, but he does not control the air.”

He spoke and then set his mind to thinking
of inventions as yet unknown, and thus
he changed the course of nature. For he arranged
rows of feathers, taking the smallest first
and then longer ones laid out in sequence,
so it looked as if they’d grown out on a slope,
like those ancient pipes shepherds used to play,
with different reeds which lengthened gradually.
Those in the centre he then joined with thread,
those at the ends with wax. Once the feathers
were assembled in this way, he shaped them
into a gentle curve, so they looked like
wings of real birds. His son Icarus
stood beside him, unaware that the things
he touched would put his life in danger.
Sometimes he laughed as he caught the feathers
shifting around in the wandering breeze
or with his thumb softened the yellow wax
and with his playful games kept interrupting
his father’s miraculous construction.
When Daedalus had put the final touches
on what he had begun, he raised himself

into the moving air, balancing his body
between a pair of wings. He also gave
the following instructions to his son:

“I warn you, Icarus—limit your flight
to the region between heaven and earth.
If you go too low, then water vapour
will weigh down your wings. If you go too high,
fire will burn them. So fly between the two.
And listen. Do not look at Boötes,
Helice, or the drawn sword of Orion.
I will guide you. Follow the path I take!”

While Daedalus was telling him the rules
of flying, he adjusted the new wings
on Icarus’ shoulders. While he worked
and issued his advice, the old man’s cheeks
were wet, and the father’s hands were trembling.
He kissed his son (he would not kiss him again),
moved upward on his wings, and flew ahead,
concerned for his companion. Just as a bird
leads her tender chicks out of their high nest
into the air, Daedalus keeps encouraging
his son to follow, as he demonstrates
his skill in the dangerous art of flight.
While moving his own wings, he glances back
at the wings of Icarus behind him.
Those who catch sight of them—a man angling
for fish with a trembling rod, a shepherd
leaning on his staff, or a farmer resting
on his plough—are astonished and assume
that people who can travel through the sky
must be divine.

By now the island Samos,
sacred to goddess Juno, was on their left,
while Delos and Paros lay behind them,
with Lebinthus on their right, along with
Calymne, rich in honey. At this point,
Icarus started to enjoy the flight,
for all its perils, so he left his guide
and, filled with a desire to reach heaven,
pursued a higher path. His close approach
to the fierce Sun softened the fragrant wax

which held his wings in place. The wax melted.
He flapped his naked arms, but since he had
no oar-like wings, he failed to catch the air.
While his mouth was screaming his father's name,
his cries were drowned out by the sky-blue sea
which takes its name from him. His sad father,
now no more a father, shouted:

“Icarus!

Where are you, Icarus? Where should I look
to find out where you are?”

He kept on calling

“Icarus!”

Then he noticed feathers
in the waves and cursed his own inventive skills.
He buried his son's body in a tomb
in a place whose name became Icaria,
after the young lad who was buried there.

HERCULES, DEIANEIRA, NESSUS¹

[The hero] Hercules, son of Jupiter,
while returning to his native city
with Deïanira, his new wife, reached
the swift stream of the river Euenus.
Swollen by winter rains, the water flow
was now above its customary height,
with many whirlpools, and could not be crossed.
Though Hercules had no fear for himself,
he did have some concern about his bride.
Nessus rode up. His limbs were powerful,
and he was well acquainted with the ford.²
He said to Hercules:

“Child of Alceus,
with my help she will be deposited
on that bank over there. You use your strength
for swimming!”

¹This story begins at 9.167 in Ovid's complete poem.

²Nessus is a centaur (part man, part horse), a son of Ixion.

The hero from Boeotia
hands the Calydonian girl to Nessus.
She is pale with fear of both the river
and the centaur. Hercules throws his club
and his curved bow across to the far bank.
Then, just as he is, weighed down by quiver
and the lion's skin, he says:

“Since I have started,
I must cross this river.”

He does not pause
or search out the calmest stretch of water,
for he refuses to be borne across
because the stream has given its consent.
As he climbs the further bank and grabs the bow
he hurled across, he hears his wife cry out.
Sensing that Nessus is now intending
to violate his trust, he shouts at him:

NESSUS ABDUCTS DEIANIRA

“Where are you carrying her, you brute beast,
vainly relying on your rapid hooves?
I'm talking to you, Nessus, you monster
with a double form. So listen to me!
Do not run off with what is rightly mine.
If respect for me does not restrain you,
that wheel your father rides might well prevent
forbidden sexual acts.¹ You won't escape!
Though you may trust your powers as a horse,
I'll catch you with an arrow, not my feet.”

And then he carried out what he had said.
He shot an arrow at the fleeing back.
The iron barb struck Nessus through the chest.
When he removed the arrow, blood poured out,
mixed with lethal poison of the Hydra,
from both his wounds, one where the arrow hit
and one where it was sticking out.² Nessus
sopped up his blood and muttered to himself:

THE DEATH OF NESSUS

¹Ixion, father of Nessus, attempted to rape Juno and was punished by being eternally tied to a wheel deep in Hades.

²Hercules put the poisonous blood from the Hydra, a monster he had killed, on the tips of his arrows.

“I will not die without getting revenge.”

And so he soaked his shirt in his warm blood
and gave it to the girl he was abducting,
telling Deïanira it was a gift
which had the power to arouse new love.

Many years go by, and the entire world
is full of the deeds of mighty Hercules
and his step-mother's hatred towards him.¹
Hercules has captured Oechalia
and is preparing to make sacrifice
to Jupiter at Cenaëum. But then,
chattering Rumour, who takes great delight
in mixing false things with the truth and grows,
thanks to her lies, from the minutest things,
flies on ahead of him and strikes your ears,
Deïanira, claiming Amphitryon's son,
your husband, is in love with Iole.
Deïanira, who loves Hercules,
believes the story of this new affair
and is alarmed. First, she turns to weeping,
and, feeling miserable, vents her sorrow
with laments. But soon she says:

DEÏANIRA AND HERCULES

“Why am I crying?
My rival will be happy with these tears.
Since she is coming here, I must prepare
some brand new scheme, while it's still possible,
before that other woman takes control
inside my marriage bed. Should I complain
or hold my tongue? Go back to Calydon
or remain right here? Should I leave this house,
or, if I can do nothing more, should I
at least make things more difficult for them?
O Meleager, what if I remember
I am your sister and with a brave heart
prepare to carry out a crime and show,
by slitting Iole's throat, how much harm
a woman's grief is able to inflict.”

¹Hercules' step-mother is Juno, wife of Jupiter.

Her mind reviewed the different options,
 and of them all she chose to send the shirt
 soaked in Nessus' blood, to restore the strength
 of her husband's fading love. Unaware
 that the shirt would make her miserable,
 she gave it to the unsuspecting Lichas.¹
 Using words designed to win him over,
 the desperate, unhappy woman told him
 to give it to her husband.

Hercules,

knowing nothing about the shirt, takes it
 and drapes across his shoulders the poison
 from the Lernaean Hydra. At the time,
 he is setting incense, offering prayers
 by the initial flames, and pouring wine
 from a dish onto the marble altars.
 The destructive power in that poison
 heated by the flames, softens and dissolves
 and spreads itself through Hercules' body.
 While he still can, he silences his groans
 with his habitual courage. But later,
 once his agony has overpowered
 his resistance, he throws the altars down
 and fills the woods of Oeta with his cries.
 He wastes no time in trying to rid himself
 of the fatal shirt. But where he tears it,
 it rips away the skin or—the details
 are appalling to describe—sticks to his flesh,
 so all attempts to get it off are futile,
 or else it shows his mutilated limbs
 and massive bones. His very blood sizzles,
 boiling from the searing venom, just like
 red-hot metal plunged in freezing water.
 His pain goes on and on. Voracious flames
 suck in his stomach, from his whole body
 black sweat keeps oozing out, scorched sinews crack,
 and hidden poison liquefies his bones.
 Raising his hands, he shouts up to the stars:

“Daughter of Saturn, feed on my collapse.
 Eat your fill, you cruel goddess! Look down

¹Lichas was one of Hercules' attendants.

from lofty heaven on this destruction,
and glut your savage heart! Or if my state
earns pity even from an enemy—
even from you—then carry off my soul,
my wretched spirit, wracked with searing pain
and born for toil. To me death is a gift,
a fitting present from my step-mother.
Was it for this I threw down Busiris,
who desecrated shrines with strangers' blood?
Was it for this I raised Antaeus up,
above his mother Earth, who gave him strength,
or stood my ground before the triple shape
of that Iberian herdsman Geryon,
or faced you, Cerberus, and your three heads?
Was it for this these hands of mine hauled down
the horns of that strong Cretan bull, and worked
at Elis, at the Stymphalian lake,
and in Parthenian woods? Thanks to their strength
did I not fetch that belt engraved with gold
back from the Amazons and those apples
guarded by the dragon that never sleeps?
And were the centaurs able to stand up
to me, or that boar which wrecked such havoc
in Arcadia? And was the Hydra helped
by growing larger from its loss, gaining
redoubled strength? And what about the time
I saw Thracian horses fed human blood,
their stables crammed with mangled bodies,
and, once I'd seen that, overpowered them,
and killed those horses and their master, too?
The huge Nemean lion now lies dead,
killed by these arms of mine, and with this neck
I have held up heaven. Jupiter's cruel wife
may have grown tired of issuing orders—
I am still not tired of carrying them out.
But now I am facing some new disease
which courage, weapons, and power in war
cannot resist. An all-consuming fire
roams deep inside my lungs and feeds itself
on every limb, and yet Eurystheus

is thriving. Are there men who still believe
the gods exist?"¹

When Hercules had spoken,
he wandered across the heights of Oeta,
still ravaged by the poison, like a bull
with a hunting spear stuck in its body
after the man who threw it goes away.
You could have seen him there, often groaning
and grinding his teeth, often attempting,
again and again, to rip off his back
the remnants the shirt, flattening trees,
howling at the mountains, or raising his arms
up to his father's sky.

Then, lo and behold,
he caught sight of Lichas hidden away
in a cavernous rock and terrified.
In his pain, Hercules brought all his rage
to bear on Lichas and yelled at him:

HERCULES AND LICHAS

“Lichas!
Weren't you the man who brought that fatal gift
and gave it to me? Are you not the one
responsible for my death?”

¹Hercules in this speech reviews some of his most famous exploits, most of them from his celebrated twelve labours. Busiris was a king of Egypt who sacrificed foreigners. Hercules, passing through Egypt, was arrested by Busiris but broke free and killed him. Antaeus was a Libyan giant who drew his strength from the earth. He challenged people to wrestle and then killed them. Hercules held Antaeus off the earth, from which he drew his strength, until Antaeus weakened and then Hercules killed him. Geryon was a herdsman with three bodies. Hercules, in his tenth labour, killed him with an arrow and took away his herds. Cerberus was a three-headed dog guarding the entrance to Hades. Hercules in his twelfth labour went down to Hades and dragged him up to earth. In the seventh labour, Hercules brought back to Eurystheus the Cretan bull, which was ravaging Crete. At Elis Hercules completed his fifth labour, cleansing the Augean stables. His sixth labour was to drive birds away from the Stymphalian lake. Parthenium was a mountain in Arcadia where Hercules carried out his third labour, capturing the deer with golden antlers. For his ninth labour Hercules brought back the belt of Hippolyta, queen of the Amazons. In his eleventh labour, Hercules brought back apples from the Hesperides. Capturing the Erymanthian Boar was Hercules' fourth labour, and killing the Lyrnaean Hydra was his second labour. The Thracian horses were the mares of Diomedes, which Hercules captured and brought to Eurystheus in his eighth labour (Ovid's text says he killed them). Hercules' first labour was to bring back the skin of an allegedly invincible lion rampaging around Nemea. Hercules visited Atlas, who supported the heavens on his shoulders, and temporarily relieved him of the burden. Eurystheus, king of Mycenae, was Hercules' great enemy, who, on Juno's instructions, assigned Hercules the different labours.

Lichas trembled,
grew pale, and panicked. Timidly he mentioned
his excuses. But while he was pleading
and trying to reach for Hercules' knee,
Alcides grabbed him and spun him around
three or four times, then threw him with more force
than a catapult out over the depths
of Euboea's sea. As he soared upward
into the airy breeze, Lichas hardened.
Just as rain, so people say, is frozen
by the icy winds—that's how snow is formed—
and in whirling snow, soft bodies are packed down
and rounded into dense clouds of hailstones,
in the same way, so former ages claim,
once those powerful arms threw Lichas up
into the air, fear drained the man of blood,
and, lacking any moisture in his body,
he was transformed to solid rock. And now,
in the waters off Euboea, there stands
a little reef which juts up from the deep
and keeps the traces of a human form.
Sailors are afraid to walk along that rock,
as if the stone might sense their presence there.
They call it Lichas.

LICHAS IS TRANSFORMED

Then, famous son
of Jupiter, you cut down trees that grew
on rugged Oeta, built up a funeral pyre,
and told Philoctetes, son of Poeas,
to take charge of your bow, your bulky quiver,
and your arrows—destined to see once more
the realm of Troy.¹ And with that same man's help
you lit a flame deep in the pyre. While the pile
was catching fire in the ravenous flames,
you spread the hide of that Nemean lion
on the top part of the wood and lay down,
neck resting on your club, looking just like
a guest with garlands on his head, reclining
in the middle of full cups of wine.

THE DEATH OF HERCULES

¹ Troy, according to the decrees of Fate, could be captured only with the bow and arrows of Hercules, who had been to Troy before when he attacked king Laomedon for his failure to keep a promise. Years later, Philoctetes, now the possessor of the bow, went to Troy to help end the Trojan war.

By now
the growing flames were crackling and had spread
in all directions. They attacked his limbs,
but his body was serene and scorned them.

The gods grew anxious for this protector
of the earth, so Jupiter, Saturn's son,
sensing their mood, spoke reassuring words:

JUPITER AND HERCULES

“You gods above, your fear gives me great joy,
and I can freely and whole heartedly
congratulate myself for being called
ruler and father of a grateful people
and also for the way your high regard
protects my offspring. For though your concern
pays tribute to what this great man has done,
I also am obliged you honour him.
But do not let an empty fear affect
your hearts. Think nothing of those fires
on Oeta! He who has overcome all things
will overcome those flames you now perceive
and will have no sense of Vulcan's power,
other than in parts his mother gave him.¹
What he gets from me is everlasting,
beyond death's reach. It will not be destroyed
or consumed in any fire. Once that part
is done with earth, then I will welcome it
to heavenly regions, and I have faith
that all you gods will find this act of mine
a reason to rejoice. But if perhaps
some god—and I mean any god at all—
will grieve when Hercules becomes divine
and is not happy to bestow this gift,
that god should realize we're giving it
because his merit makes him worthy of it,
and should approve, although unwillingly.”

The gods agreed, even royal Juno,
Jupiter wife, who, if she looked upset
with his last words, appearing to resent
that he was making reference to her,
seemed to accept the rest of what he said.

¹Vulcan is god of fire.

Meanwhile, whatever the fire could burn up
Vulcan had consumed, and what now remained
no one would recognize as Hercules,
for he bore no traces of those features
he had inherited from his mother
and preserved only those he had received
from Jupiter. And just as a serpent
throws off old age when it casts off its skin
and takes great delight in being renewed
with glistening fresh scales, in the same way,
when that Tirynthian hero had lost
his mortal limbs, his better part grew strong,
and he began to look much greater than before—
awe-inspiring, with solemn dignity.
The omnipotent father carried him
through hollow clouds in his four-horse chariot
and placed him up among the glittering stars.

THE SONGS OF ORPHEUS¹

From Crete, Hymen, dressed in yellow garments,
flew through vast expanses of the air
and moved to regions of the Cicones,
summoned there by the voice of Orpheus.²
His trip was futile. Although he did attend
Orpheus' wedding, he did not speak
his usual words, or have a joyful face,
or bring good luck. Even the torch he held
spluttered with smoke, making his eyes water,
and waving it around produced no flames.

ORPHEUS AND EURYDICE

What happened afterwards was even worse
than any omen, for Eurydice,
Orpheus' new bride, while wandering
through a meadow with a crowd of naiads,
was bitten on the ankle by a snake.

¹This selection, which begins at 10.1 in Ovid's poem, includes a number of stories which occur in sequence (with some editorial deletions): Orpheus and Euridice, Jupiter and Ganymede, Apollo and Hyacinthus, Pygmalion, Cinyras and Myrrha, Venus and Adonis, Atalanta and Hippomenes, and the death of Orpheus (which continues his story at the opening of Book 11). Orpheus was a legendary musician, son of the Muse Calliope.

²Hymen is the god of marriage.

She collapsed and died. The Thracian poet,
after he had had enough of mourning
in the upper world, dared to travel down
the Taenarian gate to the river Styx,
to see if he could win the sympathy
of dead shades below. He moved through crowds
of insubstantial spirits, the phantoms
of those who had received full burial rites,
and came to Persephone and the god
of all the shadows of the dead, who rules
that dismal kingdom. Plucking lyre strings
to accompany his words, Orpheus sang:

“O you gods who live underneath the earth,
where all we created mortal beings
finally descend, if you’ll permit me
to set aside the uncertain stories
of a deceptive tongue and speak the truth,
then, with your permission, I will tell you
I am not here to see dark Tartarus
or tie up Medusa’s monstrous offspring
with its triple throat and snaky hair. No.
The reason I came down here is my wife.
She stepped on a snake, which spread its poison
through her and robbed her of her youthful life.
I beg you by these terrifying spaces,
by this vast Chaos, and by the silence
of this huge realm, weave once again the thread
which determined Eurydice’s swift fate.
All things, including us, belong to you,
and after we delay a little while,
sooner or later we all hurry down
to this one place. All men come to this spot.
It is our final home, and you possess
the longest rule over the human race.
My wife will also come under your sway,
when, as a mature woman, she has lived
her full span of years. I am asking this
as a favour to me, and if the Fates
deny my wife this gift, my mind is set—
I have no wish to journey back. You gods
can then rejoice that both of us are dead.”

As Orpheus sang this, striking his strings
 to match his words, the bloodless spirits wept.
 Tantalus did not reach for the water
 when it flowed out, Ixion's wheel stood still,
 as if amazed, and vultures did not gnaw
 on Tityus' liver. The Belides,
 daughters of Danaüs, put down their jars,
 and Sisyphus, you, too, sat on your rock.
 And people say that then, for the first time,
 the cheeks of the Furies were wet with tears,
 overpowered by his singing.¹ The queen
 of the lower regions and her husband,
 who rules the Underworld, could not refuse
 what he had asked. They called Eurydice,
 standing there among the spirits of those
 who had just arrived. She walked up slowly,
 still affected by her wound. Orpheus,
 the poet from Thrace, took her back again
 and, as he did so, accepted this condition—
 he would not turn round and look behind him
 until he had moved up from the valleys
 of Avernus, and if he did, his gift
 would be withdrawn.

The two of them then climbed
 the ascending path through the still silence,
 a steep, dark way, enveloped in thick fog.
 As they drew near the surface of the earth,
 Orpheus feared his wife Eurydice
 could not keep up and longed to look at her.
 Because he loved her, he glanced behind him.
 She instantly fell back. Poor Orpheus
 stretched out both his arms, trying to hold her
 and be held. He caught nothing but thin air.

¹This is short list includes the best-known names of those punished in Hades. Tantalus, a son of Jupiter, offended the gods (different accounts give different reasons) and was punished by being unable to drink the water from the pool in which he was standing or eat the fruit in a tree overhead. Ixion attempted to seduce Juno and was tied to a wheel which kept him revolving. Tityos, another son of Jupiter and a creature of enormous size, attempted to rape Latona and was killed by Apollo. In Hades his liver was constantly devoured by a vulture and kept growing back. The granddaughters of Belus (a king of Egypt) are the daughters of Danaus (the Danaïds), who killed their husbands (who were also their cousins) on their wedding night. They were condemned to spending all their time filling jars from which the water quickly leaked out. Sisyphus was punished for various crimes. He had to push a large rock uphill, but just as he was about to reach the top, the rock rolled down again. The Furies are the divine agents of blood revenge.

Now dying a second time, Eurydice
made no complaint at all about her husband
(what could she object to except the fact
that she was loved?). She said her last farewell,
which scarcely reached his ears, and then turned back
returning to the region she had come from.

Orpheus longed to cross the Styx again,
but prayers were useless—the ferryman
pushed him away. He sat down by the shore
for seven days, neglecting his appearance.
He refused all nourishment and fed himself
on his own tears and mental pain. Complaining
that the gods of Erebus were heartless,
he moved away to high Mount Rhodope
and windswept Haemus.

The Titan sun god
had three times come to watery Pisces,
finishing off the year, and in that time
Orpheus had refused to love a woman,
either because his love had ended badly
or because he'd made a promise not to.
But many women, passionate for him,
wished to wed the poet and were upset
when he declined. But Orpheus transferred
his love to tender boys and was the first
among the Thracian people to enjoy
their brief spring years and early flowering,
before they were young men.

There was a hill
whose summit was an open level plain
with fresh green turf, a place which had no shade.
But when that poet, born of gods, sat down
and struck his lyre strings, the trees moved there.
Chaonian oak and groves of poplar
(Phaëton's sisters), oak trees thick with leaves,
tender lime, beech, and virgin laurel trees
came to the place, with brittle hazels, too,
and ash trees (used for spears), clear firs, holm oaks
weighed down with acorns, delightful plane trees,
maples in all their various colours,
with willows, which grow by banks of rivers,

ORPHEUS SINGS TO THE TREES

watery lotus trees, as well as boxwood,
which is always green, slender tamarisks,
twin-coloured myrtle trees, and viburnum
with its dark blue berries. You ivy trees
with twisting shoots came, too, and leafy vines,
ivy-covered elm trees and mountain ash,
spruce, wild strawberry loaded with red fruit,
and bending palms, the prize of victory.

These were the types of trees which Orpheus
attracted to him, and he sat down there,
with crowds of wild beasts and birds around him.
When his thumb had tested his strings enough
and he sensed the various notes they made,
although quite different, were all in tune,
he raised his voice in the following song:

“My parent Muse, begin my song with Jove,
for all things yield to Jupiter’s power,
and I have often offered songs before
about the might of Jupiter and sung
more solemn melodies of the Giants
and Jove’s victorious bolts of lightning
hurled down upon the plains of Phlegraea.
But now’s the time for a less solemn song.
I sing of boys the gods have loved and girls
in the grip of forbidden flames who earned
just punishment for carnal love affairs.

ORPHEUS’ SONG

The king of the gods once burned with love
for Phrygian Ganymede. So he changed
to a bird, feeling that form would better fit
what he had in mind than his normal shape.
He thought most birds beneath his dignity,
so he chose the one with power enough
to bear his lightning bolt. Once in this form,
he did not hold back, but beating the air
with his spurious wings, he flew to Troy
and snatched away the boy, who even now
still brings the mixing cups to Jupiter,
and, flouting Juno’s wishes, pours his nectar.

JUPITER AND GANYMEDE

You too, Hyacinthus from Amyclae—
Phoebus would have settled you in heaven,

APOLLO AND HYACINTHUS

if grim fate had given him sufficient time.
Still, as much as things like that are possible,
you are immortal, for every time the spring
drives off the winter and the Ram appears
right after watery Pisces, you rise
and blossom in the fresh green turf once more.
You are the one my father doted on
above all others. His shrine at Delphi,
placed in the centre of the world, lacked
its presiding deity, while the god
remained in Eurotas and unwall'd Sparta,
totally neglecting lyre and bow.
Ignoring who he was, he volunteered
to carry hunting nets or hold the dogs,
as he travelled across harsh mountain ridges,
always with his companion Hyacinthus.
In this way, by staying with him, he nursed
his fiery love.

When the Titan Sun
was almost in the middle of his course
between the previous and the coming night,
an equal distance from each one of them,
Hyacinthus and Apollo stripped down,
covered their bodies with rich olive oil
until they gleamed, and started to compete
in a discus toss. First Apollo threw,
balancing the discus and hurling it
into the airy breeze. Its weight broke up
the clouds along its path. After some time,
the disc fell back and struck the solid ground,
proof of Apollo's strength and skill combined.
Eager to have his turn, the Spartan lad,
not thinking clearly, quickly ran ahead
to pick the discus up, but the hard earth
made it bounce, and it hit him in the face.
The boy grew pale. So did Apollo, too.
He held your failing limbs, Hyacinthus,
and strove at times to bring your spirit back.
He also tried to stanch the grievous wound
and with his herbs to keep your soul inside,
as it was leaving. But all his expertise
had no effect. The wound could not be cured.
When someone in a garden breaks the stems

of lilies with bushy yellow stamens,
or of violets or poppies, the blooms
no longer stand erect, but quickly droop,
bowing their weakened heads, and their top parts
now gaze upon the ground. In just that way
the dying face of Hyacinthus sagged.
His weakened neck could not support his head,
which sank onto his shoulder. Phoebus said:

‘Son of Oebalus, you are now leaving me,
robbed of your early youth. I see your wound
and stand condemned. Because of you, I feel
both shame and sorrow. This right hand of mine
must be considered guilty of your death.
I am the one who took your life. But still,
how was I to blame, unless playing games
can be called a fault, unless my love for you
can be called a huge mistake? How I wish
that I could die with you or give you back
your life for mine! But I am bound by Fate.
Still, you will remain with me forever,
clinging to my lips as they remember.
The lyre my hand strikes and songs I sing
will ring out for you. And you will become
a brand new form of flower whose markings
imitate my cries of grief. The time will come
when the bravest hero will link himself
to this same flower and on its petals
men will read his name.’

While Apollo’s lips,
which do not lie, were uttering these words,
lo and behold, blood which was pouring out
across the ground, discolouring the grass,
was no longer blood. A flower sprang up
with a more brilliant tint than Tyrian dye
and a shape like lilies, but where a lily
is silvery white, this bloom was purple.
Apollo was the one responsible
for honouring Hyacinthus in this way,
but for the god that was not sufficient.
So he inscribed his own groans on the plant
and put the words *ai ai* on the flower,

HYACINTHUS IS TRANSFORMED

and there these mournful letters are inscribed.¹
Sparta is not ashamed that it gave birth
to Hyacinthus. They still honour him
today, and every year they celebrate
a festival in Hyacinthus' name,
based on set rituals from earlier times.

But if, by chance, you were to ask Amathus,
that mine-rich city, if it was happy
to be home to Propoetus' daughters,
it would renounce them. Those girls denied
that Venus was divine. Because of that
and because the goddess was enraged,
those women, according to what people say,
were the first to sell their reputations
and their bodies as public prostitutes.
But then, once they lost all sense of shame,
blood hardened in their cheeks, and a slight change
was enough to turn them into stony flint.

THE CERASTES

PROPOETUS' DAUGHTERS

Pygmalion saw these women's filthy lives
and was disgusted by the many vices
Nature had placed within the female mind.
So he lived a long time as a single man,
without a wife or partner for his bed.
Meanwhile, with astonishing skill he carved
a statue out of snow-white ivory,
a work of genius. He gave the form
beauty no mortal woman could possess
and fell in love with what he had produced.
She has a face just like a real young girl,
and you might well believe she is alive
and wishes to move, if her modesty
did not prevent her. So much artistry
lies hidden in his art. He is amazed,
and passion for this image of a body
eats at Pygmalion's heart. Often his hands
stroke the work, testing whether it is flesh
or ivory. He still does not concede
that it is stone. He kisses the statue
and imagines those kisses are returned.
He speaks to it, embraces it, and thinks,

PYGMALION

¹The words *ai ai* (or *aiai*) are the Greek word for *alas*.

when he holds onto a limb, his fingers
make an impression there and is afraid
he may bruise her flesh by pressing on it.
Sometimes he talks to her with flattery
and sometimes brings her presents girls might like—
sea shells and polished pebbles, little birds,
flowers with a thousand colours, painted beads,
and amber tears from Helios' daughters,
which drip from trees.¹ He also clothes her limbs,
puts gemstones on her fingers, and places
long necklaces around her throat. Smooth pearls
hang from her ears and pendants on her chest.
All things suit her, but when she has no clothes,
she seems no less attractive. This statue
Pygmalion places on a couch covered
with fabric dyed in Tyrian purple.
He calls her the companion of his bed
and cushions her reclining neck on pillows,
as if she were alive.

The day arrived
when throughout all Cyprus they celebrate
the most splendid festival of Venus.
Young heifers with gold on their growing horns
collapsed as axes struck their snow-white necks,
and burning incense smoked. Pygmalion,
having made his offering at the altar,
stood there and timidly spoke out:

‘If you gods
are able to grant anything, I wish
my wife could be . . .’

He did not dare to say

‘. . . my ivory girl,’

so he finished with:

‘. . . just like my girl carved out of ivory.’

¹The daughters of the Sun (sisters of Phaëton) were transformed into trees after Phaëton's death.

Golden Venus, who was there in person
at her festival, understood his prayer
and what he meant. She gave him a signal
the gods were well disposed—the altar fire
flared up three times, sending a spiky flame
into the air. Pygmalion went home
and hurried to the statue of his girl.
Leaning down over the couch, he kissed her.
She seemed warm, so he kissed her once again
and also felt her breast. Under his touch
the ivory lost its hardness, grew soft,
moved underneath his fingers, and gave way,
just as Hymettus wax softens in the sun
and, once men's fingers work it, can be formed
in many shapes, thus becoming useful
by being used. Pygmalion is amazed,
full of joy but also doubtful, afraid
he may be wrong. The lover's hands caress
the object of his love repeatedly.
It is a living body! When his thumb
presses on a vein, it throbs! Then indeed,
Pygmalion of Paphos in his mind
uttered the most fulsome thanks to Venus,
with his mouth still firmly pressed against those lips
that were no longer stone. The living girl
felt his kisses and blushed. Lifting her eyes
timidly up to the sunlight, she saw
her lover and the heavens both at once.
The goddess was present at the marriage
she had brought about, and when the moon's horns
had nine times formed a perfect circle,
Pygmalion's wife bore a son called Paphos,
from whom the island now derives its name.

This Paphos had a son named Cinyras,
who could have been considered fortunate
if he had had no children.

I will now sing
of horrifying events. You daughters,
keep far away from here and parents, too.
Or if my song does captivate your heart,
do not accept my story, and assume
it is not true. Or, if you do believe it,

CINYRAS AND MYRRHA

believe also how the act was punished.
But if nature apparently allows
such things, I am happy that this land
lies at a great distance from those regions
where such appalling wickedness was born.(22)
Let Panchaeon land be rich in balsam
and have its cinnamon and costmary,
its incense oozing from the trees and blooms
of different kinds—none of that is worth it,
if it still produces myrrh, for the cost
of that new tree was much too great.

Myrrha,
Cupid himself denies that you were struck
by an arrow from his bow and says his flames
played no part in your crime. It was a Fury,
one of those three sisters with bloated snakes
and firebrands from the Styx, who breathed on you.
To hate one's father is a wicked thing,
but love like yours is a more heinous crime.
Distinguished princes of every country
desire your hand, and from all eastern lands
young men have come competing for your bed.
Pick out a man from all of these, Myrrha,
to be your husband, and make sure one man,
your father, is not included with them.
Myrrha, in fact, senses this and fights back,
trying to conquer her repugnant love.
She tells herself:

‘Where is my mind taking me?
What am I trying to do? O you gods,
I pray to you and to the natural ties
and sacred laws of parents, you must stop
this wickedness and keep me from my crime.
If it truly is a crime. One could say
natural affections do not rule out
a love like this, for other animals,
when they have sex, do not discriminate.
When a heifer has her father mount her,
there is no disgrace, and a horse will take
his daughter for a wife, goats will couple
with goats who are their offspring, and birds
with other birds whose seed created them.

How happy they are, that they can do this!
But human worry has imposed harsh laws,
and jealous regulations now forbid
what nature tolerates. Still, people say
races exist where mothers wed their sons
and daughters are married to their fathers,
where natural affection is increased
by double bonds of love. I feel so sad
I was not born there and have to suffer,
because, with my bad luck, I live elsewhere!
But why do I keep going over this?
I must get rid of these forbidden feelings!
He deserves my love, but as a father.
If I were not great Cinyras' daughter,
then I could go to bed with him. But now,
I cannot have him, because he is mine
already—his very closeness to me
is my downfall. If I were a stranger,
I could do more. I would happily leave
and travel a long distance from this place,
if I could just escape this guilty love.
But a malicious passion holds me back.
By staying here I can see Cinyras,
touch him, talk to him, kiss him, even if
those are the only things I am allowed.
You wicked girl, what more can you expect?
Do you have any idea how much
you're mixing up established bonds and names?
Do you wish to be your mother's rival
and your father's whore? Will people call you
your child's sister and your brother's mother?
Are you not terrified of the Furies,
those sisters with black serpents in their hair?
People with wicked hearts see them attack
their eyes and face with savage torches.
But while your body still remains unstained,
do not corrupt your mind or violate
great Nature's laws with such forbidden sex!
Yes, you want to, but your circumstances
rule that out. He is an honorable man
and follows what is right. But how I wish
he felt inside a passion like my own.'

She says this to herself. Meanwhile, Cinyras,
faced with a large crowd of noble suitors,
is not sure what to do. He lists their names
and asks her which one she wants to marry.
Myrrha at first says nothing and just gazes
at her father's face. In her confusion,
her eyes fill with warm tears. So Cinyras,
thinking this a sign of virgin shyness,
tells her to stop crying, dries off her cheeks,
and kisses her. Myrrha is delighted
with his kiss, too much so, and when he asks
what sort of husband she would like to have,
she says:

‘One just like you.’

But her father,
not realizing what she means, praises her
and says:

‘Always be this loving to me.’

As he utters that word ‘loving,’ Myrrha,
aware of her own guilt, stares at the ground.
It was now midnight, and sleep had released
men's bodies from their cares. But the young girl,
Cinyras' daughter, was wide awake,
consumed by passion she could not suppress.
She thought again about her wild desires,
sometimes in despair and sometimes ready
to sound her father out. She was ashamed,
yet keen to try, unable to decide
what she should do. Just as a massive tree
struck by an axe, with one last blow to come,
leaves men in doubt where it will fall and causes
fear on every side, so her shifting mind,
struck by contradictory feelings, wavered,
swayed here and there, blown in two directions.
She could see no final end to how she felt,
no rest from her desires, other than death.
She made up her mind to die. So she got up,
resolved to tie a noose and hang herself.
She fixed some clothing above the doorway
and said:

‘Farewell, beloved Cinyras.
Understand the reason for my death!’

These words
muttered to herself, so people say, reach
the ears of her faithful nurse, keeping watch
at the threshold of the girl she cares for.
The old woman gets up, opens the door,
sees what Myrrha has done to harm herself,
and screams. Then, all in the same instant,
she strikes her breast, tears her robe, removes
the clothes from Myrrha’s neck, and rips them up.
Only after that does she have time to weep,
embrace the girl, and ask about the noose.
Myrrha stands there without saying a word,
eyes gazing at the ground. She is upset
she was so slow in trying to kill herself
and has been discovered. The old woman
starts questioning her. Baring her white hair
and withered breasts, she keeps begging Myrrha,
by her cradle and her first nourishment,
to tell her what is causing her such grief.
Myrrha turns away and groans. But the nurse,
determined to find out, then promises
she will do more than not betray her trust.
She says:

‘Tell me, and let me be of help.
I may be old, but I am not useless.
If it is some fit, I have herbs and charms
with healing force. If a man has harmed you,
I can cleanse you with a magic ritual.
If gods are angry, they can be appeased
with sacred offerings. I can’t imagine
what else it could be. Your house’s fortunes
are certainly secure and will remain so,
with your mother and your father still alive.’

When Myrrha heard that word ‘father,’ she sighed
from the bottom of her heart. Even then,
the old nurse had no notion of the act
she had in mind. But still, she did assume
the young girl’s anguish had to do with love.

She kept entreating Myrrha, begging her
to let her know, no matter what it was.
Clutching the weeping girl against her breast,
her trembling arms embraced her, and she said:

‘I know what the matter is—you are in love!
And in this my readiness to help you
will be of service. You need have no fear.
Your father will never know a thing.’

Myrrha was frantic. She pushed herself away
from the nurse’s arms and, pressing her face
into the bed, she cried:

‘Get out of here.
I’m begging you. Spare me the wretched shame.’

When the nurse insisted, Myrrha shouted:

‘Either go away or stop asking me
why I feel such pain. What you want to know
is an immoral crime.’

The old woman
felt a twinge of dread. She stretched out her hands,
shaking with age and fear, and fell down
at Myrrha’s feet, just like a suppliant.
She tried coaxing and then frightening her
with what might happen if she did not tell,
threatening to speak out about the noose
and her attempt to kill herself. She swore
to help, if she would tell her of her love.
Myrrha raised her head. From her weeping eyes
the tears dripped down onto the nurse’s breast.
She tried repeatedly to confess her love,
but then would stop herself and hide her face
inside her clothing, too ashamed to speak.
All she said was:

‘Mother is so fortunate
to have the husband she is married to.’

And then she groaned. A cold tremor ran through
the nurse’s limbs and bones, for now she knew

what Myrrha meant. Across her entire head
the old white hair bristled and stood on end.
She talked at length to Myrrha, telling her
she should get rid of such a fatal love,
if she could do it. The young girl understood
the advice was sound, but was still resolved
to die if she could not have the one she loved.
So the old nurse told her:

‘Go on living,
and enjoy your . . .’

Not daring to say ‘father,’
she fell silent. But then she swore an oath
to the gods to validate her promise.

Pious married women were now holding
the annual festival of Ceres,
where they dress their bodies in white robes
and offer as first fruits of harvest time
garlands made from ears of grain. For nine nights
they consider sex and all contact with men
forbidden. Cinyras’ wife, Cenchreis,
was a member of that group, participating
in the sacred rites, and thus the king’s bed
lacked its rightful occupant. When the nurse
noticed Cinyras drunk from too much wine,
she informed him, with misplaced eagerness,
there was a girl truly passionate for him.
She gave her a false name and praised her beauty.
When the king asked how old the girl might be,
the nurse replied:

‘The same age as Myrrha.’

Cinyras told her to bring the girl to him.
The nurse returned back home and said to Myrrha:

‘Rejoice, my dear child. We have won the day!’

The girl was not completely overjoyed.
Her prophetic heart sensed future sorrow.
But still, there was such conflict in her mind
she did feel thrilled, as well.

The time has come
when everything is quiet—the Boötes
has turned his wagon with its slanting pole
between the Bears. Myrrha is preparing
to commit her dreadful act. The golden moon
flees from the heavens, and dark clouds conceal
the hidden stars. Night lacks its fires. Three time
a sign makes Myrrha falter, when she stumbles,
and three times the funereal screech owl
gives out an ominous shriek of warning.
She still keeps moving. Black night and shadows
lessen her shame. In her left hand she grips
the nurse, while with her right she gropes her way
through total darkness. And now she is there,
on the threshold, and opening the door.
Now she is being led into the room.
Her knees threaten to give way beneath her,
her blood and colour disappear, her spirit
fails as she moves on. The closer she gets
to her great crime, the more she feels afraid.
She regrets what she is doing and wishes
she could go back without being recognized.
As she pauses, the old nurse takes her arm,
leads her to the high bed, hands her over,
thus joining two doomed bodies, and then says:

“Take this young girl, Cinyras. She is yours.”

The father welcomes his own flesh and blood
into his incestuous bed, soothing
her virgin fears and encouraging her
when she is frightened. And it may well be
he even calls her ‘daughter’ to suit her age,
while Myrrha addresses him as ‘father,’
two names appropriate to their foul crime.

After having sex with her own father,
Myrrha left the room. In her corrupt womb
full of incestuous seed, she carried
a burden she had criminally conceived.
The next night they once again committed
the guilty act, and they did not stop there.
But after having sex so many times,

Cinyras at length was eager to find out
who his lover was. So he brought in a light,
recognized his daughter and his own guilt,
and, in such pain he could not say a word,
pulled a gleaming sword out of the scabbard
in which it hung. Myrrha fled, saved from death
by the gift of night and pitch-black shadows.

Wandering through wide fields, she moved beyond
the Arabian palm trees and Panchaea
for nine full cycles of the crescent moon
until, at last worn out, she stopped to rest
in Sabaeon land. By now, the burden
in her womb was getting difficult to bear.
Weary with life and yet afraid of death,
not knowing what to wish for, she uttered
the following prayer:

MYRRHA IS TRANSFORMED

‘O, if any of you gods
listens to those who are truly penitent,
I am not seeking to excuse myself,
for I deserve this cruel punishment.
But in case, by staying alive, I pollute
the living or, by dying, harm the dead,
drive me from both realms by altering me
and robbing me of both my life and death.’

Some deity attends to those who pray,
for some god clearly hears her final plea.
While she is speaking, earth covers her legs,
roots shoot out sideways through her breaking nails,
growing a solid base for a tall trunk,
her bones grow stronger and, in the centre,
the blood still in her marrow turns to sap.
Her arms become large branches, her fingers
small ones, and her skin hardens into bark.
A tree has grown around her heavy womb,
and covered her breasts, and is preparing
to spread across her neck. She cannot wait
and, leaning down to meet the rising wood,
buries her face in bark. Though she has lost
her body and the senses she once had,
she keeps on weeping still, and the warm drops
drip down the tree. But with these tears of hers

she wins great fame, for the myrrh that trickles
down the bark still bears its mistress' name,
which men will hear in every future age.

But underneath the bark, that infant child
her incest had conceived has grown to term
and now is searching for a passageway
where he might crawl out and leave his mother.
Inside the tree, the pregnant womb swells up.
The burden strains the mother, but her pains
have no words of their own. She lacks a voice
to call Lucina in her labour pangs.¹
But the tree is like a person struggling
to be delivered—it groans frequently,
bends over, and is wet with falling tears.
Kind Lucina stands beside the branches,
as they cry in pain, rubs them with her hands,
and murmurs phrases to bring on the birth.
The tree cracks open and through the splitting bark
gives up its living burden, a crying child.
The naiads set him down on the soft grass
and then anoint him with his mother's tears.
Even Envy would have praised his beauty.
He looked like one of those naked bodies
of painted Cupids, except to make them
both alike you would have to take away
their quivers or else give him a small one.

BIRTH OF ADONIS

Winged time glides past before we notice
and tricks us, for nothing moves more quickly
than the passing years. That young infant child,
son of his own sister and her father,
not long ago encased inside a tree,
that most beautiful boy born yesterday,
is now a youthful lad, and now a man,
even finer looking than he was before,
so much so he wins the love of Venus.
Young Cupid, while carrying his quiver,
gave his mother a kiss, and, by accident,
one of his arrows which was sticking out
scratched her breast. Venus pushed her son away,
but the wound she had received was deeper

VENUS AND ADONIS

¹Lucina is the goddess of childbirth.

than it looked, more than she first recognized.
Now captivated by a human form,
she does not care about Cytherian shores,
or visit Paphos, her sea-girt island, [530]
or Cnidos, rich in fish, or Amathus,
with its wealthy ores. She even avoids
the heavens, for she prefers Adonis
to the sky. She holds him, remains with him
as his companion, and though her custom
is constantly to linger in the shade
and, by cultivating her own beauty,
to enhance it, now she travels with him
over mountain ridges and through forests,
across shrub-covered rocks, with knees exposed
and her clothes hitched up, just like Diana.
She urges on the hounds and even hunts
wild beasts considered safe to chase as prey—
swift-running hares, stags with huge horns, or deer.
But she avoids ferocious boars and shuns
rapacious wolves, bears with claws, and lions,
who gorge themselves on cattle herds they kill.
She warns you to fear these beasts, Adonis,
as if her warnings would have some effect:

‘Be brave against the ones that run away,
for boldness which confronts a bold wild beast
is just not safe. Do not be rash, my boy.
Spare me the danger. Do not chase the brutes
whom nature has fitted out with weapons,
in case your glory comes at my expense.
Your youth and beauty and those other things
which Venus finds delightful will not charm
bristling boars and lions or eyes and minds
of savage beasts. In those curved tusks of theirs
wild boars have lightning, and tawny lions
display a boundless fury when they charge.
How I hate that tribe.’

When Adonis asked
the reason why she felt that way, she said:

‘I will tell you, and you will be amazed
at the strange result of a wrongful act
committed long ago. But I am tired.

I am not used to all this exercise.
Look, that poplar tree is beckoning us
with welcoming shade, and the green turf there
will serve us as a bed. I wish to rest
on the ground right here, with you beside me.'

She stretched out, pressing against the grass and him,
her neck reclining on the young man's chest,
and, as she spoke, she mixed her words with kisses:

'You may perhaps have heard about a girl
who in a race could beat the fastest men.
That story was not just a foolish tale—
in any contest she outran them all.
But it was hard to tell if her fast pace
deserved more praise than her great beauty.
Once she asked a god about a husband,
and the god replied:

ATALANTA AND HIPPOMENES

'You do not need a man,
Atalanta. For you, getting married
is something to avoid. But nonetheless,
you will not escape it and, while still alive,
will lose yourself.'

What the god prophesied
scared Atalanta, so she lived her life
in shady forests and did not get married.
She escaped the crowds of eager suitors
by demanding very harsh conditions:

'No one will wed me, until a suitor
beats me in a race. So run against me.
To the swift will go a wife and wedding.
For the slow the prize is death. On those terms,
let the contests start!'

Yes, she was cruel,
but the power of beauty is so great,
many men agreed to the rule she set
and courted her. At one unequal race
Hippomenes looked on from where he sat
and asked himself:

‘Why would anyone
seek out a wife at such enormous risk?’

He found the young men’s passion foolish
and excessive. But when he saw her face
and her unclothed body—one like my own,
Adonis, or yours, if you were female—
he was amazed. Raising his hands, he said:

‘Those of you I criticized just now,
forgive me. When I spoke, I did not know
you were competing for a prize like this.’

By praising her, he lights a fire of love,
and when his jealousy has made him tense,
he prays that none of those young challengers
will beat Atalanta. And then he says:

‘But in this contest why not try my luck?
A daring man will get help from the gods.’

While he is reflecting on this question,
Atalanta races past on feet like wings.
To the young Boeotian, she seems to fly
with all the speed of a Scythian arrow,
but her beauty astounds him even more.
On her swift feet the facing breeze blows back
her sandal straps, her hair is thrown across
her ivory shoulders, embroidered ribbons
flutter below her knees, and a blush spreads
across the girlish whiteness of her flesh,
just as a purple awning spread across
white hallways colours them a different shade.
While the stranger is noticing all this,
the final lap is over. The winner,
Atalanta, receives a festive crown.
The losers groan and pay the penalty,
as they have promised. But Hippomenes,
undeterred by the fate of these young men,
steps forward and, looking right at the girl,
calls out:

‘Why seek to win an easy crown
defeating sluggards? Why not race with me?’

If fortune gives me strength enough to win,
you will not be ashamed to be defeated
by such a worthy man, for my father
was Megareus, son of Onchestius,
whose grandfather was Neptune. So I am
great-grandson of the ruler of the seas.
My courage is as noble as my race.
And if I lose, you will have overcome
Hippomenes and thus have won yourself
a great and famous name.'

As he spoke these words,
the daughter of Schoeneus looked at him
with a sympathetic face, uncertain
whether she would prefer to win or lose.
She murmured:

'What god so despises beauty,
he wishes to destroy this man and tells him
to seek marriage and risk his precious life?
In my own view, I am not worth that much.
It is not his handsome form which moves me
(though I could be influenced by that, as well),
but the fact that the youth is still so young.
It is his age which makes me sensitive,
not the man himself. What of his courage
and his heart, which is not afraid of death?
By his descent is he not fourth in line
from the god who rules the seas? And besides,
does he not love me and think our marriage
so important he would die, if harsh fate
denied me to him? While you can, stranger,
go away! Leave these bloody courtship rites!
A match with me is cruel. No woman
would be reluctant to become your wife.
A girl with sense would welcome such a chance.
But why should I concern myself with you,
when many others have already perished?
Let him look to himself! And let him die,
if he will not be deterred by the deaths
of all those suitors and is pushed to it
by weariness with life. Will he die, then,
because he wished to share his life with me,
and suffer death, which he does not deserve,

as a reward for love? If I prevail,
people will hate me for my victory.
But that is not my fault! I wish you'd stop,
or, if you are mad to do this, I wish
you might run faster. Look at that young face,
those boyish features, like a virgin girl!
Alas, poor Hippomenes, how I wish
you had not seen me! You deserved to live!
If I had had more luck, if grievous fate
did not hold me back from marriage, then you
would be the one I'd want to share my bed.'

She finished. Like an inexperienced girl
feeling her first twinge of sexual desire
and unaware what she is doing, she loves,
but does not realize she is in love.

Now, as her father and the people cried
to have the usual race, Hippomenes,
Neptune's descendant, prayed to me,
begging for my help:

'O Cytherea,
I entreat you to look on me with favour
in this risky contest. Nourish those flames
which you yourself have lit.'

A gentle breeze
carried his flattering request to me.
I admit it moved me. So without delay
I offered him my help. There is a field,
the finest piece of land in all of Cyprus.
The natives call it Tamasus. Long ago,
their elders consecrated it to me
and gave instructions it should be a gift
added to my temples. A tree grows there,
right in the middle of the field. Its leaves
are gleaming yellow, and its branches rustle
with golden yellow fruit. As it so chanced,
I had just left that tree and in my hand
I held three golden apples I had picked.
And so I went up to Hippomenes,
hiding myself from everyone but him,
and told him how he should use the apples.

THE GOLDEN APPLES

The trumpets gave the signal. Both runners
leaned out and raced off from the starting line.
Their flying feet skimmed the surface of the sand.
You could imagine them speeding over
ocean waves without moistening their feet
or racing over ears of standing grain.
The young man's spirits were stirred up by shouts
and the crowd's support, as they all cried:

‘Now, now, Hippomenes! This is the time
to push ahead! Right now with all your strength!
Don't hold back! You'll win the race!’

It was not clear
which one was happier to hear these words,
Hippomenes or Atalanta. How often,
when she could have passed him, did she slow down,
gaze at his face a while, and move on by
against her will! He was gasping for air,
his throat parched, with the end still far away.
At that moment, Hippomenes tossed out
ahead of her one of the three apples
taken from the tree. She was astonished.
Keen to have the shining apple, she swerved,
ran off course, and picked up the rolling gold.
Hippomenes sped past her. Those looking on
applauded wildly. But she raced ahead,
making up for her delay, and once more
left the youth behind. Then she was held up
by a second apple. But she ran on
and passed him yet again. There still remained
the last part of the race. The young man prayed:

‘O goddess, you who offered me this gift,
stand by me now!’

With all his youthful strength,
he tossed the shining gold off to the side,
far into the field, so Atalanta
would require more time to run and get it.
She was not sure if she should chase the fruit,
but I forced her to pick it up and then,
once she had it, I made it heavier.
So I slowed her down with the apple's weight

and by the time she wasted getting it.
Well, to stop my story lasting longer
than the race itself, Atalanta lost,
and the man who triumphed led away his prize.

Surely I deserved his thanks, Adonis,
and a tribute offering of incense?
But he forgot. I got no thanks from him
or any incense. I felt a sudden rage—
his contempt annoyed me. So to make sure
I would not be slighted in the future,
I took care to make them an example
and stirred myself to move against the pair.

The two of them were going past a shrine
hidden in a forest grove, a temple
which famous Echion built long ago
for the mother of the gods, to fulfill
a promise he had made. Their lengthy trip
convinced them they should stop there for a rest.
My godlike power roused Hippomenes
so he was keen to make love with his wife,
although the time was not appropriate.
Near that temple was shady hollow,
like a cave, with a natural stone roof,
a place sacred to the old religion,
in which the priest had gathered images,
many wooden figures of ancient gods.
Hippomenes went in this holy place
and polluted it with forbidden sex.
The sacred figures turned their eyes away,
and Cybele, great mother of the gods,
in her turreted crown, was wondering
whether she should plunge the guilty couple
deep in the waters of the river Styx.
But that punishment seemed insufficient.
And so a tawny mane covered their necks,
which had been so smooth before, their fingers
bent into claws, their arms turned into legs.
Their entire weight is centered in their chests,
and their tails sweep the surface of the sand.
They have angry faces. Instead of words
they utter roars, and they roam the forest,
rather than the rooms of their own home.

As lions, they are terrifying to others,
but, once subdued by Cybele, their jaws
bite down quite tamely on her chariot bit.

So Adonis, my love, avoid those beasts
and along with them all savage creatures
which do not flee but stick out their chests
and stand prepared to fight. If you do not,
your courage will be fatal to us both.'

Venus gave this warning to Adonis,
harnessed her swans, and flew off through the air.
But his courage disagreed with her advice.

Now, it happened that his dogs were tracking
the clear trail of a boar and roused the beast,
which left its den and was getting ready
to charge out from the trees, when Adonis
struck it from the side. Instantly the beast
dislodged the hunting spear stained with its blood
and chased Adonis, who was terrified
and looked for somewhere safe. But the wild beast
sank its sharp tusks deep in the young man's groin
and threw him down onto the yellow sand,
where he lay dying.

As she moved through the air
in her light chariot drawn by flying swans,
Cythera, still on her way to Cyprus,
heard his dying groans from a long way off,
and turned the white birds back towards him.
When, from high up in the sky, she saw him
lying dead, body soaked in his own blood,
she jumped down, tore her clothing and her hair,
and with frantic hands pounded on her breast,
as she protested to the Fates, saying:

ADONIS IS TRANSFORMED

'But not everything is in your power!
Adonis, memorials of my sorrow
will remain forever, and every year
the image of your death will be performed
and give a re-enactment of my grief.
I will change your blood into a flower.
For if Persephone was once allowed

to change a woman into fragrant mint,
will I be begrudged the transformation
of a courageous son of Cinyras?’

After saying this, she sprinkled the blood
with sweet-scented nectar, which, on contact,
made the blood froth up, the way clear bubbles
rise in yellow mud. Before an hour passed,
a flower grew there, the colour of blood,
a bloom like pomegranates bear, that fruit
which hides its seed beneath a hardened skin.
But one cannot enjoy this flower long,
for its petals are attached so lightly,
in gusts of wind they quickly fly away,
and from those winds the flower gets its name,
for people call it the anemone.”

While with songs like these the Thracian poet
was making trees, rocks, and wild creature’s hearts
all follow him, lo and behold, from a hilltop
the frenzied women of the Cicones,
with skins of savage beasts draped on their breasts,
caught sight of Orpheus playing his lyre,
accompanying his songs with music.
One of them, whose hair was being blown back
by the gentle breezes, screamed:

“Look! Down there!
It’s him—the man who has rejected women!”

She hurled her spear at Apollo’s poet,
while he was in the middle of a song.
But the spear had leaves wrapped around the point,
and so it made a mark but left no wound.
Another woman threw a rock at him,
but while the stone was flying through the air,
it was overpowered by the harmonies
of his voice and lyre and fell at his feet,
as if it were begging his forgiveness
for such a rash assault. But after that
the mad attacks increased, and all restraint
was gone—the frenzied Furies took control.
His songs would have made all weapons harmless,
but loud noises from Berecyntian flutes

of curving horn, the din of tambourines,
as well as beating hands and Bacchic chants,
drowned out the music Orpheus was playing,
and finally the rocks turned red with blood,
for now the poet's song could not be heard.
First the women rip apart those creatures
still captivated by the singer's voice—
countless birds, snakes, and throngs of savage beasts—
that audience which made the poet famous.
And then they lay their bloody hands on him,
crowding together, like those birds who glimpse
the night owl roaming in the light of day,
or like the dogs in amphitheatre sand
at a morning show in the arena,
when they throng around the body of a stag
who is doomed to become their prey and die.
That's how those women go at Orpheus,
hurling their leafy thyrsus stems, not made
for such a purpose. Some throw lumps of earth,
others toss branches they have torn from trees,
and others flint stones. **Their insane attack
does not lack weapons, for it so happens
some oxen have been working on the soil,
hauling a plough, and not far away from there
burly farmers are digging up tough ground,
sweating hard, and getting their fields ready
to plant the grain. But when they see that mob,
they run away and leave their tools behind.
Long mattocks, hoes, and heavy rakes lie there,
scattered across the empty fields. The women,
in their frantic state, get their hands on these,
and, once they have torn apart the oxen,
whose horns are menacing them, hurry back
to kill the poet.** Stretching out his arms,
Orpheus speaks, but now, for the first time,
his voice is useless and has no effect.
Those sacrilegious women rip him up,
and through those lips which stones have listened to
and senses of wild beasts have understood—
O Jupiter!—the soul of Orpheus
slips away and vanishes in the winds.
The grieving birds, the crowds of savage beasts,
the flinty rocks and woods, which so often
followed your songs, wept for you, Orpheus.

Trees shed their leaves and, with their crowns now bare,
 grieved at your death, and rivers, too, men say,
 were swollen with their tears. Naiads and dryads,
 their hair unkempt, put on dark mourning clothes.
 The poet's scattered limbs lay everywhere.
 You, Hebrus, received his head and lyre,
 and (what is amazing!) as they floated
 down the middle of the stream, the lyre
 sounded some kind of doleful melody,
 the lifeless tongue intoned a sad lament,
 and river banks echoed the plaintive song.
 And then, carried down to the sea, they left
 their native stream and were tossed up onshore
 on Lesbos at Methymna. Here the head,
 as it lay on that foreign beach exposed,
 with its dishevelled hair still dripping wet,
 was assaulted by a ferocious snake.
 But as the beast was just about to bite,
 Phoebus finally appeared and stopped it.
 He froze the striking creature's open jaws
 and, in that posture, hardened it to stone.

The shade of Orpheus moved underground
 and recognized the places he had seen
 on his earlier trip. He set out searching
 in fields of the blessed for Eurydice,
 his wife, and when he came across her there,
 he held her in his eager arms. And now,
 they wander side by side together.
 Sometimes he follows as she walks in front.
 At other times he strolls ahead of her
 and, since the action is quite safe, looks back
 to gaze upon his own Eurydice.

MIDAS¹

[Bacchus left] the land of Thrace, and with a group
 of celebrants visited the vineyards
 of his own Mount Tmolus and the waters
 of the Pactolus river. The usual throng
 went with him, Bacchic worshippers and satyrs,
 except for Silenus, who had been seized

MIDAS AND SILENUS

¹This passage begins in 11.126 of Ovid's poem.

by Phrygians, as he staggered along,
tottering from age and wine.¹ Those peasants
chained him in wreaths of flowers and led him
to king Midas, a man who had been taught
the Bacchic mysteries by Orpheus
and by Eumolpus, a man from Athens.
Midas recognized him as a comrade,
his associate in the sacred rites,
and was pleased to honour the arrival
of his guest with joyful celebrations
which lasted ten successive days and nights.
On the eleventh day, once Lucifer
had ushered out the distant ranks of stars,
Midas happily set out for Lydia,
where he gave Silenus back to Bacchus,
the satyr's youthful foster child. The god,
pleased to have Silenus returned to him,
gave Midas, as a favour, the chance to ask
for any gift—a fine offer, but wasted,
for Midas made poor use of this reward.
He said:

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MIDAS AND BACCHUS

“Make all things my body touches
change to yellow gold.”

Since this was his choice,
Bacchus consented and granted Midas
the harmful gift, sorry he had not asked
for something better. However, the king
from Berecynthia was happy as he left,
joyful in his misfortune. He tested
his belief in what Bacchus had conveyed
by touching various things and, when he did,
could hardly comprehend the things he saw.
When on an oak he snaps a green twig off
a lower branch, the twig is changed to gold.
If he picks any rock up from the ground,
it, too, becomes pale gold, and when he grasps
a clod of earth, the power of his touch
turns it into a lump of yellow metal.
He gathers in dry ears of Ceres' grain,

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MIDAS' GOLDEN TOUCH

¹Silenus was an older companion and tutor to Bacchus, the god of wine. Midas was a king in Phrygia (modern day Turkey).

and they become a harvest of pure gold.
He holds an apple taken from a tree,
and you would think he has received the fruit
of the Hesperides. When his fingers touch
tall pillars by the door, they seem to glow,
and if he dips his hands in running streams,
Danaë herself could well have been seduced
by the liquid gold flowing past his palms.¹
Midas has trouble holding back the dreams
now active in his mind, for he imagines
all things turned to gold. As he rejoices,
his servants set tables out before him
loaded with rich amounts of meat and bread.
But if he puts his hand on Ceres' gifts,
the bread grows hard. If his hungry jaws
attempt to chew the meat, when his teeth touch,
a golden yellow plating coats his food.
And when he drinks pure water mixed with wine,
a present from the very god who gave him
his new gift, you see a golden liquid
flowing in his mouth. This strange disaster
fills Midas with dismay. For all his wealth,
he is a wretched man. He wants to flee
from all his riches and now despises
the very things he recently desired.
No supply of food relieves his hunger,
his throat is burning with a parching thirst,
and he is plagued, as he deserves to be,
by the gold he now detests. He stretches
his shining hands and arms up to the skies
and cries:

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“Forgive me, father Bacchus.
I have sinned. But pity me, I beg you.
Save me from this gift which seemed so fine!”

The will of the gods is kind. Once Midas
had confessed his fault, Bacchus restored him
and took back the present he had given
to fulfill his promise. He told Midas:

¹ The Hesperides were three divine nymphs of the evening and western regions. They took care of a tree whose fruit was golden apples. Danaë was tricked by Jupiter, who had sex with her in the form of a shower of gold.

“To make sure you are no longer covered
with gold, as you so foolishly desired,
go to great Sardis, to the river there,
and make your way across the shining ridge.
Keep going upstream to the river’s source,
then plunge your head and body both at once
right where the spring is frothing up the most,
and, as you do that, wash away your crime.”

Midas went to the spring, as he was told.
When the golden force moved from his human flesh
and passed into the spring, its colour stained
the waters of the stream, and even today,
the lands absorbing grains from this old source
gleam and harden in those spots where water
flowing in the river soaks into the soil.

Midas now hated wealth and spent his time
in fields and woods and mountain caves, where Pan
is always present. But his wits remained
as stupid as before, and his foolish mind
was doomed to hurt its owner once again.

Tmolus, a towering, rugged mountain
with panoramic views out to the sea
has one flank extending down to Sardis
and another reaching tiny Hypaepae.
Pan is there, boasting to some gentle nymphs
about his songs and playing a modest tune
on a pipe of reeds held in place by wax.
He dares to demean Apollo’s music
in comparison with his own. And thus,
it comes to an unequal competition
in which Tmolus will select the winner.
The ancient judge sits on his mountainside
and shakes his ears to rid them of their trees.
The only thing he wears in his dark hair
is a wreath of oak, with acorns hanging
by his hollow temples. He looks at Pan,
the god of flocks, and says:

APOLLO AND PAN

“No need to wait.
It’s time to judge.”

Pan plays his rustic pipes,
and his wild tune fills Midas with delight
(he happens to be there, close by the music).
After that, sacred Tmolus turns his head
towards Apollo's face and, as he turns,
his forests follow. Around his golden head
Phoebus wears a wreath of Parnassus laurel.
His garments, dyed with Tyrian purple,
sweep along the ground. In his left hand
he holds his lyre, inlaid with gemstones
and Indian ivory, and in his right
a plectrum. The very way he holds himself
proclaims the artist. Then he plucks the strings
with skilful fingers, and his sweet music
captivates Tmolus, who then orders Pan
to hold his pipes inferior to the lyre.
The verdict of the holy mountain god
delighted all of them, except for Midas.
He was the only one to disagree
and say it was unfair. The Delian god
could not allow such foolish ears to keep
their human shape, and so he stretched them out,
filled them with white hairs, made them flexible
at the base, and gave them power to move.
Midas was human in his other parts,
but in this one feature he was punished,
for he now carried plodding asses' ears.

APOLLO AND MIDAS

Midas was anxious to conceal this change
and tried to mitigate his own disgrace
with a purple turban around his head.
But a servant, the one who trimmed his hair
with iron scissors, saw what the god had done.
Though he was keen to tell what he had seen,
he did not dare divulge such shameful news.
But still, he could not keep it to himself.
So he went off alone, scooped out the earth,
and in a whisper told the empty pit
the kind of ears he had seen on Midas.
He pushed the soil in place again and buried
the news he had disclosed, then filled the pit
and crept away in silence. But a thick patch
of trembling reeds began to sprout up there,

and in a year, when they were now full grown,
they gave away the man who dug the hole.
For when the gentle South Wind stirs those reeds,
they repeat the words the servant buried
and tell the truth about his master's ears.¹

HECUBA²

Troy was on fire,
and the flames had not yet been extinguished.
Jupiter's altar was still soaking up
the meagre streams of ancient Priam's blood.
Apollo's priestess, hauled out by the hair,
was holding up her arms in a vain plea
to heaven, and the victorious Greeks
were dragging away the women of Troy,
an enviable prize, as the women,
while they still could, kept gathering in crowds
inside the burning temples, still clutching
their paternal gods. Infant Astyanax
was hurled down to his death from those same towers
where he often watched his father Hector.
Andromache, his mother, would point him out
as he was fighting on his child's behalf,
protecting his ancestral realm.

TROY IS DESTROYED

And now,
North Wind was urging Greeks to leave for home,
the sails were flapping in a friendly breeze,
and sailors said they had to take advantage
of the winds. The women of Troy all cried:

“Farewell, Troy. We are being taken away.”

They kissed the Trojan ground and left behind
their smoking homes. The last one to embark—

¹When the wind blows through them, the reeds say “Midas has asses' ears.”

² This passage begins at 13.666 of Ovid's poem. Hecuba was the wife of Priam, king of Troy.

a wretched sight!—was Hecuba. They found her surrounded by the tombs which held her sons, clinging to their graves and trying to kiss her children's bones. Ulysses dragged her off. But she opened up one grave and carried Hector's ashes with her, clutched to her breast, leaving a lock of hair on Hector's stone, a humble offering, her gray hair and tears.

Now, facing Phrygia and Trojan land,
there was a country where Bistonians lived
and Polymestor had a lavish palace.
Your father, Polydorus, sent you to him
to be brought up in secret, a long way
from the war going on in Troy. A wise plan,
if your father, Priam, had not sent you
with such wealth—a tempting prize, rich enough
to turn an avaricious man to crime.
So when the fortunes of the Trojans fell,
the wicked Thracian king picked up a sword
and drove it into Polydorus' throat—
into his foster child!—and after that,
as if he could get rid of his own crime
by throwing out the corpse, he climbed a rock
and hurled the lifeless body in the sea.

POLYDORUS AND POLYMESTOR

Agamemnon, son of Atreus, moored his fleet
on a beach in Thrace, waiting for calm seas
and more favourable winds. Suddenly
the ground split open, making a wide cleft,
and Achilles' ghost emerged, as massive
as he used to be in life. His face looked
threatening, like the expression he wore
the day he pulled his sword on Agamemnon
in that fierce and lawless confrontation.
He called out:

ACHILLES AND POLYXENA

“So, you Greeks, you're leaving.
You have forgotten me. Your gratitude
for my courageous acts you buried with me!
Do not let that happen! My funeral mound
must not lack its honours. So to appease

Achilles' shade, you Greeks must sacrifice
Polyxena, Priam's child."¹

His comrades
obeyed the orders of that ruthless ghost.
Though she was almost the only comfort
Hecuba still had, they tore Polyxena
from her mother's arms and led the young girl
to Achilles' burial site. She was strong,
in spite of her misfortune, and kept up
her courage, more than most women do.
But she became a victim, sacrificed
to a pitiless grave. As she stood there,
before the savage altar and witnessed
the harsh rites they were preparing for her,
she remembered she was Priam's daughter.
When she saw Achilles' son standing by,
gripping a sword, and staring at her face,
she said:

"Now shed this noble blood. You have
no need to wait. So plunge that sword of yours
deep in my throat or chest."

Here she exposed
her neck and breast.

"You may be sure of this—
Polyxena has no wish to be a slave
to any man, and this kind of ritual
will not appease the gods. I only wish
my mother would not hear about my death.
She worries me, diminishing my joy
in dying. And yet she should be mourning,
not my death, but her own life. Move off,
you men, so I may go to Stygian shades
in freedom, and if my prayer is just,
let no man set his hand on virgin flesh.
Whoever you are trying to appease

¹ Polyxena was the youngest daughter of Priam and Hecuba. In some accounts, she had been captured and befriended by Achilles, who told her about the one vulnerable spot on his body (his heel). Achilles had recently been killed by a poisoned arrow from Paris. It hit him in the heel in an ambush, when he was on his way to meet Polyxena.

by killing me will be more satisfied
with blood from someone free. If my last words
move any of you—and I am no slave
requesting this, but king Priam's daughter—
return my body with no ransom paid
back to my mother. For the mournful right
to have a tomb, let her pay, not with gold,
but with her tears. Back in earlier days,
when she still could, she used to pay in gold.”

Polyxena finished. She shed no tears.
The people did that for her. Even the priest
wept as he reluctantly plunged in the knife
and pierced the breast she offered up to him.
As her knees buckled, she fell to the ground,
but to the very end her face remained
quite fearless, and even as she collapsed,
she took great care to hide those parts of her
that should remain concealed and so maintained
the honour of her blameless modesty.

The Trojan women took up the body,
counting all the names of Priam's children
they had mourned and all the bloody killings
this one house had suffered. They grieved for you,
young virgin girl, and you, too, Hecuba.
Not long ago they called you a king's wife
and royal parent, the very image
of rich Asia, and now a worthless part
of captured spoils. Victorious Ulysses
would have refused to take you as his slave,
had you not given birth to noble Hector,
who had great trouble finding anyone
who wished to be his mother's master.

Hecuba embraced her daughter's body,
whose spirit, which had been so brave, was gone.
She shed tears over it, the very tears
she had so often wept for her own land,
her children, and her husband, pouring them
into the young girl's wound. She kissed her lips,
beat her chest, as she had done so frequently,
and trailed her gray hair in congealing blood.

HECUBA LAMENTS

She tore her breasts and cried out many things,
including this:

“O my child, you are
your mother’s final grief. What else is left?
My daughter lying here! I see your wound
as my own injury. Look here! This wound
was to make sure I did not lose one child
without some blood being spilled. Still, I thought
you, as a woman, would be spared the steel.
But now, even though you were a woman,
you have fallen to the sword. That same man
who slaughtered so many of your brothers
has killed you, too—Achilles, who ruined Troy
and left me childless. After that man fell
to those arrows of Paris and Apollo,
I said:

‘Now, at least, we no longer need
to fear Achilles.’

But even in death,
I should have feared him. His very ashes
in his tomb rage against our royal house.
Even from the grave we have felt his hate.
It was for Achilles that I gave birth
to all my children. And now mighty Troy
has fallen. The destruction of our state
has reached its bitter end. Still, it’s over.
For me alone Troy’s citadel yet stands.
My grief will run its course. Not long ago,
I was the greatest lady of them all,
thanks to my husband, my many children,
all those sons-in-law and daughters-in-law.
Now I am helpless, dragged into exile,
torn from my family’s burial mounds,
a gift for Ulysses’ wife, Penelope,
who will point me out to married women
in Ithaca, as I am spinning wool
she hands to me, and say:

‘This woman here
is Hector’s famous mother, Priam’s queen.’

After I had lost so many children,
you, Polyxena, were the only one
who would alleviate a mother's grief.
And now you have been made a sacrifice
at an enemy grave! I bore children
as sacrificial offerings for my foes!
And yet, like iron, I endure. But why?
Why am I still here? Why am I preserved
by lingering old age. You cruel gods,
why prolong the life of an old woman
who has lived so long, unless your purpose
is to have me witness still more funerals?
Who could have imagined Priam happy
once Pergamum fell? But he is happy
in his death! He did not see you butchered,
my child, for he left his life and kingdom
both at the same time. I assumed that you,
a royal child, would have rich burial rites,
your body placed in our ancestral tombs.
But that is not the fortune of this house.
Your funeral gifts will be a mother's tears
and a pile of foreign sand! We have lost
everything. The only child remaining
is Polydorus, once the youngest son
of our family line, and now a reason
for me to go on living for a while.
We sent him to these shores, entrusting him
to Polymestor's care, a Thracian king.
But why waste all my time with these laments?
I should rinse your savage wound with water
and wash away those dreadful spots of blood
splashed across your face."

Hecuba said this,
and shuffled off, with an old woman's gait,
down to the sea shore, pulling her white hair.
She cried:

"You Trojan women, fetch a jug!"

The poor woman wanted to draw water
from the sea. But there by the shore she saw
Polydorus' body thrown up on the beach
with gaping cuts from blades of Thracian swords.

HECUBA AND POLYMESTOR

The Trojan women screamed, but Hecuba
was dumb with grief. Pain had swallowed her voice
and dried the tears drops welling in her eyes.
She stood still, like impenetrable rock.
At times she fixed her eyes down at the ground,
or raised her haggard face up to the sky.
Then she would look at her son lying there,
at his face and wounds, but mainly at his wounds.
She felt her anger growing deep inside
and made that rage her weapon. She caught fire,
and, as if she were still queen, set her mind
on vengeance, concentrating all her thoughts
on how she could punish Polymestor.
Just as a lioness rages at the theft
of her unweaned cub and looks for footprints
of an adversary she cannot see,
so Hecuba, mixing her grief with rage,
recalled her courage, cast her age aside,
went to Polymestor, who had arranged
the dreadful murder, and asked to see him.
She said she wished to show him stores of gold
she had buried away, so he could give it
to her son. The Thracian king believed her,
and, driven by his usual love of gain,
came to her in private. He spoke to her
with slyly reassuring words:

“Come now,
Hecuba, do not wait. Give me that gift
kept hidden for your son. He’ll get all of it—
what you are giving now and gave before.
I swear by the gods.”

She watched him grimly,
as he uttered this deceitful promise,
and then her simmering rage boiled over.
Calling on her group of captive women
to seize hold of Polymestor, she sank
her fingers deep into his treasonous eyes
and gouged his eyeballs out. Rage made her strong.
She plunged her hands, stained with the murderer’s blood,
inside the holes and sucked out, not his eyes
(for they were gone) but what was in the sockets.

The Thracian folk, angry at the murder
of their king, started to attack the queen,
hurling stones and weapons. But Hecuba
chased after rocks they threw and snapped at them,
growling harshly. And when she set her jaws
and tried to speak, she barked. The place stills stands.
It's called Cynossema, the Bitch's Tomb,
a name derived from things that happened there.
For a long time Hecuba remembered
the ancient evils she had undergone
and still continued howling mournfully
through all the fields of Thrace. Her suffering
moved the Trojans and the enemy Greeks
and all the gods, as well—yes, all of them—
so even Juno, Jove's wife and sister,
affirmed that Hecuba had not deserved
to end her life that way.

HECUBA IS TRANSFORMED

PYTHAGORAS¹

There was a man living in Crotona
called Pythagoras, who was born in Samos
but had fled that island and its rulers
and gone into exile of his own free will,
because he hated tyranny. In his thoughts
he visited the gods, although they lived
far off in distant regions of the sky,
and what nature has denied to human sight
his mind could see. Once he had scrutinized
all things with his inner eye and studied
them with care, he made his knowledge public
and taught his silent audience, who heard
and were amazed by what he had to say
about how the vast universe began,
about how things are caused, what Nature is,
what gods are, where the snows originate,
where lightning comes from, whether Jupiter
or wind makes thunder when clouds split apart,
what forces make Earth shake, what laws control
the motions of the stars, and everything
that lies hidden away from human sight.

PYTHAGORAS

¹This passage begins at 15.93 in Ovid's complete poem.

He was the first one to complain about
wild beasts being killed and served for dinner,
the first to say things like the following
(judicious words, indeed, but not believed):

VEGETARIANISM

“O you mortal beings, stop corrupting
your own bodies with such defiling food.
We have grain, apples weighing branches down,
along with grapes which ripen on the vine.
You can use fire to cook sweet-tasting plants
and make them tender. There is no lack of milk
or honey smelling of the fragrant thyme.
Munificent Earth offers you her wealth,
producing feasts of harmless things to eat,
without the need for blood and slaughter.
Some beasts feed on meat, but many do not,
for horses, sheep, and cattle live on grass.
Those whose temperament is wild and savage—
Armenian tigers, raging lions, bears,
as well as wolves—delight in blood-soaked meat.
How wrong it is to feed our flesh with flesh,
to fatten up our gluttonous bodies
by eating bodies, to let one creature live
by bringing death to other living things.
Is it really true that, with all this wealth
the Earth, the best of mothers, offers us,
nothing pleases you unless your savage teeth
bring back the eating habits of the cyclops
and gnaw on pitiful wounds? Can you men
not satisfy the ravenous hunger pangs
inside your greedy and intemperate gut
unless you butcher other living things?
That earlier time, which we call Golden,
was happy with its harvests plucked from trees
and crops the earth produced. Men did not stain
their mouths with blood. Birds winged their way
in safety through the air, hares roamed unafraid
in open fields, and fish were not hauled up
on hooks because they were so credulous.
There was no treachery in anyone,
no fear of fraud. All things were filled with peace.
Then someone, whoever he was, acting
against the common good, was envious
of what the lions ate and stuffed raw meat

into his greedy stomach, thus opening
the road to crime. It may well be the case
that at the start men's gory swords grew hot
from slaying animals, but that's all right,
for I concede that men may kill those beasts
intent on killing them. That is no sin.
But while such creatures may be put to death,
it is not right for men to eat them, too.
From that time on the wickedness spread further.
The pig is thought to be the first wild beast
men felt deserved to die, for its broad snout
dug up the seeds and killed the hoped-for harvest.
And then men led the goat away to die
on Bacchus' altars, as a punishment
for chewing on his vines. And so the harm
these animals went through was their own fault.
But what have sheep done to deserve the same?
O you peaceful flocks, born to serve mankind,
you bear sweet milk for us in your full udders
and grow the wool from which we make soft clothes.
Your life serves us so well, more than your death.
What have oxen done, simple, harmless beasts,
without fraud or deceit, and born for toil?
That man is truly an ungrateful wretch,
unworthy of the gift of harvest grain,
who, after he has just relieved his ox
by freeing it from the heavy, curving plough,
can kill the creature who has tilled his fields,
hacking its worn down neck with his sharp axe,
when with its help he has so many times
worked hard to open up hard earth and sow
so many harvests. Even crimes like this
are not enough, for men involve the gods
in their own wickedness when they believe
that killing toiling cattle brings delight
to higher powers in heaven! A victim
of outstanding beauty, without a flaw
(its pleasing looks make it a sacrifice),
adorned with gold and garlands, is led out
before the altars. In its ignorance,
it hears the praying priest and sees him shake
the grain it helped produce across its forehead,
between the horns. And when the beast is struck,
its blood then stains the knives which earlier

it may have seen reflected in still water.
Next, while the animal is still alive,
its lungs are quickly ripped out from its chest,
and priests probe into them to ascertain
what gods may be intending . And after this,
(the human craving for forbidden food
has so much force) you dare to eat that meat,
you race of mortal men! Do not do this,
I beg you, and keep my admonitions
in your mind! Know and understand this well:
when you put the meat of slaughtered cattle
in your mouths, the food you are devouring
is flesh from those who labour on your land.

And since a god is urging me to speak,
I will follow, as I should, the deity
who moves my lips and tell you what I know
of Delphi and of very heaven itself.
The oracles of a majestic mind
I will unlock and sing of mighty things
left unexplored by previous intellects
and long concealed. It pleases me to move
among the lofty stars, and I delight
in leaving earth and this dull home behind
to ride up on the clouds and stand up there
on mighty Atlas' shoulders looking down
on men from far away, as they scurry
everywhere, with no good sense or reason,
and to unfurl for them the scroll of fate
and comfort them in their anxiety
and fear of death, by speaking words like these:

'O race of men, so stricken by your dread
of icy death, why do you fear the Styx,
and shadows of the dead and empty names,
the stuff of poets, the terrors of a world
which is not there? For you should not believe
these bodies of ours, whether destroyed
by funeral fires or ravages of age,
can suffer any further injuries.
For our souls do not die. Once they depart
an earlier dwelling place they always find
new homes, and, once received in there, live on.
I myself at the time of the Trojan war

IMMORTALITY OF THE SOUL

METEMPSYCHOSIS

(and I remember this) was Euphorbus,
a son of Panthous, whose chest was pierced
by a heavy spear from Menelaus,
a son of Atreus. Not long ago,
in Argos, that city ruled by Abas,
I recognized in Juno's holy shrine
the shield I used to hold on my left arm.

Each thing changes, but nothing ever dies.
The spirit wanders, roaming here and there,
and takes possession of a creature's limbs,
whatever body it desires, passing
from savage animals to human beings,
from human beings to beasts, but spirits
never are destroyed. Just as pliant wax
shaped in a new form does not stay the same
as what it was before or keep its shape,
and yet in essence does remain the same,
so, according to the principles I teach,
our souls always continue on unchanged,
passing into various body shapes.
And thus, in case your stomach's appetite
overwhelms your natural affections,
I warn you: stop this wicked butchery
which drives the souls of your own relatives
out of their homes. Do not feed blood with blood.'

And now that I am being transported
over the great sea and have spread my sails
and filled them with the wind, I will go on.

CHANGES IN NATURE

Nothing in the whole universe persists.
Matter is always changing. Particular things
arise as transitory images,
and even time itself, like a river,
keeps flowing on with never-ending motion.
For like the running stream, the fleeting hour
can never stop. As one wave drives another,
chasing the one in front, while being pursued
by one behind, in just that way time's moments
run ahead and follow and are always new.
For what was once ahead is left behind,
what did not exist comes into being,
and every passing instant must give way

to some fresh instant. You observe how night
completes its course and passes into day,
how the light of dawn replaces darkness.
The colour of the sky is not the same
at midnight with all weary things at rest
and when bright Lucifer on his white horse
emerges. Its colour changes once again
when the herald of the day, Aurora,
paints the world she must hand on to Phoebus.
The Sun god's shield is red when it is rising
from underneath the earth and red once more
when sinking down below, but at its height
the shield is brilliant white, because up there
the aether is more pure and far removed
from earth's contagion. And Moon at night
cannot remain the same, keeping her shape
the way she was before—if on the wane
tomorrow she will be smaller than today,
and if her orb is waxing, she will grow.

Besides, have you not noticed how the year
travels through a sequence of four seasons,
and in this imitates the way we live?
For early spring, with its new life, is tender
and full of juice, and very like a child.
Then the plants spring up, fresh but delicate,
not yet robust, and kindle farmers' hopes.
It is the time when all things are in flower.
In fertile fields the coloured blossoms dance,
but there is still no strength in any leaves.
As summer follows on the spring, the year,
now sturdier, displays his youthful strength.
No season is more vigorous or rich,
none glows with greater heat. Next Autumn comes,
all youthful passion spent, ripe and mellow,
in temperament halfway between our youth
and our old age, his temples flecked with gray.
And then comes aged, trembling wintertime,
with tottering steps. He has lost his hair,
or else the hair he has is now quite white.

SEASONS OF THE YEAR

And our bodies, too, are always changing.
They never stop. Tomorrow we will not be
what we have been or what we are today.

CHANGES IN OUR BODIES

There was a time when, early in our lives,
we lived inside our mother's womb as seeds,
mere hopes of mortal beings. Then Nature
put her skilful hands to work, refusing
to let our twisted bodies stay concealed
inside the belly of our swollen mother,
and sent us out into the empty air.
Brought into the light, the infant lies there
helpless, but soon, just like a quadruped,
he moves his limbs the way wild creatures do,
and gradually, with something for support
to help his trembling sinews, he stands up
on shaky knees, not yet quite firm enough.
Then he grows strong and swift, passing through
his youthful stage, and soldiers on through years
of middle age, then glides along the path
of his old age, where life declines, a time
which undermines and saps the strength he had
in earlier years. Old man Milon weeps
to see his arms, once strong and muscular,
like those on Hercules, hang limp and scrawny.
And Tyndarus' daughter Helen cries
to see an old crone's wrinkles in the glass
and wants to know why she's been ravished twice.
Devouring Time and you, hateful Old Age,
destroy all things. The teeth of passing years
gnaw everything to shreds, and gradually
you two swallow them all in drawn-out death.

Even those things we call the elements
do not remain the same. Focus your minds,
for I will show the changes they go through.
The everlasting universe contains
four substances which generate all things.
Two of these, earth and water, are heavy
and sink down from the force of their own weight.
The other two, air and fire (a substance
more rarefied than air) lack any weight.
If nothing holds them back, they try to move
up to the heights. Though these four elements
are distinct in space, all of them arise
from one another and resolve themselves
back into one another. When earth breaks down,
it liquefies and turns into clear water,

THE ELEMENTS

water, once it becomes less dense, changes
into wind and air, and when air loses weight
and turns into the subtlest element,
it flashes out as high aetherial fire.
Then they reverse their order and go back,
traversing the same stages as before—
fire grows more dense, turns into heavy air,
air changes into water, and water,
as it grows more dense, changes into earth.

And nothing retains its shape. For Nature,
who renews all things, keeps recreating
one form from another. And, believe me,
nothing in the entire universe can die,
but things do alter, changing how they look.
What men call 'being born' is just the start
of turning into something different
from what was there before, and 'dying'
means ceasing to remain in the same form.
Though this thing may perhaps change into that,
and that to this, the total sum of things
remains unchanged.

CHANGES IN NATURE

For my part, I believe
nothing retains the same appearance long.
Thus, the ages passed from Gold to Iron,
and many times the fortunes of a place
have been upended. I myself have seen
what once was solid earth turn into sea
and looked at land created from the waves.
We notice sea shells lying far from shore,
and on a mountain summit men have found
an ancient anchor. A flow of water
creates a valley where there was a plain,
floods have carried off and flattened mountains,
swampy areas have changed to arid sand,
and thirsty lands to stagnant marshy pools.
In one place nature opens up fresh springs,
while in another closing off their flow.
Rivers may burst forth, disturbed by tremors
deep inside the earth, or they may dry up
and disappear. Thus, the river Lycus,
once swallowed by a chasm in the earth,
is reborn from a new source and flows on

GEOLOGICAL CHANGES

far away. The mighty Erasinus
in one place is pulled down, flows underground,
and emerges once again in Argos.
They say the river Mysus grew ashamed
of his first source and his original banks
and now, as the Caïcus, flows elsewhere.
The Amenanus, too, in Sicily,
can sometimes flow so fast it churns up sand,
but then at other times its sources stop,
and it dries up. The river Anigrus,
which in earlier days was fit to drink,
now flows with water you would never touch,
not since the time the centaurs used that stream
to wash the wounds inflicted by the bow
and club of Hercules (unless, of course,
we stop believing all tales poets tell).
Is it not true the river Hypanis,
born in the Scythian hills, once tasted sweet,
but has been ruined now with acrid salt?
Antissa, Pharos, and Phoenician Tyre
at one time were surrounded by the sea.
None of these cities is an island now.
Inhabitants of Leucas long ago
worked in fields connected to the mainland.
The place is now encircled by the sea.
Zancle, too, they say, was linked to Italy,
until the sea destroyed the boundary
and waves flowed in to carry off the land.
If you look now for Helice and Buris,
once Achaean cities, you will find them
buried in the waves, and sailors, even now,
like to point out these inundated towns
with walls beneath the sea.

Near Troezen,
where Pittheus was king, there is a mound,
steep and bare of trees, which some time ago
was the most level part of the whole plain.
Now it is a hill. How this came to be
is a strange tale. Fierce and powerful winds
shut up in hidden caverns wished to find
some outlet for their gales and vainly fought
to enjoy the open sky. But their blasts
had no way out, for in their prison cell

there were no cracks at all. And so those winds
put pressure on the ground and made it swell,
the way our human breath inflates a bladder
or the skin of a horned goat. After that,
the swelling stayed and, as the years went by,
it hardened, so it looks like a steep hill.

Though many more examples of such things
occur to me from what I have been told
or learned about myself, I will list here
just one or two. Think of water. Does it not
take on and generate new forms, as well?
At noon the waters of horned Ammon's spring
are freezing cold, but when Sun is rising
or declining they grow warm. People say
the Athamanians set fire to wood
by pouring water from this spring on it
when Moon has shrunk down to her smallest size.
The Cicones live by a stream whose water,
once drunk, turns inner organs into stone
and, when it touches things, spreads over them
a layer of marble. The Crathis river
and the Sybaris (which is close to here,
near our own lands) can change a person's hair
and make it look like amber or like gold.
Even more amazing are those rivers
capable of changing not just bodies
but even minds, as well. Who has not heard
of Salmacis, with its disgusting pools,
or of those lakes in Ethiopia
where anyone who drinks becomes insane
or falls into a deep and wondrous sleep?
Whoever drinks from the Clitorian spring
avoids all wine and in his sober state
enjoys pure water. This may well take place
because there is some power in the water
which works against the warm effects of wine.
Those who live there give another reason—
after Melampus, Amythaon's son,
had with his spells and herbal potions saved
Proetus' raving daughters from the Furies,
he threw the medicines which purged their minds
into the spring, and that is why its waters
generate a strong distaste for wine.

PROPERTIES OF WATER

The flowing stream of the Lyncestius
has an opposite effect. Whoever
swallows some of it, even a small amount,
stumbles around, as if he had been drinking
unmixed wine. Arcadia has a place
(Pheneus was its name in earlier days)
whose waters are mistrusted, for they have
two different effects. During the night
you must beware, for then a drink does harm,
but in the day its water is quite safe.
Thus, various lakes and rivers can possess
quite different properties.

Ortygia,
once a floating island, is now fixed in place.
Men on the Argo feared those clashing rocks,
the Symplegades, and the spray tossed up
by crashing waves. And now they do not move,
but stand fixed in place, defying the winds.

Mount Aetna, glowing with its furnaces
of blazing sulphur, will not always burn
and was not always burning in the past.¹
For if Earth is a living animal
with many passages that breathe out flames,
then, every time she moves, she can remake
those breathing holes. She can seal some up
and open others. Or if rapid winds
imprisoned in deep caves hurl rocks together
with matter which contains the seeds of flame,
and friction causes Aetna to catch fire,
the caves will cool off once the winds calm down.
Or if the fires are blazing bitumen
and yellow sulphur burning with less smoke,
surely, after many ages have gone by,
that rich supply of food the earth provides
will be used up and it will have no fuel
to feed the flames. Without the nourishment
their greedy nature craves, the flames will starve,
and, as they die, will starve Mount Aetna's fire.
They say that in Pallene, in those lands
beyond the northern winds, there are some men
who cover their skin with downy feathers

MOUNT AETNA

¹Mount Aetna (or Etna) is an active volcano in Sicily.

by plunging in Minerva's pool nine times.
As far as I'm concerned, this is not true,
but people claim that Scythian women
have spells to do this, too, by sprinkling limbs
with magic potions.

But if what you believe
relies on what experience can prove,
you must have seen that corpses when they rot,
because of time or melting heat, are changed
to tiny animals. We know full well
that if you take a sacrificial bull
and bury the tossed-out carcass in a ditch,
from every portion of the putrid entrails
flower-sipping bees will rise. And these bees,
just like the animal from which they spring,
live in the fields, love toil, and work with hope.
A war horse buried in the ground becomes
a source of hornets, and if you remove
a land crab's hollow claws and put the rest
below the ground, then from that buried part
a scorpion will emerge and threaten you
with its hooked tail. As farmers have observed,
those grubs which cover leaves in country fields
with their white thread change into butterflies,
their shape transformed to emblems of the dead.
And mud contains the seeds that generate
green frogs, which, when they first appear, lack feet.
Soon it gives them legs well formed for swimming
and makes the back ones longer than in front,
adapting them to jump huge distances.
When she gives birth to young, a mother bear
does not produce a cub but a mere lump
of living flesh, barely alive. But then,
by licking it, she gives that lump its limbs
and turns it into something with a shape
just like her own. And have you not observed
how grubs from honey bees which lie contained
in their hexagonal cells have bodies
but no limbs and how their legs come later
and then, even later still, their wings?
Who could imagine, if he did not know,
that Juno's bird, whose tail plumes carry stars,
and Jupiter's eagle with the lightning bolt,

SPONTANEOUS GENERATION

and Venus' doves, and every race of birds
come into being from inside an egg?¹
Some people claim that when the human spine
is buried in a tomb and rots, its marrow
is transformed into a snake.

The elements

THE PHOENIX

of all these animals originate
from other species. But there is one bird
which reproduces and renews itself
all on its own. Those in Assyria
call it the phoenix. It does not live on grain
or grasses, but eats drops of frankincense
and balsam sap. And when this bird has lived
five centuries, it builds itself a nest
in a swaying palm tree, in the branches
at the very top, using its chaste beak
and claws. Then, after it has lined the nest
with bits of cassia, smooth ears of nard,
pieces of cinnamon, and yellow myrrh,
it sits down on the top and ends its life
in the perfumed air. And, so people say,
from the father's body a small phoenix
is reborn, destined to remain alive
for just as many years. When this bird's age
has made it strong enough to bear the weight,
it lifts the heavy nest from the high branches
and piously removes its father's tomb
and its own cradle, flying through the air
towards the city of the Sun, and there,
inside the temple of Hyperion,
it puts it down before the sacred doors.

If there is anything astonishing
in these strange events, we might well wonder
how hyenas can alternate their sex,
with a female who has just been mounted
by a male now becoming male herself.
Then, too, there is an animal which feeds
on winds and air. When it touches something
it at once takes on that object's colour.
Conquered India once gave its lynxes

STRANGE ANIMALS

¹Juno's bird is the peacock.

to Bacchus, god of the grape-bearing vine.
Every time these beasts discharge their bladders,
so men report, the liquid turns to stone
which hardens from its contact with the air.
And coral, which, while underneath the waves,
remains a tender plant, grows hard, as well,
in just this way, when it is touched by air.

The day will end and Phoebus' weary horses
will plunge into the sea before my words
can mention all those things that have been changed
into new forms. So with revolving time
we see some nations growing powerful
and others in decline. Troy, for instance,
which was so great in wealth and citizens
and for ten years could squander so much blood,
is now a humble ruin. Ancient stones
are all it has to show, and all its wealth
lies in ancestral tombs. And Sparta, too,
was famous once, great Mycenae flourished,
as did Athens, king Cecrops' citadel,
and Amphion's city, Thebes. But Sparta now
consists of worthless land, and proud Mycenae
has collapsed. What is Oedipus' Thebes
except a story? And Pandion's Athens—
what remains of that except its name?

CIVILIZATIONS

Today the story goes Dardanian Rome
is growing and, close beside the Tiber,
which rises in the Apennines, building
an immense foundation to provide support
for mighty things. And with this kind of growth
the city's shape is changing. The day will come
when Rome will be the head of the whole world!
That, so people say, is what the seers predict,
and those oracles which foretell our fate.
As I remember, when the Trojan state
was facing ruin and Aeneas was in tears,
anxious about the safety of his race,
Helenus, a son of Priam, said to him:

ROME'S DESTINY

'Child of Venus, if you will take good note
of what I prophesy, while you are safe
Troy will not fall completely! Fire and sword

will offer you a path, and you will go,
taking with you our plundered Pergamum,
until you reach a foreign place kinder
to you than your own native land of Troy.
Even now I see a city destined
for Phrygian posterity, a town
so mighty nothing like it now exists
or will exist, or has been seen before,
in earlier years. Through long centuries
other leading men will make it powerful,
but one man born from blood of Iulus
will make that city mistress of the world.
And when that leader's time on earth is done,
aetherial realms will welcome him with joy
and heaven will be his final dwelling place.'

My mind recalls how Helenus prophesied
these matters to Aeneas, who carried
ancestral gods away from Troy. My heart
rejoices that city walls are rising
for his posterity, and I am pleased
the Greek defeat of Troy has led to this,
such a benefit to Trojans.

But now,
I must not wander too far off my course
and let my horses lose sight of the goal.
The heavens and everything below them
change their form. So does the earth, as well,
and all things it contains. We mortals, too,
part of the universe, are not mere flesh,
but souls with wings, and thus we can create
a home inside the bodies of wild beasts
or settle in the hearts of our own cattle.
And therefore, we should allow those bodies
which could well contain the souls of parents,
brothers, or others linked to us somehow,
or human beings, at least, to rest safe
and undisturbed and not cram our stomachs
with food fit for Thyestes' dinner feast.¹
How those men get used to evil actions

¹ Atrous, father of Agamemnon, invited his brother, Thyestes, to a banquet of reconciliation, where he served Thyestes the cooked flesh of his own children.

and in their impiety prepare themselves
for spilling human blood, when with their knives
they slit a young calf's throat and, quite unmoved,
hear its mournful bleats, or slaughter a young goat,
which cries out like a child, or feed on birds
which they themselves have fed. When they do this,
how close are they to acting out real crimes?
Where do such actions lead?

Let oxen plough
or perish from old age. Let sheep provide
protection from the freezing northern winds,
let well-fed she goats offer us their udders
for our hands to milk. Throw your nets away,
your traps and snares and your deceptive tricks.
Do not use twigs and lime to fool the birds,
or scare deer into nets with feathered rope,
or hide barbed hooks inside deceiving bait.
Destroy what injures you, but even then
do nothing more than kill. Make sure your mouths
abstain from blood and eat more wholesome food!"

OVID'S ENVOI¹

My task is now complete. Here I end my work,
which neither Jupiter's rage, nor fire, nor sword,
nor gnawing time can ever wipe away.
Let that day which brings my tenuous life
to its allotted end come when it will,
its power will only kill my body.
The finer part of me will be borne up,
as an immortal, beyond the lofty stars,
and my name will never be forgotten.
Wherever the power of Rome extends
throughout the nations it has overcome,
I will be read. Men will celebrate my fame
for all the ages, and, if there is truth
in poet's prophecies, I will live on.

¹This passage is Ovid's conclusion to the entire poem.

